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EYE

THE MANY LIVES OF A WEAVE

Laila Tyabji traces the hands, histories and chance encounters behind the country's handloom revival

SCREEN

A new Netflix series revisits Kargil War through the eyes of young pilots



Happening today

● **ASSAM GOVERNMENT** will begin a door-to-door assessment of flood damage in the four worst-hit districts of the state. It will disburse compensation to those affected based on this survey.

● **THE HAR GHAR TIRANGA** Campaign 2026 begins. Organised under the Ministry of Culture, this year's initiative coincides with Independence Day and is dedicated to the spirit of Vande Mataram.

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POLITICS PAGE 6

**TAMIL NADU MPs SEEK PERMANENT FREEZE ON LOK SABHA SEATS**

PLAN TO MARCH TOWARDS ASSEMBLY TOMORROW

Jharkhand student protest: Round 2 of talks with govt fails to end deadlock

Protesters say demands will be taken to CM, no call to withdraw agitation yet

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 8

THE SECOND round of talks between the Jharkhand government and student representatives protesting alleged irregularities in government recruitment examinations ended without a breakthrough on Saturday, prolonging a conflict that the state has so far struggled to resolve.

The students, however, said the government had listened to their demands and that they would wait for the issues to be taken up with Chief Minister Hemant Soren before deciding whether to withdraw their

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

Stalled govt jobs, cases stuck in court, exam delays: What's behind the Ranchi fast, protest

**Unne Habiba, 27****Rupesh Kumar Pal, 30****Savita Kumari, 28****Rahul Kranti, 40****Shubham Tigga**
Ranchi, August 8

WHEN 40-YEAR-OLD Rahul Kranti walked into the protest site, he said he was carrying nearly a decade of frustration with Jharkhand's recruitment

system. On Friday, he was among the candidates on an indefinite hunger strike, saying repeated examinations, court battles and delayed recruitments had left him with little choice but to take to the streets. Like Kranti, those on the

stage symbolise the grievances that have simmered among the state's job aspirants over decades. From a woman attending her first-ever protest to a man who has spent countless hours in court, *The Indian Express*

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

NO CHARGE ON CONSUMER, PERSON-TO-PERSON PAYMENTS

UPI free for citizens, merchants may face 'nominal' fee: Govt

The charges for merchants, if and when applied, will be lower than that for debit or credit cards: Ministry

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 8

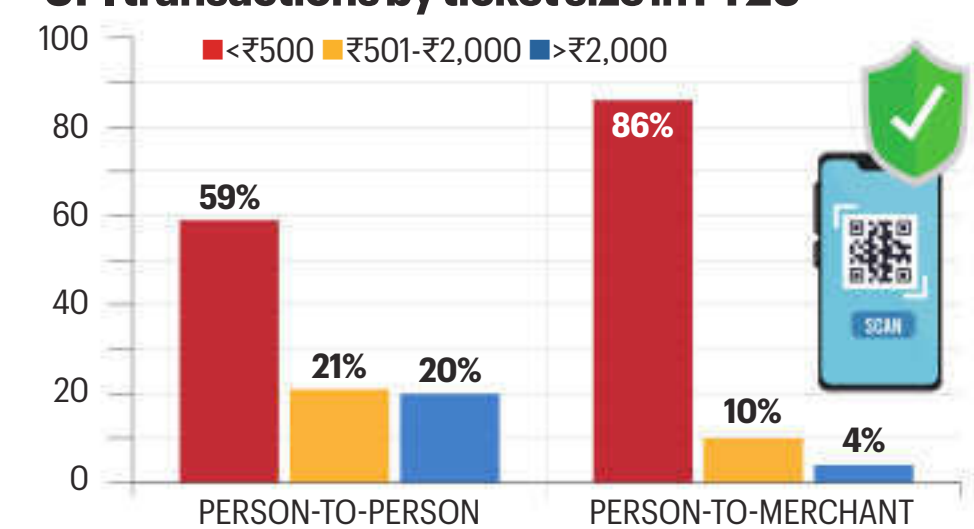
ALLAYING USER concerns, the Ministry of Finance "categorically" stated Saturday that consumers making UPI payments will not face any transaction charges, and all person-to-person transactions will continue to be free of charge.

It, however, said as and when MDR (Merchant Discount Rate) charges are introduced, they will apply at a nominal rate only above a certain threshold, and on a limited set of merchant transactions. "It would be far lower than debit or credit card MDRs," the statement said.

MDR is a fee levied on merchants by banks to help meet costs related to processing of transactions, settlement and infrastructure. Credit cards face

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

UPI transactions by ticket size in FY26



SOURCE: MINISTRY OF FINANCE

Why charge? Because smooth UPI payments cost Rs 20,000 cr a year

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 8

SHOPPING HAS never been easier or cheaper since the Unified Interface Payments, launched in 2016, democratised finance and QR codes replaced complex bank details for transactions big and small. Today, consumers don't pay for it, nor do merchants.

The costs are being paid for by banks and other financial system players, and estimates suggest these to be about Rs 20,000 crore a year now.

Banks expected to get compensated after all this when the Lok Sabha passed The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 on Thursday.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM to students: Question things accepted without thought, find solutions



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi (left) at IIT Delhi, Saturday. PTI

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi told students Saturday to "question the things that are accepted without any thought" but not stop there and "have the courage to find their solutions" as well.

Speaking at the 57th convocation ceremony of IIT Delhi,

Modi said, "I have observed the journeys of many IIT alumni. The reason for their success was not just that they gave the right answers. The reason for their success was that they identified those questions which the world had stopped considering as questions. They found solutions to those problems with which others had

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Your parents could not face their fears, you have: Rahul at Prayagraj meet



Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi interacts with students during the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' programme in Prayagraj, Saturday. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

Manish Sahu
Prayagraj, August 8

IN HIS first student outreach event after the Jantar Mantar protest concluded in Delhi, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi invoked "dard (pain), data and daulat (wealth)" to attack the BJP and RSS. Lauding youths for "fighting against the system", he said he would always

stand with them.

Addressing a 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' programme in Prayagraj, Gandhi said: "You are the power and pride of India. When I say this, I am talking about every Indian citizen."

Gandhi spoke before a large gathering, of mostly students and competitive exam aspirants, including those who had

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

THE WORLD PAGE 12

**DEAL WITH OMAN CLOSE, SAYS IRAN**

INSIDE PAGES 6, 8

**IN BENGAL, BJP CRACKS DOWN ON 325 WORKERS OVER EXTORTION****MANIPUR GOVT REOPENS NATIONAL HIGHWAYS AFTER THREE YEARS**

No drop-down options, caste census format to be open-ended

Enumerators to record caste stated by people, will not try to classify surnames, sub-castes into broader caste categories

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 8

THE REGISTRAR General of India (RGI) has decided to use an "open-ended question on caste" rather than a drop-down menu of castes for the caste census to be conducted alongside the population enumer-

ation phase of the Census.

This format is likely to produce results similar to the 2011 exercise when the Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) was conducted.

Sources in the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) said enumerators will simply ask people to state their caste and record the

answer verbatim, without attempting to classify surnames, sub-castes or other responses into broader caste categories.

Population enumeration, along with the caste census, will be conducted across the country in February next year. However, in hilly and snow-bound areas,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

FROM STEALING A CHAIR TO MEETING HIS FUTURE WIFE AT A BAR, A JAPANESE MAN'S INDIA ADVENTURE

He was jailed in Bengaluru, fought police from Japan — and found love along the way

Kiran Parashar
Bengaluru, August 8

THE AMOUNT was modest: Rs 75,000.

For Hirotoshi Tanaka, the payment represented something bigger. Five-and-a-half years after the Japanese national alleged he had been arrested, jailed, and asked to pay bribes by a Bengaluru Police officer, the Karnataka government compensated

him in June following a human rights commission inquiry.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* from his hometown of Yaizu in Japan's Shizuoka prefecture, the 36-year-old said, "I knew nothing about the police system or the courts. My English is not particularly strong, and I don't understand Kannada at all... Even so, I was able to win the case against the police."

Tanaka arrived in Benge-



Hirotoshi Tanaka, 36, who had arrived in India in October 2019, was deported in April 2021

luru in October 2019. A psychology graduate, he enrolled at an academy in RT Nagar to learn English and hoped to spend time exploring the city.

But his plans began to unravel.

Tanaka claimed that problems at the academy surfaced within two weeks of his joining, with classes allegedly being cancelled without explanation. The simmering tension eventually boiled over, said Tanaka,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Round 2 of talks

hunger strike.

The controversy began soon after the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) declared the preliminary examination results of the 14th Combined Civil Services Examination on July 2. The Commission shortlisted 2,204 candidates against 103 vacancies, but allegations of irregularities emerged soon after. Around 3.5 lakh people took the exam.

At the heart of the protest, which comes against the backdrop of the developments at New Delhi's Jantar Mantar, are allegations of paper leaks in the exam. The Soren government has tried to act quickly – 19 people have been arrested, and the Chief Minister has said they stand with the youth – but the protests have shown no signs of slowing.

On Saturday, an eight-member delegation of the JPSC-JSSC Abhyarthi Nyay Manch left the protest site at Ranchi's Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium and reached a guesthouse in Morabadi around 10:30 am for the meeting. The talks began around 11:30 am.

The delegation reiterated the demands already put forward by another platform that has emerged during the protests, the JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch, which held talks with the government on Friday night. Saturday's meeting also saw some additional demands concerning candidates from different recruitment tests, including issues related to the TGT examination and other teacher recruitment examinations.

UPI free for citizens

an MDR of 1-3% of transaction value while it is up to 0.9% for debit cards.

The Finance Ministry's statement comes amid a raging debate over a potential fee on UPI payments after the government introduced The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in Parliament. Passed by the Lok Sabha on Thursday, the Bill proposes changes to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, which open the door for banks and payment system providers to charge fees on UPI and RuPay debit card payments.

The Bill led to fears that merchants which may face MDR charges in the future will pass on the cost to consumers. On Friday, the Payments Council of India (PCI) had clarified that consumers will not have to pay extra while making UPI transactions to large merchants.

In its statement, the Finance Ministry said the amendment to the taxation Bill has been misinterpreted "as a move to impose charges on ordinary users".

Two days after the Bill was introduced, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Thursday said in a post on social media platform X that the cost of the MDR "will inevitably be borne by ordinary people who will now have to pay to use UPI transactions".

Responding to his post, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had said the UPI and Services Steering Committee, headed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), is yet to make a decision. In its statement, the Finance

subsidising UPI payments of up to Rs 2,000 made to only small merchants through its 'Incentive scheme for promotion of RuPay Debit Cards and low-value BHIM-UPI transactions (P2M)'. The incentive offered is capped at 0.15% of the transaction value and is shared between banks, payment service providers and third-party app providers.

The Centre paid out Rs 8,730 crore under the incentive scheme from 2021-22 to 2024-25. However, this was only 11% of the cost incurred by the payment industry, according to a report by the Standing Committee on Finance.

Congress' Jairam Ramesh had also expressed concerns in his August 6 post that the amendment follows a report by the US Trade Representative criticising UPI and RuPay "for being free and accuses them of having driven out American payment platforms like Visa and MasterCard".

The Finance Ministry said any suggestion that "external influences may be driving policy changes" is "unfounded, completely false and misleading".

The USTR, in its National Trade Estimate Report for 2026, had said the US had continued to raise concerns "relating to informal and formal policies with respect to electronic payments services that appear to favour Indian domestic suppliers over foreign suppliers, creating a non-level playing field". Specifically, it noted that US electronic payment services suppliers were unable to participate in the UPI ecosystem, including credit transactions on UPI, like RuPay could.

It also mentioned the 30%

Caste census format

the exercise will begin from September 1 this year to avoid difficulties during the winter months.

"It has been finally decided that no dropdown menu or any other means will be used for caste enumeration. People have to just state their caste and the same will be recorded as it is. Enumerators are not supposed to categorise any surname or sub-caste in a caste category. Things will be recorded verbatim," a senior MHA official said.

The decision comes after the RGI considered using a dropdown menu drawing from the Central and State lists of castes, particularly for Other Backward Classes (OBCs). The Census already uses a drop-down menu for recording notified Scheduled Caste (SC) and Scheduled Tribe (ST) communities.

The "open-ended question on caste" method was exactly how the 2011 Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) was conducted. The exercise failed to produce usable caste data largely because of poor data quality, the absence of a standardized caste registry and flaws in operational design. Since respondents could self-report caste names without verification, the exercise generated an administrative nightmare.

The final dataset contained nearly 46.7 lakh distinct caste names, compared with the 4,147 castes recorded in the last comprehensive caste census in 1931. The Union government eventually withheld the raw caste data.

"Yes, it is true that an open-ended question will likely produce 2011-like results. But what can we do? We have always

Why charge

The Bill proposed changes to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, that could allow banks and payment system providers to charge fees on UPI and RuPay debit card payments.

These fees, called the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), would have to be paid by the seller, not buyers. Using UPI will remain free and no MDR will be applicable on money transferred from one person to another, or P2P transactions.

Other payment mechanisms too carry costs. The Reserve Bank of India, for instance, spends around Rs 5,000 crore a year to print currency notes. Cards are paid for by the issuer and costs are recovered from the user – public sector banks charged as much as Rs 7,564 crore for annual maintenance of debit cards in 2025-26, up from

Rs 3,905 crore in 2021-22.

The MDR, that merchants may be charged, would help cover a variety of payment infra costs: mobile app development, transaction authorisation, reconciliation, and settlement, cybersecurity, cloud storage, disaster recovery, fraud detection, dispute handling, continuous network monitoring, and regulatory reporting, among others.

While there are no official figures on the costs that facilitate smooth UPI payments, Mehul Mistry, Senior V-P (Customer success, Strategy and Growth), Zeta, a banking technology company, said industry estimates suggest the annual cost of operating UPI and RuPay debit card infrastructure "could be at least Rs 10,000 crore". His estimate may be conservative.

A March report by the Standing Committee on Finance said the government's subsidy payout on RuPay debit card and person-to-merchant UPI transac-

Rahul

travelled from outside Prayagraj, on a ground that was waterlogged at many places and covered with muddy patches. Ahead of the meeting, JCB machines were used to put limestone and sand at waterlogged spots and a road roller was also used to level the ground.

Without mentioning Jantar Mantar or Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as Union Education Minister, Gandhi lauded the fact that youths had held several protests. It was a sign that young people were beginning to challenge the status quo, he said.

"...iss andhere mein aap logon ne light jala di. Aapne woh kiya jo aapke mata-pita nahin kar paye. Woh apne dar ka saamna nahin kar paye, magar Hindustan ke student aur yuvak ne dar ka saamna kiya... aur desh ko badal diya (In this darkness, you lit a light. You did what your parents could not do. They could not face their fears, but Hindustan's youth and students did... and changed the country)."

Urging them to continue "fighting for your rights", he said: "Mein iss mein aapke saath khada hoon, khada raheonga (I stand with you in this fight, and I will continue to stand with you)."

One of the big protests leading up to Jantar Mantar was held at Prayagraj, with students hitting the streets on May 29 over two UP recruitment exams.

Dressed in a pink shirt unlike his usual white or black T-shirt, Gandhi told an enthusiastic crowd that said youths in India were "unparalleled", despite all the talk about America, China and Russia. "India has the youth and the maximum data in the world. Youth plus data equals the 21st-century economy," he said.

However, Gandhi said, while Artificial Intelligence

PM at IIT Delhi

already compromised."

"Therefore, maintain curiosity in life, keep the learning instinct alive, and remain aware. Examine and question the things that are accepted without any thought. But do not stop at just asking questions. Have the courage to find their solutions as well. This very mindset will create your distinct identity."

He told the graduating students that "campus life and life outside the campus are vastly different". The IIT exam, he said, has a set syllabus, but "the exam of life is entirely out of syllabus... life moves quite differently. There is neither a set course nor any question paper. Often, nobody even tells you what the real question was. You have to identify that question all on your own."

He said life's challenges need to be broken down into manageable components, much like solving complex laboratory simulations. "If difficulties inevitably come in life, entirely new opportunities will also emerge. You just have to remain alert."

Modi urged students to help build a self-reliant and developed India. Pointing to the rapid pace of technological change and the emergence of new sectors, he said India's youth would have opportunities spanning semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space technology, quantum computing, critical minerals, electric mobility and energy storage.

Referring to apprehensions that some had raised on India's ability to establish domestic production of semiconductors, he said, "Today, production has begun at the first semiconductor unit. I firmly believe that from chips to ships, everything will be made here by your hands".

He said those who adapt to

Japan

and he ended up punching the academy head. Police booked him under charges of voluntarily causing hurt and criminal intimidation and he was arrested on November 23, 2019.

His bail was finally granted and he walked out on December 11, 2019. The following day, he went to RT Nagar police station to collect his belongings.

By then, he had little money left. Seeing his plight, he said a constable lent him Rs 1,500. But another officer, B Hanumantharayappa, then a sub-inspector, allegedly demanded a bribe. After some negotiation, Tanaka claimed he paid Rs 5,500.

He alleged Hanumantharayappa demanded another Rs 3,000 to close the case. Tanaka decided he would not let the alleged bribe demands go unchallenged.

Towards the end of March, during the Covid-19 pandemic, his visa expired. Said Tanaka, "I

was granted a visa extension till July 2020 but could not leave India till my case remained pending."

Tanaka had only one way out: get the case against him withdrawn. He filed a criminal petition.

The coaching centre head agreed to resolve the dispute, following which the Karnataka HC, on November 2, 2020, halted criminal proceedings and quashed the FIR. Tanaka was now free to leave India, but he "couldn't forget" what he faced.

In December of that year, he filed a complaint against Hanumantharayappa, alleging bribery and harassment before the Karnataka State Human Rights Commission. "I have respect for the police community across the globe as my father is also a police officer. But not at the cost of my self-respect," he said.

There was, however, a problem: Tanaka was running out of time in India. The Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO) sent him a letter, asking him to leave before February 28, 2021. So he decided to do something drastic to halt his deportation.

Around 1 am, on February 27, he arrived at the RT Nagar police station. That's when he noticed the plastic chairs at the reception desk of the ACP office. "On my phone, I looked up the offence of theft under the Indian Penal Code (the law then in force)... and found it was a non-bailable offence... Committing theft would inevitably lead to my arrest, so I decided to take the chair..." he recalled.

He posted selfies with the chair on X and the post went viral. He expected to be arrested. But nothing happened.

The police did not file a case against him, treating the incident – and him – as a "headache".

On March 3, 2021, Tanaka was summoned by the FRRO. In late April 2021, he was deported.

But he was not done with the case. Tanaka engaged Bengaluru-based advocate Rohan Kothari to represent him before the Karnataka SHRC, which on May 9, 2022, recommended that the

state pay him Rs 75,000 as compensation, and consider disciplinary action and recovery of the amount from Hanumantharayappa.

Hanumantharayappa, now 65, denied ever asking for a bribe. "In my 35 years and four months of service, this was the first time that a department inquiry was initiated against me," he told *The Indian Express*, adding that he has contested the human rights panel judgment in the Karnataka HC.

Amid all that he went through in Bengaluru, Tanaka found something worthwhile – his future wife. She was from the Northeast and they first met at a bar he frequented. "She stood with me during tough times... she was the one who encouraged me to file a petition in court," he said.

In 2025, they got married. His wife is back in Bengaluru while her spouse visa for Japan is being processed. There's one thing Tanaka wants from India. "I wish to visit my wife's hometown and meet her family..."

Unlike several others, her case is not in court. "The Constitution gives me the right to protest. This is my power," she said.

Rupesh Kumar Pal, a 30-year-old from Garhwa, is among the students who have spent years preparing for government jobs. He graduated with a degree in English in 2018 and completed a B.Ed. in 2020. He then obtained a Master's in English in 2022, followed by another in Political Science in 2024.

Alongside his studies, he was preparing for government recruitment examinations. But it was the JSSC CGL recruitment that drew him into a legal battle with the recruitment system.

The JSSC CGL examination advertised in 2016 was held in 2024 after repeated delays over allegations of irregularities. Pal said he scored around 83 per cent, but his result was not de-

clared. He claimed candidates who scored lower were eventually selected.

He moved Jharkhand HC in September 2025 along with more than 100 candidates.

The examination itself had already been at the centre of controversy. "After the 2024 examination, everyone alleged that the paper had been leaked. Students approached the commission and submitted material and evidence. The commission initially denied the allegation," he said.

After an FIR was filed in Ranchi, students approached the court, leading to the formation of an SIT. "The first CID team found evidence supporting the allegation," he claimed.

He further alleged that late last year, the government rejected the findings of the first investigation team and constituted another team whose conclusions

Behind Ranchi protest

spoke to those on hunger strike to understand the circumstances that brought them here.

Kranti completed his post-graduate degree in Geography in 2010 and later earned a Post-graduate Diploma in Rural Development from IGNOU, along with a B.Ed, hoping that multiple qualifications would improve his chances of securing a government teaching job.

A father of a six-year-old girl, Kranti measures his life between government exams. In 2016, he cleared the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission's Trained Graduate Teacher (TGT) examination. "I scored 20 marks more than the last selected candidate in the OBC category, yet never received an appointment," he said.

ation pushed him beyond the prescribed age limit, Kranti became the lead petitioner in a HC case seeking age relaxation for candidates. This February, the court ruled in favour of 264 petitioners, including Kranti.

"It allowed us to appear in the 14th JPSC examination. But the current developments (in JPSC recruitment) have shattered those dreams, and all my hopes are ending," he said.

On the same stage where protesters have gathered, 27-year-old Unne Habiba from Bokaro held a copy of the Constitution in her hand. She has been at the protest since July 29 and is surviving on water during her hunger strike, now in its fifth day.

She studied in Bokaro, completing a BA in English in 2019. In 2017, while in her first year of college, she began preparing for the Panchayat Secretary recruit-



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NO WARNING FOR TODAY; LIGHT TO MODERATE SHOWERS EXPECTED AT MANY PLACES

Delhi crosses monthly August rainfall in first 8 days of month



Rain lashes Ring Road near Raj Ghat in New Delhi on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

WITH DAYS of intense rain, Delhi has crossed its average August rainfall in just the first eight days of the month.

The cumulative rainfall for August was recorded at 230.1 mm until 8.30 pm on Saturday at Safdarjung, the Capital's base station. The month's long-period average is 226.8 mm, India Meteorological Department (IMD) data shows.

The showers are expected to ease on Sunday, with the IMD forecasting light to moderate rain at many places and no weather-related impact warning for the day.

The heavy spell on Saturday added to an unusually wet August. At Palam, 104.6 mm of rain was recorded in the 24 hours ending at 8.30 am -- the highest 24-hour rainfall recorded in the area in August since at least 2011. The rainfall has amounted to more than half of Palam's average rainfall for the entire month -- 1979 mm.

Palam's all-time August 24-hour rainfall record is 183.6 mm, recorded in 1967, as per IMD.

Rainfall had been particularly intense in south and central Delhi, with the IMD issuing red alerts through the day for the region.

Pushp Vihar recorded 57 mm during the day, while several other parts of the city received substantial rainfall.

Across the Capital, Ayana-gar recorded the highest 24-hour rainfall at 115 mm, ending at 8.30 am on Saturday. It was followed by Palam (104.6 mm), Najafgarh (103.5 mm), Safdarjung (98.7 mm), Ridge (89.8 mm), Lodi Road (86.8 mm), Pusa (81.5 mm), Mayur Vihar (69.5 mm) and Rajghat (62.6 mm).

Neighbouring Gurgaon, meanwhile, recorded 96.5 mm in the 24 hours until 8.30 am on Saturday, while Noida received 28.5 mm of rain and Ghaziabad 33 mm during the same period.

Traffic snarls were reported at several stretches across the Capital, with heavy congestion at the Kalindi Kunj border, ITO, Press Enclave Marg, Geetanjali Marg and Mehrauli-Badarpur



Neighbouring Gurgaon recorded 96.5 mm in the 24 hours until 8.30 am on Saturday, while Noida received 28.5 mm of rain and Ghaziabad 33 mm during the same period

Road. Traffic was also affected in parts of East Delhi, including stretches of GT Road.

Safdarjung recorded a maximum temperature of 32.8 degrees Celsius, 1.4 degrees below the normal and 5.3 degrees higher than the day before. The minimum temperature was logged at 24.7 degrees Celsius, 2.2 degrees below the normal and marking a 0.9-degree decrease from a day before.

Meanwhile, the 24-hour average air quality index (AQI) of Delhi remained in the 'Satisfactory' category at 63 on Saturday, same as the day before, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board.

For Sunday, the IMD has forecast generally cloudy skies with one or two spells of very light to light rain at many places, with the possibility of moderate rain at a few places towards night.

The maximum temperature is expected to be in the 33-35°C range, while the minimum is likely to remain between 23°C and 25°C.

Very light to light rain has been forecast from Monday to Thursday, with the possibility of one or two spells on each day.



(From top) Heavy rain at Delhi, Noida and Gurgaon on Saturday.

PRAVEEN KHANNA, GAJENDRA YADAV & PTI

• Skywatch



Forecast: August 9, 2026

Generally cloudy sky. Very light to light rain

MAX: 30-32

2.2°C below normal

MIN: 22-24

2.9°C below normal

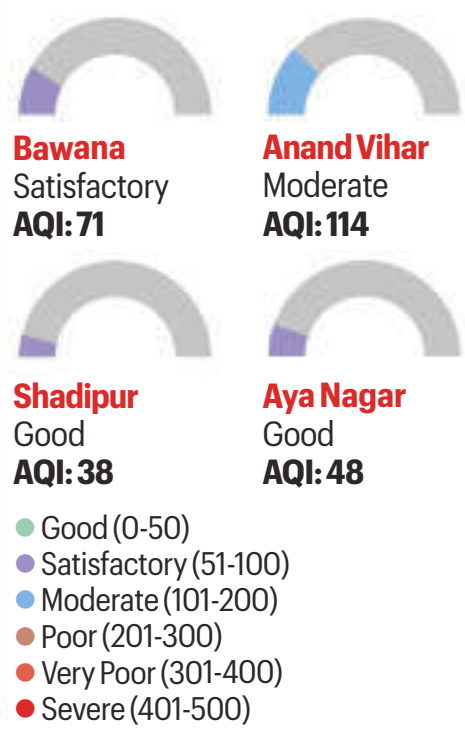
• **Sunrise: 5:47 AM (August 9)**

• **Sunset: 7:07 PM (August 8)**

• **Moonrise: 1:33 AM (August 9)**

• **Moonset: 3:19 PM (August 8)**

• AQI Tracker



Teen swept away while crossing drain in Delhi, search operation on

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

AN 18-YEAR-OLD man was swept away by a strong current while crossing a drain in the Madanpur Khadar area of Southeast Delhi on Friday evening, prompting a search and rescue operation by the police, Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) and Delhi Fire Service, said officers.

Police said the missing youth was identified as Ankit (18), a resident of Bhim Colony in Ali Vihar.

The incident took place around 8 pm near Priyanka Camp Nala in Madanpur Khadar, falling under the jurisdiction of Sarita Vihar police station. Two PCR calls were received regarding the incident on Friday—the first at 8.31 pm at Kalindi Kunj police station and the second at 8.54 pm at Sarita Vihar police station, officers added.

A police officer said that after receiving the information, a sub-inspector, along with beat staff, immediately reached the spot. During the preliminary enquiry, Ankit's friend, Manish (23), told police that the two were returning from Noida when Ankit accidentally slipped near the drain and was swept away by the strong flow of water.

Search and rescue operations were subsequently launched. Despite sustained efforts, Ankit could not be traced till the latest update came in on Saturday, police said.

Search and rescue operations are ongoing.

The incident comes as Delhi-NCR witnessed heavy rain on Friday with several areas inundated, causing massive inconvenience to people. Safety concerns emerged in waterlogged areas as people were seen wading through knee-deep waters.

Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Arms Act.

According to the prosecution, the police, acting on secret information, apprehended Akash and allegedly recovered a country-made pistol with four live cartridges and a country-made rifle/carbine with four live cartridges. Akash's disclosure statement led to the nomination of two more accused, including his brother Aman.

The petitioners' counsel argued that the accused had been falsely implicated.

GROUND report

‘Can’t grasp Math concepts’: Ghaziabad students struggle amid 10-day school closure for Kanwar Yatra

Drishti Jain
Ghaziabad, August 8

THE 16-YEAR-OLD woke up at 10 am on Friday, ate a hurried breakfast, and left her home in Makanpur, a neighbourhood in Ghaziabad, to join her mother at work, cleaning utensils at nearby kothis.

Her day would usually not start like this. The Class 9 student of Home Science and Music would be at Balika Inter College, hitting the books. But with schools shut for the Kanwar Yatra for 10 days, she was left to study on her own.

Taking cover from the rain under a tree, she said: “The teacher keeps sending work on the school WhatsApp group, but I haven’t seen any messages posted since August 3. I study from the books... what can we do if there is no phone?”

The only phone at home belongs to her mother, who takes it to work and returns late.

On August 3, the Ghaziabad District School Inspector ordered all schools in the district to remain closed from August 4 to 12 citing the movement of Kanwariyas in large numbers on various routes and the safety of students.

Several schools moved to online classes or send work through WhatsApp groups. But many children either don’t have a smartphone, uninterrupted access to it, or someone who can help them understand what is being taught.

Half a kilometre away in Gyan Khand III, a Class 7 student solved a math problem. Though he hates the subject, his teachers at school used to help him.

With three other siblings, his chance to open the school WhatsApp group on his father's phone comes at 3.30 pm.

“My father works at a gym... he leaves home at 5 am and comes back at 3 pm. I then study till 4.30 pm, after which my brother, who is in Class 9, uses the phone,” he said, adding that his mother uses a button phone.

Studying the math concept of ‘HCF’ and ‘LCM’, he said he turned to ChatGPT to explain it to him. ‘Find Product 29.0 X 31.8,’ he typed, before noting down the answer in the



(Top) A closed government school in Makanpur; a student solves a Math problem at his home in Ghaziabad. DRISHTI JAIN

notebook.

He added that for other subjects, the teacher posts pictures of the pages and marks the paragraphs they need to study.

“The problem is that I’m not able to understand the concepts. In class, I could raise my hand and clear my doubts,” he said.

His family is originally from Sitapur in Uttar Pradesh.

While these two students get homework, three brothers who live a few lanes away have not received any since school closed.

They study at a government school in Gyan Khand III.

Their father, a painter, was worried: “My elder one (in Class 8) studied regularly for a month... Now after this 10-day break, he’ll forget what he was taught.”

The family is from Purnia in Bihar.

Glancing at the youngest one who is in Class 3, he asked: “If they don’t learn now, when will they? In winters when schools shut due to the pollution, teachers used to hold on-

line classes till 10 pm... sometimes stretching till midnight. But if they don’t get work from school, what will they do?”

Basic Shiksha Adhikaari, O P Yadav told *The Indian Express* that schools decide which medium they want to use to continue teaching during such times. It could be online classes, sending work online, or assigning work before the holiday starts.

“We’ve given directions that homework is to be given so that every child is *nipun* (skilled) and that the level of learning according to the class is maintained despite such breaks,” he said.

He added that schools are regularly monitored by both State Resource Group (SRG) and Academic Resource Persons (ARP), who are responsible for visiting schools and conducting student assessments.

Back at Makanpur, the rain had eased. The 16-year-old set off again. “A day before school opens, I’ll sit the entire night and complete the work,” she smiled.

Draft drone policy ready, aim to create 1,000 jobs: Minister

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 8

INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh on Saturday said that the much-awaited draft of Delhi's proposed drone policy is ready and that it aims to over a thousand jobs.

“The proposed drone policy, which aims to create 1,000 jobs, will focus on promoting the drone industry, research and development, creating a trained manpower base, developing testing infrastructure and identifying civilian use cases for drones,” Singh told *The Indian Express*.

“The policy is ready; we plan to table it for Cabinet approval in a month,” he added.

A senior official said the proposed five-year policy is currently under departmental consultation and is expected to be implemented by September. “The minister has approved the policy. It has been sent to other concerned departments like legal, finance and others for their approval,” the official added.

Under the policy, which has been allotted a budget of Rs 85 crore, the government plans to provide support to start-ups and businesses working in the drone sector. Academic institutions undertaking research on drone and related technologies could also receive support. The policy will emphasise establishing drone research clusters, dedicated flight testing facilities, utilising drones for traffic



Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh

management, and providing subsidies to enhance the drone ecosystem.

Training will be another key focus, with the government considering the use of industrial training institutes (ITIs) to create a skilled workforce trained in drone-making, flying and maintenance, said officials.

“You have to be trained to fly; not everybody can pilot a drone,” said the official, adding that drone flying and certification would be an important area of focus.

Officials said the government is also looking at developing drone-testing infrastructure. “However, this could pose a challenge because around 60% of Delhi is classified as either a red or yellow zone under the existing drone regulations,” said the official.

Under the regulations, drone operations are permitted without specific permission in green zones, while permission

is required for flying in yellow zones. Red zones are designated as no-fly areas, for which clearance from the Ministry of Home Affairs is required, officials said.

The government is, therefore, exploring possible locations for drone testing, officials added. Narela and Bawana in Outer Delhi is among the areas being considered, they said.

Further, the policy will focus on identifying government and civilian use cases for drones. “These could include reconnaissance, land surveys, detection of encroachments and three-dimensional mapping. The Yamuna area has been identified as one potential application, while the police could also explore the use of drones for safety and surveillance,” the official said.

The IT department, which is preparing the policy, has prepared a list of potential use cases, the official added.

“The government plans to engage with different departments to identify applications, develop concepts and subsequently take them forward for implementation. The policy is also expected to examine how drone technology can be used more extensively by government departments, while creating an ecosystem to support businesses and research in the sector,” said the official.

The policy is being framed within the legal framework governing drone operations, including the Drone Rules, 2021, officials said.

Jagpreet Singh Sandhu
Chandigarh, August 8

FLAGGING A “disturbing trend” of organised criminal gangs and their sleeper cells allegedly operating with increasing frequency in Palwal, Faridabad and Gurgaon, the Punjab and Haryana High Court has directed the Haryana government to place on record its policy framework and institutional measures put in place to tackle the menace.

A bench of Justice Sanjay Vashisth issued the directions

granting regular bail to three accused in a criminal case registered in Palwal.

“This court deems it appropriate to take note of the disturbing trend emerging in certain districts of the State of Haryana, particularly Palwal, Faridabad and Gurugram, where organized criminal gangs and their sleeper cells are alleged to be operating with increasing frequency. Such activities have serious ramifications for the maintenance of public order and the safety and security of citizens,” the

bench observed.

The bench, accordingly, directed Additional Chief Secretary, Haryana Home Department, to file an affidavit on or before August 24 “apprising this Court of the policy framework and institutional measures put in place by the State to effectively deal with organised criminal gangs, their sleeper cells and other similarly placed criminal networks.”

Justice Vashisth further directed that the affidavit should indicate the “preventive, investigative and intelli-

gence-based mechanisms adopted by the State, the inter-agency coordination in place, and the specific measures undertaken to maintain law and order and curb organised criminal activities in the districts of Palwal, Faridabad and Gurugram.”

The court was hearing a bunch of three petitions for regular bail filed by Kuldeep Tyagi, Aman alias Aman Bhati and Akash alias Akash Bhati in an FIR registered at Palwal City police station on January 22, 2025, under provisions of the

37 MPs, INCLUDING THOSE FROM DMK & AIADMK, BOYCOTT MEET

Vijay-led MPs’ meet seeks permanent freeze on LS seats

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, August 8

A MEETING of Tamil Nadu MPs convened by Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay Saturday called for permanently freezing the strength of the Lok Sabha at 543 and preserving each state’s existing share of parliamentary representation, even as most of the state’s MPs stayed away amid an escalating political dispute over delimitation.

Only 20 of Tamil Nadu’s 57 MPs — 39 in Lok Sabha and 18 in Rajya Sabha — attended the meeting. Thirty-seven MPs boycotted it, including those from DMK and AIADMK. PMK, DMDK and MNM also stayed away, while MPs belonging to the Congress, VCK, CPI, CPI(M), IUML and MDMK participated.

The meeting resolved that the TN government should bring a resolution in the Assembly urging the Centre not to proceed with delimitation and instead extend the existing freeze



TN CM C Joseph Vijay expressed displeasure over the absence of DMK & AIADMK. PTI FILE

on number of LS seats. Such a resolution is likely to be introduced in Assembly next week.

“Since the delimitation exercise will reduce Tamil Nadu’s representation and importance, it is imperative that MPs work in unison to protect the state’s right,” Vijay was quoted as saying in an official release.

MPs who attended the meeting said Vijay also expressed displeasure over absence of DMK and AIADMK.

The participants rejected suggestions that increasing the

strength of LS could address the concerns of southern states, describing a possible 50% expansion as an “illusion intended to sweeten the pill.” Their position goes further: Parliament should remain at 543 elected LS seats, and the relative representation of states should not change.

The boycott, however, exposed the political divisions surrounding an issue on which TN’s parties broadly agree: states that successfully reduced population growth should not lose political influence.

DMK parliamentary party leader Kanimozhi Karunanidhi called Vijay’s meeting a “political drama” intended to divert attention from Cauvery dispute and proposed Mokedatu dam. She said the DMK’s position had already been settled through an earlier all-party process initiated by ex-CM MK Stalin. AIADMK similarly argued that Vijay should have called party leaders for an all-party meeting rather than separately inviting MPs.

Day after PM meet, Badal backs ‘fair and equitable’ delimitation

Raakhi Jagga
Patiala, August 8

A DAY after his meeting PM Narendra Modi, SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal demanded that Parliament pass the Women’s Reservation Bill, while also backing a “fair and equitable” delimitation exercise.

The move has breathed new life into speculations about SAD’s growing proximity to its former ally, the BJP, which comes at a time when the Centre is seeking wider political support for both the Bills and the delimitation. However, Badal and the SAD leadership remain tight-lipped about the recent developments.

The party has only one member in Parliament — Har-simrat Kaur Badal.

In April, the government failed to secure the required two-thirds majority in Lok Sabha to pass the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill.

On Saturday, Badal, in a social media post, maintained that his party’s position was rooted in the teachings of the Sikh Gurus, “who championed the dignity, equality and equal rights of women”. The Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee has already set an example by



Akali Dal chief Sukhbir Badal during party meeting in Chandigarh

providing reservation for women in its House, he added.

Badal said that “after detailed deliberations on key issues before Parliament, the Shiromani Akali Dal also demanded a fair and equitable Delimitation that ensures equal representation to all States”.

Meanwhile, SAD sources said the issue of women’s reservation and delimitation figured among the key issues discussed by Badal during his meeting with the prime minister.

The party has also supported the Centre’s proposal for a uniform 50% increase in number of Lok Sabha seats for all states, while stressing that women’s reservation and delimitation should be implemented immediately.

This move, however, is a departure from Badal’s stand in April, when he opposed a population-based delimitation approach, while separately supporting women’s reservation.

Welcoming the SAD’s stand, Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said all parties must come together to empower women with a fair and equitable delimitation of seats. In a post on X, Rijiju said, “I wholeheartedly welcome this very important decision taken by Shiromani Akali Dal following the example set by Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee. We must come together to empower women with a fair and equitable delimitation that ensures equal representation.”

Not attack on Cong, says Tharoor amid row over remarks at Mumbai event

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

AMID ROW over his remarks Friday that “established parties will cease to be relevant unless they can listen to new voices” and questioning if “our finger was missing from the pulse of Gen Z”, Congress MP Shashi Tharoor Saturday said that his statements were distorted as an attack on his party.

At an event celebrating the 15th anniversary of India’s International Movement to Unite Nations in Mumbai Friday, Tharoor was asked why the Congress was not being able to mobilise students the way the BJP did at Jantar Mantar over alleged exam irregularities.

“I am very conscious of what you have to say... All the Opposition parties have to be conscious of the fact that we didn’t provide a route into our parties for the kinds of people who were at Jantar Mantar. And to my mind that is actually something we really need to examine. How do young people get into established parties? Where there are hierarchies, establishments, dynastic considerations, political networks. How does a young person come in... Can they actually be the people who make a difference?” he had said.

“I think we really need to wake up and smell the coffee. Let not our epitaph be that we were bypassed or became irrelevant because we failed to listen. The established parties will cease to be relevant unless they can listen to the new voices. We should have started hearing them already. Interestingly enough the issues taken up by the CJP and Jantar Mantar protesters had been taken up by us earlier. We had a Chhatron ki Goonj thing where (Leader of the Opposition) Rahul Gandhi was addressing students about paper leaks,” Tharoor had said.

Asked about ‘Chhatron ki Goonj’ not resonating with youth like CJP’s call, he had said: “Correct. And that’s why we need to ask ourselves, what did



Congress MP Shashi Tharoor in Mumbai, Friday. @SHASHITHAROOR/X

we fail to do? Did we fail to listen? Did we fail to tap into the old cliché of having our finger on the pulse of the people? Was our finger missing from the pulse of Gen Z?”

As his statements started doing the rounds on social media, Tharoor in a post on X Saturday said: “It takes a particular combination of incompetence and malice for some media to interpret my conversation with Rishabh Shah as an attack on my own party or its leadership. Here is the entire video, uncut and unexpurgated, in full, of the conversation. Watch it and judge for yourself, as clearly none of the journalists distorting it have done.”

Senior Congress leaders declined to comment on Tharoor’s remarks but quoted his statement on X Saturday.

During Friday’s programme, Tharoor also spoke about July 20 police action on protesters in Delhi. “The whole thing was very badly handled. And as you know the result worked out in students’ favour and public opinion was so outraged... It became inevitable that the government would have to bend.”

On RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat’s recent remarks on Gen Z, Tharoor said: “I haven’t heard every single thing he said. But one of the things I was very struck by was his statement that the Gen Z protests were an expression in democracy, that they were justifiable, and nothing anti-national about protesting in a democracy... That is an absolutely essential lesson the entire political establishment needs to have learnt.”

NCP-SP MPs to meet Modi tomorrow; oppose FCRA Bill in present form: Sule

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 8

NCP (SP) WORKING president Supriya Sule Saturday said all party MPs in Lok Sabha will meet PM Narendra Modi Monday to raise issues concerning Maharashtra. “A delegation of 8 MPs belonging to NCP (SP) will meet the PM at his Parliament office,” Sule said in Mumbai.

She said the delegation will raise issues including the water crisis, farmer suicides and challenges arising from rapid urbanisation. The MPs would also discuss problems related to utilisation of their Rs 5 crore

development funds, which, she said, face hurdles due to a lack of state government support.

Sule also said the party opposed the FCRA Bill, 2026, in its present form and called for either its withdrawal or referral to a joint committee of Parliament. “We are willing to debate on the legislation in the House. But any decision without discussion and consensus is not acceptable to us.”

Sule rejected suggestions that the meeting with the PM had any political motive. “We are meeting for Maharashtra-related issues. Our meeting is not over breakfast,” she said.

BJP slams AAP govt, flags illegal mining, extortion, media censorship

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

THE BJP on Saturday trained its guns at AAP government in Punjab over “breakdown of law and order”, and accused it of putting in place an “undeclared censorship” being busy in “managing headlines”.

A day after SAD chief Sukhbir Badal called on PM Narendra Modi, BJP RS MP and state-in-charge Tarun Chugh at a press meet questioned AAP’s style of governance, and said that the party has become “the country’s biggest example of misuse of state machinery”.

Addressing reporters at the BJP headquarters, Chugh underlined that the party will “contest all 117 Assembly seats” in the elections.

Accusing the AAP government of making “extortion, collection and torture centres” the norm of the day in the state, Chugh took a dig at AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal, saying that Kejriwal had promised a new mining policy, which would bring Rs 20,000 crore to the Punjab’s coffers annually. “In reality... even Rs 800-900 crore has not reached the treasury... every child in Punjab knows that a ‘Mann Tax’ of Rs 3,500 is being collected from every truck carrying illegally mined material,” he alleged.

In addition to accusing the AAP government of putting in place an “undeclared censorship” in the state, Chugh said that it had also used force against its own sanitation employees that were conducting a peaceful protest at Barnala.

3 months into govt, Bengal BJP cracks down on 325 workers over extortion charges

Ravik Bhattacharya
& Atri Mitra

Kolkata, August 8

THREE MONTHS after storming to power in West Bengal, BJP has been dealing with increasing allegations of corruption and extortion against a party section, which it had earlier associated with previous Mamata Banerjee-led TMC regime.

The Bengal BJP recently suspended about 25 party activists and issued show-cause notices to over 300 workers at various levels across districts on charges of extortion, corruption and anti-party activities against them.

“This (extortion) is indeed a problem. There are two things. One, a section of our own leaders and workers are indulging in it. And second, several TMC activists have informally joined our party and are continuing such activities,” said a senior BJP leader. “Apart from suspension and show-cause notices, we have issued stern warning to district leaders to check these activities. We have a strict organisational code and ideology. Anyone violating it will be dealt with severely.”

Soon after BJP handed a crushing defeat to TMC in May, Bengal BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya had said the party’s doors will be closed for TMC leaders.

Recently, Bhattacharya admitted that BJP has “not been able to eliminate extortion completely” within its ranks. Warning BJP leaders that no one found involved in cor-



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari, Speaker Rathindra Bose (left) and rebel TMC MLA Ritabrata Banerjee in Kolkata, Saturday. PTI

ruption, including any MLAs or MPs, would be spared, he said, “Some people are trying to extort money using our party’s name. CM Suwendu Adhikari is taking strict administrative action. We are also taking action at organisational level.”

Even RSS seems to be concerned about charges of extortion, syndicates and corruption being made against a section of BJP leaders. The BJP earlier used to link them with the “culture” of the then ruling TMC.

“It will be alright soon. You have to give it some time. It (BJP government) has just been for three months. Corruption was there during the Left regime and thereafter institutionalised during TMC rule. Steps are being taken and we hope it will be controlled soon,” Jishnu Basu Saha, Prachar Pramukh of the RSS, Purba Pranta, told *The Indian Express*.

The BJP central leadership has been apprised of these matters, party sources said. During his Kolkata visit this week, the party’s Bengal in-charge, Sunil

Bansal, held a slew of organisational meetings with state unit, where these issues were discussed threadbare, sources said.

On Thursday, Bansal held a meeting with party brass from Kolkata and Barasat. On Friday, he convened a core committee meet, which was attended by CM Adhikari, Samik Bhattacharya, and Union Minister Sukanta Majumdar, among others.

These high-level meetings also discussed the law and order situation, party organisation, current delimitation in KMC wards and the civic body elections and various Assembly and Lok Sabha bypolls.

While BJP’s disciplinary committee is keeping a watch over state leaders and workers, the leaders of all organisational districts and mandals have been asked to keep an eye for any corrupt or unscrupulous activities and report to the state leadership, sources said.

State BJP has got complaints of extortion, both verbally and in writing, from parts of Kolkata and its suburbs, South 24-Par-

ganas, Hooghly, West Burdwan, and Birbhum, among other places, sources said, adding that even during Adhikari’s ‘Janta Darbar’ several people have alleged some BJP leaders’ involvement in “extortion and hooliganism” in districts.

Last month, a promoter in south Dum Dum was allegedly beaten up by some goons who have allegedly switched allegiance form TMC to BJP now. The promoter alleged that extortionists had demanded Rs 5 lakh for a new construction project.

Dum Dum BJP MLA Arijit Bakshi, who met the promoter at a hospital, said he had asked the promoter to lodge a police complaint, irrespective of the political affiliation of the accused.

In West Bardhaman’s Jamuria, a BJP leader, Rakesh Maji, was arrested and sent to police custody for extorting cash from sand-laden trucks. BJP MLA of Jamuria, Bijan Mukherjee, said, “Police has taken action soon after a complaint was received.”

A BJP leader in Kolkata’s Behala was accused of extortion from a developer as a contribution to “party funds”.

A row also erupted in Baduria in North 24 Parganas after videos on social media purportedly showed two local BJP leaders seated with bundles of cash. Local police have yet to take any action in this matter.

The allegations of extortion have been made against some BJP leaders in Katwa, East Burdwan, by a clerk Sujan Ghosh in Land and Land Reforms Department. He alleged that Rs 5 lakh

was demanded from him and that he was also assaulted. He has lodged a complaint at Katwa police station against several local BJP leaders. Local BJP leadership has denied the allegations while police are probing into it.

CM Adhikari recently launched four toll-free helpline numbers for complaints related to cut money, syndicate extortion, and illegal toll and liquor.

Another trouble brewing in Bengal BJP is related to entry of TMC leaders and workers into party fold. While several TMC workers have already come under the banner of BJP in districts, some prominent TMC leaders such as Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Sushmita Dev and Prakash Chik Baraik, also switched to the party. They have been re-elected to RS as BJP candidates soon after joining the party.

The proximity of 20 rebel TMC MPs, who have now merged with NCPI, to BJP have also caused resentment in a party section, sources said. Seeking to downplay such rifts, Minister Dilip Ghosh said, “We have not opened doors for anyone. This will not be accepted by party’s workers. Those (TMC) leaders, because of whom our workers have lost their houses and were injured will not be accepted.”

On rebel TMC MPs, Ghosh said “We hold relations with TMC MLAs and MPs. But we have not take them into our party. BJP is a national party and we will accept our high command’s orders. But they too are aware of the situation at the grassroots level.”

● FARM AGITATION TO LGBTQ RIGHTS, RSS HAS OFTEN MADE PUBLIC INTERVENTIONS TO FLAG ‘SHORTCOMINGS’ IN BJP-LED GOVT’S APPROACH, OFTEN BEFORE PARTY RECALIBRATES ITS MOVES

2024 poll setback to Gen Z protests: How RSS chief nudges BJP into course correction

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 8

RSS CHIEF Mohan Bhagwat’s observation that the BJP-led government erred in delaying engagement with protesting youths at Jantar Mantar is being seen in Sangh Parivar circles as more than a comment on the current student agitation over the exam paper leaks. In the Sangh ecosystem, this actually fits a familiar pattern — the RSS publicly signalling its discomfort with BJP dispensation’s handling of certain politically sensitive issues, while stopping short of any direct confrontation.

At a youth event in Mumbai Thursday, Bhagwat said, “*Kami to rahi hai*” (there were shortcomings) when asked whether government had delayed in initiating dialogue with youth protesters at Jantar Mantar. He argued that protest is a legitimate form of democratic dialogue,

cautioned against branding young protesters as anti-national, and stressed that concerns over India’s education system were genuine and required engagement rather than dismissal.

“When something that should not happen, happens, then it is evident some mistake has been committed.

E. *Kami to rahi hai.* It should have been done. We should also see if Gen Z is protesting, it is not protesting because it is opposed to us. It is protesting because it is facing some problem. The solution to that problem must be found,” the RSS chief said.

Those familiar with the RSS-BJP relationship say Bhagwat’s intervention is best understood in the context of Sangh’s long-standing role as ideological mentor that periodically urges its political arm towards course correction.

‘Corrective voice’

Unlike the Atal Bihari Vajpayee-era Sangh, the Mohan Bhagwat-led RSS rarely takes on BJP government directly. Instead, its interventions typically acknowledge the government’s broad direction while identifying deficiencies in implementation, communication or political strategy.

That approach was evident during the farmers’ agitation in 2020-21 against three now-repealed farm laws, which had marked the last time the Narendra Modi government buckled under a movement’s pressure. As protests continued, the government showed resistance in finding a resolution, with the deadlock persisting for months.

In January 2021, then RSS general secretary Bhaiyyaji Joshi openly underlined the need for a dialogue. “It is important to find that point where the two sides can agree and the agitation can end. Any agitation running



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat during an event in Mumbai. PTI FILE

for long is not beneficial... A middle ground must be found and both sides must work to find a solution,” he had then told *The Indian Express* in an interview.

10 months later, PM Modi announced the repeal of three laws.

After 2024 polls

The 2024 LS elections saw BJP fall short of a majority with its tally dropping from 303 to 240 seats, marking the first time

in a decade the party had to rely on its NDA allies to form a government. Days after poll results, Bhagwat said, “A true sevak operates within decorum... he does not get attached, is not arrogant that this has been done by me. Only he can be called a sevak.”

Although he did not mention BJP, the RSS Sarsangchalak’s remarks were widely read as a message to its leadership after the party’s setback. Its tim-

ing amplified such an interpretation. It came soon after then BJP chief J P Nadda suggested in an interview with *The Indian Express* BJP had become organisationally self-sufficient and no longer depended on the RSS in the way it once had.

Bhagwat’s comments were thus seen not merely as a moral observation but also as a reminder that electoral strength had not altered the ideological hierarchy within the Sangh Parivar.

LGBTQ rights

Bhagwat has also, at times, steered broader conservative discourse in directions different from BJP’s stances.

In 2013, senior BJP leader Rajnath Singh had opposed criminalising homosexuality, describing it as “unnatural”.

A decade later, Bhagwat articulated a markedly different position. In January 2023, he argued that homosexuality was a biological reality, rooted in his ar-

gument in Indian civilisational traditions, and said the LGBTQ deserved dignity and their own private space in society.

Drawing upon the story of Jarasandha’s generals Hans and Dimbhaka, Bhagwat suggested that people with same-sex orientation had always existed in India and that society should accommodate them rather than ostracise them. “RSS wants them to have their own private space and to feel that they, too, are a part of society,” he said.

Shifting dynamics

These interventions underline the evolving nature of the RSS-BJP ties during the tenure of the Modi government.

Since 2014, BJP has expanded dramatically, becoming electorally dominant and institutionally stronger than at any point in its history. BJP central leadership exercises far greater autonomy now than earlier, reducing their day-to-day organ-

isational dependence on RSS.

At the same time, RSS has sought to preserve its role as the Parivar’s ideological fountainhead rather than just a political manager. Instead of intervening in routine governance matters, it reserves public comments for occasions when it believes that the political leadership might be drifting away from their organisational ethos or losing touch with social sentiments.

That explains why Bhagwat’s latest remarks have attracted wide attention as he has sought to again position RSS as BJP’s moral compass. As one senior RSS functionary put it, “BJP has come from RSS and not the other way round. Before BJP, there was another party spawned by RSS. What Bhagwat ji says is in the role of a guardian. If a swayamsevak, despite having the best intentions, is making mistakes, it is the Sarsangchalak’s job to correct him. Ultimately, it is all in the family.”

Spain’s India envoy under scanner over ‘irregularities’

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 8

SPANISH AMBASSADOR to India, Juan Antonio March Pujol, is being recalled by the Spanish government over alleged financial irregularities, and a new envoy is expected to replace him in the next few weeks, sources in the Indian government have confirmed to *The Indian Express*.

Sources said that March has left the country and will be soon replaced by a senior career diplomat from the Spanish Foreign Ministry.

Spanish media outlet, the *Objective*, reported that the

Anti-Corruption Prosecutor’s Office received a report in late May from a Foreign Ministry official regarding the alleged financial misconduct. That prompted the process to replace envoy March, who had presented his credentials to President Droupadi Murmu in July 2024.

According to the *Objective*, in February this year events involving an Indian dance company, Spanish and Chinese singers were organised in Rajasthan reportedly at March’s initiative to mark 70th anniversary of India-Spain diplomatic relations, but without Madrid’s approval.



Allegations against Juan Antonio March Pujol linked to events in Rajasthan to mark the 70th anniversary of India-Spain ties

The Spanish Agency for International Development Cooperation (AECID) vetoed them after a report from the cultural

attaché of the Spanish embassy. According to the Spanish media outlet, the Chinese singer received Euros 18,000 from the Spanish embassy in 2025 for concerts organised by the Spanish ambassador. For 2026, the Spanish envoy planned more performances for Euros 14,000 with costs to be covered by companies and the Rajasthan government, without informing the Spanish Foreign ministry.

According to *Objective*, the ambassador initially sought Euros 40,500 from Spanish companies and the Rajasthan government to pay the three artists. It is alleged that the pro-

posed sponsorships were to be paid directly to the organising group, rather than through embassy accounts. The Spanish embassy’s cultural attaché reported that the Spanish envoy instructed him not to enter the activities in the internal accounting system — a step mandatory for embassy cultural events.

It is alleged that the Spanish envoy also independently negotiated a 5,000-Euros contribution from an Indian company. He allegedly instructed the cultural attaché to arrange international flights for the Chinese and the Spanish singers through that company. The attaché reported that AECID had

no record of the activity and that established procedures were not being followed.

The Indian Express reached out to the Spanish embassy for comment from the Spanish ambassador on the issue, but there was no response so far.

Before his appointment as Spain’s ambassador to India, March was the president of Fundación Onuart, an organisation specialising on the value and positive impact of art on international relations. March had earlier been posted at the UN in Geneva (2004-07), WTO (2004-07), and in Russia (2007-11) and Armenia (2009-11), among others.

30 judges appointed to Madras, Karnataka, Calcutta & MP HCs

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 8

THIRTY JUDGES were appointed to four high courts on Saturday. Twenty of them are advocates and the rest 10 are judicial officers.

A law ministry statement said while 15 judges were appointed to the Madras High Court, eight were appointed to

the Calcutta High Court. Six judges have been appointed to the Karnataka High Court and one judge has been appointed to the Madhya Pradesh High Court.

Advocates and judicial officers (judges of lower courts) are appointed to high courts. Those appointed as additional judges are usually elevated as judges (or permanent judges as they are commonly called) in two years.

After 45 years, India once again sends peacocks to UN in Geneva

Divyaa
New Delhi, August 8

‘WILL PIERRE the solitaire be replaced?’ — so began a story that ran in a Swiss newspaper in 1951. It was in reference to the last surviving peacock on the lawns of the United Nations (UN) office in Geneva, asking whether the lone bird would get company or a successor.

While a peacock continued to be spotted here over the years, in 1981, then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi sent a breeding pair of Indian peafowl from Delhi Zoo as a gift from India, where the national bird holds a special place.

This week, 45 years after the event, New Delhi moved five more birds to that ostentation. This time, all males — four in blue and one white.

At a special ceremony held on Friday, Ambassador Arindam Bagchi, India’s permanent representative to the UN, formally handed over the peafowls to Tatiana Valovaya, director-general of UN Geneva (UNOG).

“The gesture underscores India’s longstanding partnership with the United Nations and reaffirms its steadfast commitment to multilateralism and international cooperation,” India’s Mission here said in a statement post the ceremony.

“Peacocks have been an integral part of Ariana Park, the home of the UNOG for over a century. This marks the second occasion on which India



India sent 5 peafowls — 4 blue and 1 white — to the UN office in Geneva.

has donated peacocks...,” the statement further read.

What is presently UNOG grounds was once the private estate of Swiss art collector Gustave Revilliod. Peacocks have always made their presence felt here. More profoundly so in 1954, when a bird climbed onto a Soviet delegation car, much to the delight of the photographers.

However, before Friday’s event, just one peacock wandered the grounds, making only rare appearances. “We are very happy to welcome five new peacocks — four blue and one white; typical United Nations colours (blue and white). We have created a temporary house for them. They will stay here for the next three months... then they will be

allowed to move freely and enjoy the hospitality of Ariana Park,” UN’s Tatiana said.

As per the UNOG, the new muster of five remained “unruffled” even as it became the centre of attention, especially during the ribbon-cutting ceremony held in their honour on Friday. The birds will be overseen by Dr Tobias Blaha, a qualified veterinarian and the director of Bioparc Genève (Geneva Bioparc) in Switzerland.

“The Indian Peacock, a symbol of grace, beauty and resilience, represents India’s enduring commitment to the conservation of biodiversity and environmental stewardship,” India’s Mission added. UNOG will soon launch a competition to name the peacocks.

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Ref. No. 673/Admission/Academic/26

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Applications are invited for admission to M.Tech. programmes for both GATE qualified and Non-GATE candidates in (i) Computer Science & Engineering, (ii) Information Technology, (iii) Structural Engineering, (iv) Electronics & Communication Engineering, (v) CAD CAM & Robotics, (vi) Chemical Engineering, (vii) Mechanical engineering, (viii) Water Resources & Environmental Engineering, (ix) Geotechnical Engineering (x) Energy and Environmental Engineering.

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Delhi Gazette

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असाधारण
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PART IV GOVERNMENT OF THE NATIONAL CAPITAL TERRITORY OF DELHI REVENUE DEPARTMENT [Office Of The District Magistrate (South)] PRELIMINARY NOTIFICATION Delhi, the 6th August, 2026

F. No. DMS-S015/1/2026-LAC-DM(South)/E-3899/373-380 .— In exercise of the power conferred by sub-section (1) of Section 11 read with section 40(1) and (4) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 read with Notification No. S.O 2740(E) dated 21st October, 2014 read with S.O.2014(E) dated 21.07.2015 of Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India, it appears to the Lieutenant Governor of National Capital Territory of Delhi, being the Appropriate Government that a total of 8884.967 square meters of land is urgently required for public purpose, namely, for Gaushala Road in Revenue Village Satbari, Sub-Division Chattarpur, District South, Delhi for widening of approach Road leading to Central Armed Police Forces Institute of Medical Sciences (CAPFIMS) for Delhi Development Authority.

Therefore, it is notified that for the above said project in Revenue Village Satbari, Sub-Division Chattarpur, District South, Delhi a total land measuring 8884.967 square meters, whose detailed description is as follows, is given below in schedule of land is under acquisition:-

SCHEDULE OF LAND (Specification of Land)						Boundaries			
S. No	Kh. No.	Type of title	Type of land	Area under acquisition (in Sqm)	Name and address of person interested	N.	S.	E.	W.
1	269 min	Government	Partially Built up	1224.931	Gram Sabha/BDO	Remaining part of Kh. No. 269	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 270	Main Chhattarpur Road
2	270 min	Government	Partially Built up	1236.669	Gram Sabha/BDO	Remaining part of Kh. No. 270	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 273	Kh. No. 269
3	273 min	Private	Partially Built up	1244.879	Smt. Manju Gupta W/o Raj Kumar R/o B-10/7318, Vasant Kunj & Gajender Singh R/o 62/16, Kalkaji Extn. N.Delhi.	Remaining part of Kh. No. 273	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 274	Kh. No. 270
4	274 min	Private	Partially Built up	1244.964	Gajender Singh R/o 62/16, Kalkaji Extn. New Delhi	Remaining part of Kh. No. 274	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 275	Kh. No. 273
5	275 min	Private	Partially Built up	1241.131	Smt. Kamlesh Vasudewa W/o S. Vasudewa R/o S-313, Panchsheel Park, New Delhi	Remaining part of Kh. No. 275	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 293	Kh. No. 274
6	293 min	Private	Partially Built up	647.241	Smt. Kamlesh Vasudewa W/o S. Vasudewa R/o S-313, Panchsheel Park, New Delhi	Remaining part of Kh. No. 293	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 295	Kh. No. 275
7	295 min	Private	Vacant	46.246	Sh. J. M. Sehgal S/o Rai Bahadur Dev Raj Sehgal R/o D-335, Defence Colony, New Delhi	Remaining part of Kh. No. 295	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 297/1	Kh. No. 293
8	297/1 min	Private	Vacant	66.64	Sh. J. M. Sehgal S/o Rai Bahadur Dev Raj Sehgal R/o D-335, Defence Colony, New Delhi	Remaining part of Kh. No. 297/1	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 298	Kh. No. 295
9	298 Min	Private	Vacant	76.06	M/s Nirakar Property LLP R/o B-92, Shivalik Colony & M/s Gokul Realtors (P) Ltd. R/o 30, Oak Drive DLF, Chattarpur, New Delhi	Remaining part of Kh. No. 298	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 299	Kh. No. 297/1
10	299 Min	Private	Vacant	79.07	M/s Gokul Realtors (P) Ltd. R/o 30, Oak Drive DLF, Chattarpur, New Delhi	Remaining part of Kh. No. 299	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 313/1	Kh. No. 298
11	313/1 min	Private	Vacant	106.103	Sohal Lal Sharma S/o Nanak Chand Sharma R/o 105, Saingria Haminder State, 7 Bangla, Andhari West, Mumbai	Remaining part of Kh. No. 313/1	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 314/1	Kh. No. 299
12	314/1 min	Private	Vacant	197.95	M/s Bee Gee Ess farms & Properties (P) Ltd. R/o E-2, Vijay Nagar, Delhi	Remaining part of Kh. No. 314/1	Gaushala Road	Kh. No. 319	Kh. No. 313/1
13	401 min	Private	Vacant within boundary Wall	264.766	1.Sh. Jasmoohan Singh S/o Lt. Mammoohan Singh R/o A-45, New Friends Colony, New Delhi 3.Dr. Sudesh Gupta S/o Amarath Gupta R/o D-41 Defence Colony, New Delhi	Gaushala Road	Remaining part of Kh. No. 401	Kh. No. 400	Kh. No. 402
14	402 min	Private	Vacant within boundary Wall	260.881	Smt. Sarita Sarma R/o 148 Jor Bagh, New Delhi	Gaushala Road	Remaining part of Kh. No. 402	Kh. No. 401	Kh. No. 427

15	427 Min	Private	Partially Built up	260.955	Smt. Archana Singhania W/o Sh. Arving Singhania R/o 20 Singhani Farm House, Gaushala Road, Satbari	Gaushala Road	Remaining part of Kh. No. 427	Kh. No. 402	Kh. No. 428
16	428 Min	Private	Built up	269.188	1.Krishan Dev Diwan S/o Deep Chand R/o F-8/ 12, Model Town, Delhi 2.Harbhajan Kaur W/o Sohan Singh R/o 119, Sant Nagar, N. Delhi. 3. Smt. Krishna Dwivedi W/o R.D. Dwivedi R/o- 1E/136, Lajpat Nagar, New Delhi	Gaushala Road	Remaining part of Kh. No. 428	Kh. No. 427	Kh. No. 429
17	429 Min	Private	Built up	417.293	1. Smt. Gyan Devi W/o Roshan Lal R/o 107, Yusuf Sarai, New Delhi. 2. Ganga Ram S/o Duna Ram R/o 105, Yusuf Sarai, New Delhi. 3. M/s Gulshan House Store Marfat Madan Lal S/o Karamchand R/o 1-1030/1, Gautam Nagar, New Delhi. 4. Krishan Dev Diwan S/o Deep Chand R/o 8/ 12, Model Town, Delhi. 5. Jaswant Ray S/o Ram Kishan R/o 974A, Ward No.7, Mehrauli. 6. Sita Ram S/o Neeki Ram R/o Rajpur Khurd. 7. Dalchand S/o Tula Ram Sakin Deh. 8. Smt. Chaniya W/o Beni Ram R/o New Delhi. 9. Smt. Satya Goyal W/o P.S. Goyal R/o F-176, Kotla Mubarakpur	Gaushala Road	Remaining part of Kh. No. 429	Kh. No. 428	Main Chhattarpur Road

Trees			
S. No.	Kh. No.		Number of trees
1	269 Min		48 (Approx)
2	273 Min		25 (Approx)
3	274 Min		50 (Approx)
4	275 Min		12
5	293 Min		8
6	297/1Min		3
7	298 Min		13
8	299 Min		22 (Approx)
9	401 Min		15 (Approx)
10	402 Min		17 (Approx)
11	427 Min		2

Structures			
S.No.	Kh. No.	Type	Number
1	269 Min	Mostly permanent and one teen shaded structure	7 (1 Basement, 5 Ground floor Structure & 1 Teen Shaded Structure)
2	270 Min	Mostly permanent and one teen shaded structure	6 (5 Ground floor Structure & 1 Teen Shaded Structure)
3	273 Min	Permanent Structure	2 (2 Ground floor Structure)
4	274 Min	Permanent Structure	5 (5 Ground floor Structure)
5	293 Min	Mostly permanent and one teen shaded structure	5 (3 Ground floor Structure, 01 Teen Shaded Structure & partial part of 01 Double story structure)
6	402 Min	Permanent Structure	1 Transformer within boundary wall
7	427 Min	Permanent Structure	1 (1 Ground floor Structure)
S.No.	Kh. No.	Type	Number
8	428 Min	Permanent Structure	3 (Partial part of 1 Ground floor structure, 1 Triple story structure & 01 Temporary structure)
9	429 Min	Permanent Structure	1 (Partial part of 1 Ground floor structure with basement)

This notification is made under the provisions of Section 11(1) read with Section 40 (1) and (4) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 (30 of 2013), to all whom it may concern.

The Appropriate Government is pleased to authorize Deputy Commissioner, District South, and his staff to enter upon and survey land, take levels of any land, dig or bore into the sub -soil and do all other acts required for the proper execution of their work as provided and specified in Section 12 of the said Act.

Under Section 11(4) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, no person shall make any transaction or cause any transaction of land i.e. sale/purchase, etc. or create any encumbrances on such land from the date of publication of such notification without prior approval of the Collector.

The Appropriate Government being of the opinion that the provisions of sub section (1), (2) and sub - section (3) of Section 40 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 are applicable to said land under acquisition and since the land is urgently required for the public purpose falling within the purview of section 40(2), the Appropriate Government is further pleased to decide under section 40(4) of the Act and directed that the provisions of Chapters- II, III, Sections 14 to 18, 31, 32, 38, 43, 44 and 47 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act,2013 shall not apply to this acquisition and a declaration may be made under Section 19 in respect of the above land at any time after the date of publication of the preliminary notification under sub -section (1) of Section 11 read with 40(1) and (4) of the Act;

The Collector (Deputy Commissioner), District South, Delhi, though no award has been, may, on expiration of thirty days from the publication of the notice mentioned in Section 21 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, take possession of any land needed for a public purpose and such land shall thereupon vest absolutely in the Government, free from all encumbrances.

A plan of the land may be inspected in the office of the Deputy Commissioner/Collector, District South, Delhi and Director (LM)-II, DDA on any working day during the working hours.

By Order and in the Name of Lt. Governor of the National Capital Territory of Delhi,

Sh. LAKSHAY SINGHAL, IAS,
Collector (Deputy Commissioner)

DIP/SHABDARTH/CLASSIFIED/0174/26-27

JD Vance dials Modi, discusses ways to expand India-US ties

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 8

US VICE PRESIDENT J D Vance dialled Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday to discuss expanding the India-US comprehensive global strategic partnership, amid rising tensions in West Asia.

During the conversation, the PM extended his congratulations to Vance and Second Lady Usha on the birth of their son. Vance's call to the PM came days after Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan signed a mutual defence pact that was widely seen as a reflection of a new regional alignment amid the West Asia conflict.

"Received a phone call from US Vice President JD Vance. We discussed ways to further deepen India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership across key areas," Modi said on social media. "Warmly congratulated him and the Second Lady on the birth of their son and conveyed best wishes to the entire family."

The American side has not yet provided any details of the conversation. It is not immediately known whether the proposed trade deal between India and the US figured in the talks.

Modi and US President Donald Trump, during their meeting in France in June, instructed their officials to work towards a balanced, mutually beneficial and commercially meaningful trade agreement at the earliest.

Kerala: Probe into Savarkar question in school quiz

Press Trust of India
Thiruvananthapuram, August 8

A POLITICAL row erupted in Kerala over a question in a school quiz that described Hindutva ideologue V D Savarkar as a freedom fighter "who received the most severe punishment from the British", prompting General Education Minister N Samsudheen to order an inquiry.

The minister directed the Director of General Education to investigate who prepared and conducted the quiz and take stringent action against those responsible, his office said in a statement on Saturday.

The 'Freedom Quiz' was conducted on August 6 for lower primary students in schools in the Kasaragod, Kumbala and Manjeshwar sub-districts. According to the minister's office, the quiz was not part of the activity calendar of either the Social Science Club or the General Education Department, and neither had authorised anyone to prepare the questions or conduct the competition independently.

According to reports, teachers associated with the Social Science Club had prepared the questionnaire. The issue got flak from the CPI(M) and Left organisations.

MONTHS AFTER GUJARAT EDUCATION DEPARTMENT LAUNCHES 'BACK TO SCHOOL' CAMPAIGN

Ahmedabad records 86% success in bringing back dropouts

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, August 8

NEETABEN N Bhadresha (44), a head teacher at a municipal school in Ahmedabad's Vasna, spent her summer vacation going from home to home and tracking down 57 children who dropped out of her school in the past year. This meant making repeated visits on her scooter, convincing parents to not view their children as 'earning members' and pull them out of schools.

It pained her to see former students helping their parents sell vegetables on the streets near Jivraj Mehta Hospital in the evenings. These 57 children dropped out from classes 1-8 from her school during the 2025-26 academic session. At the end of the 'Back to School' campaign launched by the State Education Department in May-June 2026, all the children returned to school.

"Apart from selling vegetables, children would go to

'Free movement for all': Manipur govt reopens national highways after 3 yrs

Jimmy Leivon
Imphal, August 8

IN A significant development, the Manipur government on Saturday announced the immediate reopening of the state's national highways, allowing the free movement of people from all communities.

The announcement was made jointly by Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh, his deputy Nemcha Kipgen, and legislator Haokholet Kipgen at the Kangpokpi District Headquarters.

The state's two key lifelines, namely NH-37 (Imphal-Jiribam road) and NH-2 (Imphal-Dimapur road), have been severely affected by law-and-order challenges and blockades since the



Members of Naga and Meitei communities burn tyres on NH-2 during a protest over the death of six Naga civilians in Leilon Vaiphei village in June this year, in Kangpokpi on Saturday. ANI

outbreak of the ethnic violence on May 3, 2023. Their reopening is expected to instill life in the battle-weary state. The govern-

ment has also declared the resumption of the Imphal-Dimapur bus service.

During a public address in

Kangpokpi, Singh said that the boundaries of Manipur were shaped and protected by all communities, who have made sacrifices to safeguard the state's integrity. He also said that it was unfortunate that certain vested interests were trying to create confusion among the public, but added that every crisis has a solution.

Further, Singh urged all communities to build trust and support one another. He said that people should first identify themselves as Indians and then as Manipuris, expressing concern that some were not hesitant to do the latter.

He also pointed out that India's development would remain incomplete without the progress of the Northeast, and

similarly, Manipur's development would be incomplete without the development of Kangpokpi district.

In hailing the occasion as a historic moment for the state, Deputy Chief Minister Kipgen on Saturday said that balanced development between the valley and hill areas is essential for the state's overall progress, adding that the BJP-led government has been consistently working for the development of Manipur.

She also pointed out that lasting peace can be achieved only through mutual trust, love, and understanding among communities, and sought the support of civil society organisations, public leaders, intellectuals, and all stakeholders in building enduring peace in Manipur.

Punjab CM seeks parole for Beant Singh assassin, cites mother's poor health

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, August 8

PUNJAB CHIEF Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday wrote to the Governor pushing for the grant of 10-day parole to Jagtar Singh Hawara, serving a life term for the assassination of then chief minister Beant Singh in 1995, to enable him to meet his ailing mother.

This is the first instance of a sitting chief minister in Punjab seeking parole for a convict in the assassination of a former CM. Mann, in his letter to Governor Gulab Chand Kataria, who is also the Chandigarh Administrator, said, "Owing to her old age, the mother of Jagtar Singh Hawara is facing age-related health issues..."

The CM also referred to a petition filed by Hawara before the Punjab and Haryana High Court seeking parole and said the court had directed the authorities to consider his plea. "Therefore, on humanitarian grounds, I wish to request you that, keeping in view the deteriorating health of Hawara's mother, he may kindly be granted parole for 10 days at the earliest," Mann wrote.

Later, in a post on X, he said, "Every person should be entitled to their fundamental human rights while remaining within the framework of the law; this is the hallmark of true democracy".

Just over a week back, a delegation of Shiromani Akali Dal (Punjab) had met the Governor, seeking his intervention in allowing Hawara to meet his ailing mother.

Hawara is serving life sentence in the case relating to the August 31, 1995 assassination of Beant Singh, who was killed along with 16 others in a bomb blast outside the Punjab Civil Secretariat in Chandigarh. Hawara and co-accused Balwant Singh Rajoana were sentenced to death by the trial court in 2007.

BRIEFLY



At the accident site in Chamba on Saturday. EXPRESS

HIMACHAL PRADESH

Seven killed, 11 injured as private bus falls off steep slope in Chamba

SEVEN PASSENGERS were killed, and 11 others injured in Himachal Pradesh's Chamba after a private bus overturned and rolled down a steep slope before landing near Chalunj Mor on Bairagarh-Tissa road on Saturday, police said. There were 18 people, including the driver, on the bus. Chamba SP Vijay Kumar Saklani said they are yet to determine the cause of the accident, although a mechanical fault in the bus has not been ruled out. The deceased were identified as Jagdev Sharma (50), Des Raj (35), Tej Singh (30), Jagdey (24), Hardei (45), Neelam (34), and bus driver Roop Singh (35). Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu said, "I extend my deepest condolences to the families who have lost their loved ones in this tragic accident," ENS

Skeleton found at Bengaluru home, may be a year old

A 57-YEAR-OLD woman, who had been living alone in her house in Bengaluru's Bagalagunte, was found dead on Friday, with her remains reduced to a skeleton, police said on Saturday. The woman, identified as Dakshayini, may have died nearly a year ago. An unnatural death report has been registered, police said, adding that her family members did not harbour any suspicion regarding her death. According to her brother Mahesh (50), the family had been out of touch with Dakshayini for around two years. ENS

Man faces bid to kill charge for mid-flight chaos

POLICE HAVE added an attempt to murder charge against a man who allegedly tried to open the emergency exit of Batik Air flight OD231 from Kuala Lumpur-Kochi, damaged its window panel, and threatened fellow passengers and cabin crew late Wednesday, officials said on Saturday. Jamsheer Athanikkal of Kootanad in Palakkad was arrested on arrival at the airport Thursday. According to police, they will file a plea before the Anagamaly Judicial First Class Magistrate Monday seeking custody of Athanikkal for questioning. PTI

Kerala govt makes cause of death medical certificate mandatory

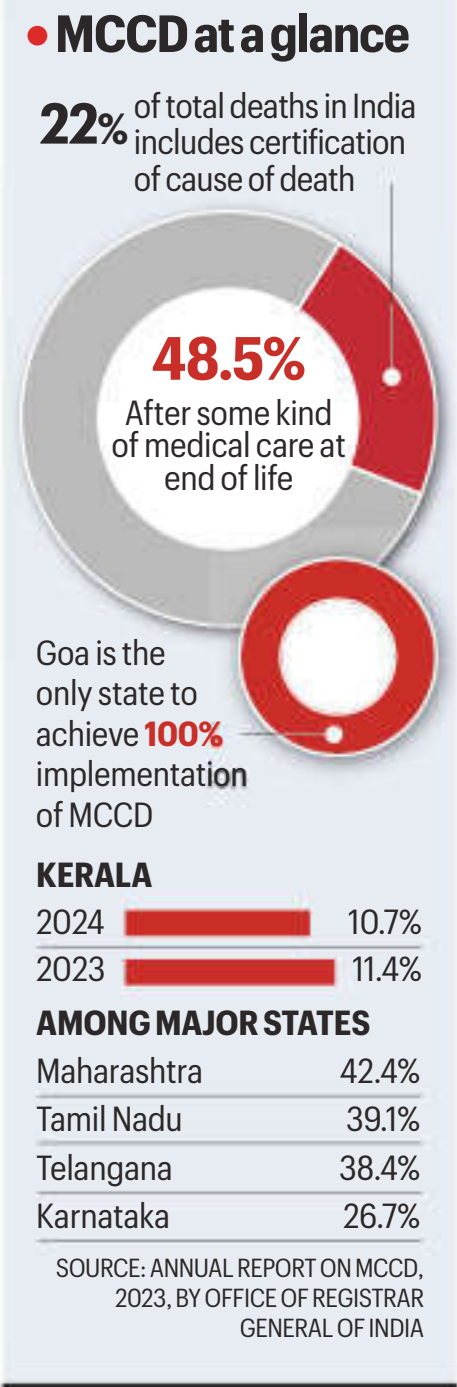
Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, August 8

THE KERALA government recently made Medical Certification Of Cause Of Death, or MCCD, mandatory for all deaths registered in the state.

According to Divya S Iyer, principal director of the local self-government department (LSGD), this course of action has been implemented in all 93 urban local bodies in the state since June 1, following an order issued on May 28. So far, the MCCD scheme has been implemented in four of the six corporations (Kochi, Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam and Kozhikode), and Alappuzha municipality were registered and certified.

"The scope of MCCD has been expanded considering its importance to public health. We have activated the civil registration system in all urban bodies (6 corporations and 87 municipalities) to incorporate the Certificate Of Cause Of Death while registering deaths, both institutional and at home," Divya said. The MCCD is a key document that informs public health policy formation, disease surveillance, medical research and allied activities. In another two months, the 940-odd village panchayats, too, will follow the practice of making medical certification of cause of death mandatory, Divya highlighted. So far, the system has not thrown up major hitches. However, it was noticed that there is a delay in certifying deaths wherein a postmortem report is necessary to ascertain the cause.

Divya also pointed out that while the medical certification of institutional deaths is seamless in the new system, "certain issues have to be addressed with regard to certifying deaths at home." A meeting will soon be arranged with all stakeholders to remedy this. In Kerala, the medical certification of cause of death under the new directive has been integrated with the Information Ke-



rala Mission, the state government venture giving IT services from local bodies.

The MCCD is the official legal and medical document that states the exact sequence of medical conditions and events leading to a person's death.

Under sections 10(2) and 10(3) of the Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Act, 1969, it is stipulated that for all deaths occurring in medical institutions, the medical practitioner who treated the deceased must provide the registrar with a certificate regarding the cause of death in the prescribed format. In the case of deaths at home, the doctor who treated the persons during their terminal illness is required to report the cause of death.

As per official data, Goa is the only state to achieve 100% implementation of MCCD.

EXPRESS special

Parks to homes in Punjab, there's new moral police in town — Nihang Singhs

Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, August 8

NEVER TOO far from controversy, groups of Nihang Singhs have now been accused of moral policing, with police complaints being filed over threats to women over clothes and social media posts.

On July 26, one such group, 'Tarna Dal 96 Cori', went around a prominent public garden in Ludhiana doing a "raid" streamed on Facebook Live, to stop "bhoond aashiq (swarm of lovers)". "Gandpaaya hoye hai Punjab cha (They have polluted Punjab)," they said in the live video, and went on to accost women for wearing sleeveless dresses, dancing and making reels, and to attack couples.

They warned that next time, they would come with their "woman fauj (army)" and beat up people with shoes and sticks. When the mother of one of the girls objected, adding that they are from Uttar Pradesh's Gonda district, group "leader" Kuldeep Singh Khalsa said: "Is this how you dance in Gonda also, wearing these half-naked clothes?" The mother and daughter were finally made to apologise, after their phone was taken and some photographs deleted.

Kuldeep, who claims to be "jathedar" of Tarna Dal 96 Cori, told The Indian Express that he and his "fauj" only "counsel" women who are on "the wrong path". "These women roam around wearing half-naked clothes, dance and make reels, sit with their lovers. We won't allow all this in Punjab... If sugar is not uncovered, flies will get attracted."

Days before the park incident, another Nihang group, led by Manpreet Singh Khalsa, entered the house of Ludhiana-based Ranjit Kaur, a social media influencer, and questioned her and her family over her "obscene reels on Instagram". Kaur mostly posts reels with her family.

Kaur said, "Around 15-20



Kuldeep Singh Khalsa and his aides moral policed women, couples at a public garden; (left) Manpreet Singh Khalsa stormed into the house of a woman social media influencer over 'obscene reels on Instagram' — both the incidents happened in Ludhiana in July



people stormed into our house... These reels are the only source of our livelihood, and now they are targeting us because we are poor. My husband and I was a palledar (labourer) but, after he started having health issues, we started making TikTok content. After Tiktok was banned, we shifted to Instagram and YouTube. When the government and law of this country don't stop us from doing this work, who are they (Nihangs)? Can they stop rich people from uploading content?... They said we should wash utensils, clean toilets and collect garbage to run our house... Can they give us Rs 50,000 a month to buy groceries? We will stop them."

Kaur and her family were forced by the group to issue a video apology, promising they will stop "posting reels". The family later filed a police complaint against Manpreet and his aides. While police are yet to act on their complaint, an FIR has been filed on Manpreet's cross-complaint against Kaur and her husband under the IT Act for "posting obscene content". The couple got bail in the case. Kaur's husband Hans said, "Punjab belongs to us, as much it belongs to them. The government should probe from where they (the Nihangs) have got so much money

that they are raiding people's houses, travelling in big cars?" Ludhiana DCP (Law and Order) Jaskiranjit Singh Teja said no one had the right to object to anyone's clothes or stop them from uploading reels on social media, or sitting in a park. "We will verify these videos and take action accordingly."

Manpreet, who runs a self-styled 'Pakhand Bhajao, Punjab Bachao' organisation, said the video posted by them of Kaur's apology was "a warning to all such girls and boys from dear armies of the guru that if you won't mend your ways, we will get an FIR registered against each one of you". On forcing their way into houses, Manpreet said, "We can go to anyone's house if they are giving a wrong message to society... We can't stop anyone from making videos but we can stop those who will put a blot on Punjab's culture."

On June 10, 2025, a Nihangs group — led by Amritpal Singh Mehron — was accused of murdering a social media influencer, Kanchan Kumari alias Kamal Kaur, in Bathinda over "spreading obscenity and vulgarity". Police had then accused Nihangs of "indulging in moral policing".

Mehron, who ran a self-styled vigilante group called 'Quam de Rakhe', fled to Dubai

after the murder as his aides were held. Three days later, Mehron had posted a video message claiming responsibility for the murder, and saying that he had "warned" Kanchan several times. In the same video, he threatened another social media influencer, Amritsar's Deepika Luthra, and said, "It isn't necessary that a body is found every time."

Luthra, who had been threatened earlier too, filed a complaint with the Amritsar police. In April, Mehron was deported from Dubai, and arrested by the Punjab police. In 2020, Mehron was booked for vandalising some statues near the Golden Temple premises in Amritsar, over the fact that they "displayed dancers... violating Sikh sentiments and religious code".

Sukhjeet Singh Kanhaiya, "mukh parcharak" of Nihang group "Baba Budha Dal", considered the most revered Nihang jathebandi, said that no real Nihang Singh indulges in such acts of moral policing. "It is difficult to identify authentic Nihangs now", he said, as anyone can "wear a bana (Nihang attire) and claim to be one". "Whenever someone gets caught doing such acts, they claim to be associated with Budha Dal or other Nihang groups just to save their skin," Kanhaiya said, adding, "In today's times, everyone has a choice to lead their own life and dress how they want."

Nihangs have also been in the news for violent incidents such as the April 2020 attack on a policeman in Patiala, with his hands chopped off after he asked them for a curfew pass during the Covid lockdown. In September 2022, two Nihangs were accused of killing a man in Amritsar over "tobacco and alcohol consumption". In June 2026, a group of Nihangs clashed with locals in Utarakhand's Karnaprayag over a parking dispute, leading to a sword attack. After four of them were held, the Nihangs took people hostage at a gurdwara demanding release of their men.

ment schemes, especially for girls. Yet parents cited social constraints and would refuse to send them back."

Asarwa locality, where this school is, largely comprises migrants who have made Ahmedabad their home. Known for textile mills decades ago, now it is better known for the Ahmedabad Civil Hospital — the largest public hospital in Gujarat. Municipal teachers here were asked to cover a 30-35 km radius, given that most parents would move frequently to find work.

For Yagnik and other teachers, the task grew difficult as the families were vegetable vendors or daily wagers living in rented quarters or temporary structures. "We would find them the first time, but they would be gone in the second. The contact number and addresses submitted during the admission process became irrelevant. Every 3-4 months, they would keep changing their numbers as most of the time

they do not recharge their mobile numbers," says Yagnik.

Sanjay Raval, principal of Chanakya Gujarati Primary School in Chanakyapuri, says, "Migration is a big issue among parents in our school. A majority of them are from Rajasthan and a few from different districts of Gujarat. Around 80% of them are into footwear-making work, while those from Gujarat are mainly safai kamdars." It is one of the seven schools in Ahmedabad city that also has a secondary school launched last year. Of 54 students re-enrolled under Raval, seven who had dropped out after Class 8 were readmitted in Class 11.

Ahmedabad Municipal School Board Administrative Officer L D Desai said, "Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel felicitated our teachers on July 22 for achieving a high success rate in bringing back the dropped out students."

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM



Paresh Patel (extreme right), a teacher at Indrapuri Public School in Ramol area of Ahmedabad, had 44 dropouts to track. EXPRESS

number includes 1,357 former students who had enrolled in schools in other states or in Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) and continued their education.

Every teacher faced a different obstacle. In the case of Suketubhai Yagnik, teacher at Jahangirpura Primary School in Asarwa area, over 80% of his 37 students were girls who dropped out. When he visited homes of the six girl students who had dropped out of Class 8, their parents told him they

needed the elder daughter to take care of younger siblings or do chores around the house.

"Parents are of the opinion that after a certain age, girls should not go out and study. Instead, they train them in household work such as stocking water, cutting vegetables, cooking, cleaning and washing. They even teach a 6-7 year old girl all these tasks," Yagnik says, adding, "When everything else would fail, at that point we would make parents aware about govern-

EXPRESS special

Mumbai to get sea-viewing deck, knowledge centre atop Bandra STP by next July

Pratip Acharya
Mumbai, August 8

IN JULY next year, Mumbai is set to get a new sea-viewing deck offering an unhindered view of the Arabian Sea and a new public space for citizens to enjoy the city's skyline, particularly during sunset hours.

The viewing deck, currently under construction, will be located at the southern edge of Bandra, adjoining the Bandra-Worli Sea Link (BWSL).

At present, Mumbai has two dedicated sea-viewing decks, at Dadar and Girgaon in the island city. The proposed facility will therefore be the first such deck in Mumbai's suburban belt.

Along with the viewing deck, the project will create an additional 2.6 acres of open space — a significant addition in space-starved Mumbai.

These amenities are part of the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation's (BMC) ambitious Wastewater Treatment Facility (WWTF) project. Under the project, the civic body plans to construct seven sewage treatment

WHAT THE PROJECT ENTAILS

2,600 sq m
Size of Knowledge Centre

2.6 acres
Area of open garden

FEATURES OF THE GARDEN

The open space will include walkways, gym equipment and seating areas. A skywalk will connect the garden with the viewing deck and convention centre.

LOCATION: Western side of the Bandra-Worli Sea Link and at the southern end of Bandra.

VIEW: 360-degree view of the Arabian Sea & Mumbai's skyline.



- 1** Knowledge Center & Viewing Gallery,

2 Admin Building,

3 Disinfection,

4 Primary Treatment
- 5** Preliminary Treatment,

6 Sludge Treatment Area,

7 IIPS,

8 Membrane Tank,

9 Bio Treatment,
- 10** Effluent Pumping Station (Existing),

11 Digesters,

12 Power Generation Building,

FEATURES OF THE TOWER:

The 60-metre tower will house a knowledge centre, auditorium & convention centre on lower deck.

KNOWLEDGE CENTRE:

Provides details on Mumbai's history of water conservation and on how BMC provides amenities.

PROJECT DEADLINE: JULY 2027 COST: RS 65.76 CR

plants (STPs) at Bandra, Worli, Dharavi, Ghatkopar, Bhandup, Versova and Malad.

In 2023, the BMC initiated the WWTF project at an estimated cost of Rs 30,000 crore. The seven STPs, which are

scheduled to become operational in phases between the end of 2026 and 2027, will have a combined capacity to treat and recycle 2,400 million litres of water daily (MLD). This is equivalent to around 55% of Mumbai's

daily water requirement.

The Bandra STP will be equipped with a bioreactor unit, where the primary treatment of sewage will take place.

The terrace of the reactor, which will be at the ground level,

will create an additional open area of around two acres, which the civic authorities are converting into a green and recreational zone. The landscaped area will include gardens, walkways and recreational facilities such as outdoor gym and seating areas.

At the Bandra facility, adjoining the recreational area, BMC is constructing a 60-metre-high tower that will be divided into multiple sections. The ground, first and second floors will house an auditorium, convention hall and information centre.

"The WWTF project is a unique venture of the BMC and today engineering students from reputed educational institutions are carrying out field visits at our sites. Therefore, the BMC decided to create a knowledge centre at this site about these STPs," an official said.

According to the civic officials, the auditorium and convention hall will be equipped with a modern library, digital classrooms, auditorium-style seating and digitally integrated study desks.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

GORKHA RIFLES



Indian Army and 11 Gorkha Rifles Salutes its brave heart, Late Rfn Nar Bahadur Rai and Late Rfn Chatur Sher Rai of 3/11 Gorkha Rifles (Third) who made the supreme sacrifice in 1970 at Mizoram on 09 Aug 1970 in a true act of valour.

Colonel 11 GR & Sikkim Scouts and All Ranks

BORDER SECURITY FORCE



Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable B B Rana on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in Counterpart firing in area of Kanga, Rajouri (Jammu) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.



Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Vijay Kumar on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in area of BOP Rasnagiri, Tura (Meghalaya).



Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Sonawane Swapnil Subhash on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in area of BOP Dholaguri, Raiganj (West Bengal).

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE



DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Jawahar Rai of 36 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while displaying exceptional courage and devotion to duty during an operation against underground hostiles in Nagaland on 9 August 1974. For his gallant action he was posthumously awarded the President's Police Medal for Gallantry. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable/Driver Kalu Ram Kad of 100 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely countering an ambush by militants in Punjab on 9 August 1992. For his exceptional gallant action, he was posthumously awarded the President's Police Medal for Gallantry. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Bappadiya Ghosh of 132 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 9 August 2009 after succumbing to injuries sustained in a militant attack while on duty at Regal Chowk, Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir on 1 August 2009. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Patel Jagnesh Kumar of 168 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured in an IED blast during an ambush by Maoists in Bijapur district, Chhattisgarh on 9 August 2014. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



ANDHRA PRADESH CAPITAL REGION DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY (APCRDA)
Project Office, Rayapudi (V), Thullur (M), Amaravati-522237, A.P.

E Procurement Tender Notice

NIT No. 22 to 35/MAU61-ADMINOPROC/TEN/2/2026-PROC, Dt:08/08/2026

Name of Work: APCRDA - "Providing Infrastructure Facilities in 26 Gram Panchayats of Amaravati Capital City under Critical Infrastructure and Investment Plan on Lump Sum contract (percentage tender) including DLP of 2 Years for 14 Packages.

The above bids can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal from 11.08.2026 to 01.09.2026 up to 14.00 Hrs. Due date for submission of Bid is 01.09.2026 up to 15.00 Hrs, Technical bid opening 01.09.2026 @16.00Hrs. For further details Please refer to www.approcurement.gov.in and www.crda.ap.gov.in . /Sd/- Commissioner, APCRDA, Rayapudi.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. AGC/TRD/T/2026/23 Date: 07.08.2026

E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE

Sr. DEE/TRD/Agra for & on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on-line only (e-Tendering) for the following work.

Tender No.: AGC/TRD/T/2026/23 Approximate Cost: Rs. 52.08.626/-

Name of Work: Modification in OHE due to Provision of 05 nos. of Lifts at RKM & FTS stations to recoup divyangjans facility in Agra Division

Earnest Money: Rs. 1.04.200/- Period of Completion: 12 months

1. For full details and submission of the bid please see the Indian Railway website www.irops.gov.in. 2. Tender can only be submitted through web portal "www.irops.gov.in" upto 15:30 Hrs. on date 31.08.2026. 1832/26(K)

North central railways www.nccr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

उत्तराखण्ड पावर कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड
(उत्तराखण्ड सरकार का उपक्रम)

कार्यालय अजीयन्ता, विद्युत भित्ति मण्डल (गुलीमो) 18 ईस्टर्ली रोड, देहरादून
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"ई-निविदा/निविदा मिस्ट्रीकरण सूचना"

अधोहस्ताक्षरकर्ता द्वारा ई-निविदा संख्या 56, 57, 58, 59, 60, 61, 62, 65 / EDCRDUU / 2026-27 तथा निविदा संख्या 63, 64 / EDCRDUU / 2026-27 आमंत्रित की गई थी, को अपरिहार्य कारणों से निरस्त किया जाता है।

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"राष्ट्र हित में विजली बचायें" टोल फ्री नं 0 1800-419-0405

रजिस्ट्री सं.डी. एल. 33002/99 REGD. No.D.L.- 33002/99

भारत सरकार
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

भारत का राजपत्र
The Gazette of India

एस. जी. -डी. एल. -अ. 07082026-275283
SG-DL-E-07082026-275283

असाधारण
EXTRAORDINARY

प्राधिकार से प्रकाशित
PUBLISHED BY AUTHORITY

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No. 228] DELHI, FRIDAY, AUGUST 07, 2026/SHRAVAN 16, 1948 [N.C.T.D.No. 158

PART IV

GOVERNMENT OF THE NATIONAL CAPITAL TERRITORY OF DELHI

REVENUE DEPARTMENT
[Office Of The District Magistrate (South)]
PRELIMINARY NOTIFICATION
Delhi, the 6th August, 2026

F. No. DMS-S015/1/2026-LAC-DM(South)/E-38399/381-388. — In exercise of the power conferred by sub section (1) of Section 11 read with section 40(1) and (4) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 read with Notification No. S.O. 2740 (E) dated 21st October, 2014 read with S.O. 2014 (E) dated 21.07.2015 of Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India, it appears to the Lieutenant Governor of National Capital Territory of Delhi being the Appropriate Government that a total of 3406.057 square meters of land is urgently required for public purpose, namely, for SAARC to CAPFMS Road in Revenue Village Maidan Garhi Sub-Division Chattarpur, District South, Delhi for widening of approach Road leading to Central Armed Police Forces Institute of Medical Sciences (CAPFIMS) for Delhi Development Authority.

Therefore, it is notified that for the above said project in Revenue Village Maidan Garhi, Sub-Division Chattarpur, District South, Delhi total land measuring 3406.057 square meters, whose detailed description is given below in schedule of land, is under acquisition:-

SCHEDULE OF LAND (Specification of Land)									
S. No	Kh. No.	Type of title	Type of land	Area under acquisition (in Sqm)	Name and address of persons interested	Boundaries			
						N. Kh. No.	S. Kh. No.	E. Kh. No.	W. Kh. No.
1.	974/421-422 Min	Private	Vacant	1179.546 (136.168 in Kh No. 421 and 1043.378 in Kh No. 422)	1. Bhudan Yagya Samiti, 2. Smt. Abha Devi W/o Satish Kumar Modi, R/o Mod Nagar, U.P.	423	424	420	Remaining part of Kh.No 974/ 421-422 min & Kh. No. 424
2.	442 min	Private	Vacant	1760.744	1. Maan Singh Dagar S/o Ramphal R/o Maidan Garhi	424	443	Remaining part of Kh. No. 442 Min	Remaining part of Kh. No. 442 Min
					2. Narain Singh Dagar S/o Ramphal R/o Maidan Garhi				
					3. Laxmi Devi D/o Ramphal				
					4. Maya D/o Ramphal				
					5. Smt Yashi Jaspal W/o S.S. Jaspal R/o 96 C, Eastern Avenue, Sainik Farm, New Delhi				
					6. Subhas S/o Maan Singh				
					7. Adarsh S/o Maan Singh				
					8. Anil Kumar S/o Maan Singh				
					9. Kulshrestha S/o Maan Singh				
					10. Nargeshwari D/o Maan Singh				
					11. Rajkala wd/o Ashok Kumar				
					12. Ankur S/o Ashok Kumar				
					13. Smt.Kavita D/o Ashok Kumar				
					14.Smt.Kanchan D/o Ashok Kumar				
					15. Satbir S/o Phool Kaur				
					16. Rajbir S/o Phool Kaur				
					17.Shakuntala D/o Phool Kaur				
					18. M/s Gurukul Leathers Office-54 Western Avenue, Sainik Farm New Delhi through proprietor S.S. Jaspal				
					19. M/s Elevation Holding Pvt Ltd.				
					F-24, Pushpanjali New Delhi through Director S.S. Jaspal				
					20. Savitri w/o Prem Singh R/o Nangli Jalib New Delhi.				
3.	519 min	Private	Vacant	41.995	Sh. Karan Kumar Modi S/o Satish Kumar Modi, R/o Modi Nagar, U.P.	520 & 424	424	Remaining part of Kh. No. 519 Min & 424	Kh. No. 424
4.	520 min	Private	Vacant	423.772	Smt. Abha Devi W/o Satish Kumar Modi, R/o Modi Nagar, U.P.	424	424	Remaining part of Kh. No. 520 Min	Kh. No. 424

Trees			
S. No.	Kh. No.	Number of trees	
1	974/421-422 Min	4	
2	519 Min	1	
Structures			
S. No.	Kh. No.	Type	Number
1	974/421-422 Min	Vacant	NA
2	442 Min	Vacant	NA
3	519 Min	Vacant	NA
4	520 Min	Vacant	NA

This notification is made under the provisions of Section 11(1) read with Section 40 (1) and (4) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 (30 of 2013), to all whom it may concern.

The Appropriate Government is pleased to authorize Deputy Commissioner, District South, and his staff to enter upon and survey land, take levels of any land, dig or bore into the sub-soil and do all other acts required for the proper execution of their work as provided and specified in Section 12 of the said Act.

Under Section 11(4) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, no person shall make any transaction or cause any transaction of land i.e. sale/purchase, etc. or create any encumbrances on such land from the date of publication of such notification without prior approval of the Collector.

The Appropriate Government being of the opinion that the provisions of sub section (1), (2) and sub - section (3) of Section 40 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 are applicable to said land under acquisition and since the land is urgently required for the public purpose falling within the purview of section 40(2), the Appropriate Government is further pleased to decide under section 40(4) of the Act and directed that the provisions of Chapters- II, III, Sections 14 to 18, 31, 32, 38, 43, 44 and 47 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act,2013 shall not apply to this acquisition and a declaration may be made under Section 19 in respect of the above land at any time after the date of publication of the preliminary notification under sub -section (1) of Section 11 read with 40(1) and (4) of the Act;

The Collector (Deputy Commissioner), District South, Delhi, though no award has been, may, on expiration of thirty days from the publication of the notice mentioned in Section 21 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, take possession of any land needed for a public purpose and such land shall thereupon vest absolutely in the Government, free from all encumbrances.

A plan of the land may be inspected in the office of the Deputy Commissioner/Collector, District South, Delhi and Director (LM)-II, DDA on any working day during the working hours.

By Order and in the Name of Lt. Governor of the National Capital Territory of Delhi,

Sh. LAKSHAY SINGHAL, IAS,
Collector (Deputy Commissioner)

DIP/SHABDARTH/CLASSIFIED/0173/26-27

3 Bengal civic volunteers rape woman, one held

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, August 8

THREE CIVIC volunteers posted at Dhupguri police station have been accused of repeatedly raping a woman over three days after allegedly abducting her from Mekhliganj in Cooch Behar district and taking her to Dhupguri in Jalpaiguri district. One of the accused has been arrested, while search is on for the other two. The arrested accused, Bulbul Alam, 30, is a resident of Bhentia in Dhupguri. All accused were posted at the Dhupguri police station, the police said. According to police sources, the three accused allegedly abducted the woman to Dhupguri last week and kept her in a rented house. The woman lodged a complaint at Mekhliganj police station.

Police sources said, the accused and their accomplices had allegedly committed several such crimes in the past, but their postings allegedly deterred victims from filing any complaints.

Teen awaiting treatment dies as mudslide blocks Rajouri road; probe ordered

Arun Sharma
Jammu, August 8

A 17-YEAR-OLD girl died for want of timely medical treatment on Friday after the vehicle carrying her to a hospital in Jammu and Kashmir's border Rajouri district remained stuck in a mudslide for several hours.

According to officials, engineers concerned had informed the administration that the road, constructed under the Prime Minister Grameen Sadak Yojana (PMGSY) and damaged during the recent rainfall, had been restored for vehicular traffic.

Rajouri District Development Commissioner Abhishek Sharma ordered an inquiry into the incident, and suspended Agha Zahid Rehman, PMGSY Assistant Executive Engineer (Kalakote Sub-Division). During the suspension, Rehman will remain attached to the Kotranka Additional Deputy Commissioner's office. The Executive Engineer, PMGSY Rajouri Division,

who had informed the administration that the road was restored, was asked to explain why disciplinary proceedings should not be initiated against him over the road's condition.

The Additional District Development Commissioner, Rajouri, has been given seven days to conduct an inquiry. Officials said the matter came to the administration's notice after a video surfaced on social media alleging the girl's death due to the closure of Chak Methayani-Panglar-Kotecharwal road maintained under the PMGSY scheme.

The girl, suffering from a disease for the past month was admitted to Government Medical College, Jammu, a fortnight ago. Quoting her father, officials said, she was being shifted to GMC Rajouri on Friday, but the road was blocked causing a delay of 2-3 hours. Local volunteers helped and partially cleared the slide but her condition deteriorated and she died on the way.

Donation row: Fadnavis orders probe into Siddhivinayak's last 5-yr records

Press Trust of India
Mumbai, August 8

MAHARASHTRA CHIEF Minister Devendra Fadnavis has ordered a comprehensive investigation into alleged donation irregularities at the popular Siddhivinayak Temple in the city, directing officials to examine the shrine's records over the past five years, an official said on Saturday.

The directive comes amid allegations by Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief Raj Thackeray, claiming Rs 18 crore was siphoned off annually from the temple donations.

Following this, nine employees were arrested in connection with the alleged theft, Sada Sarvankar, chairman of Siddhivinayak Temple Trust and a leader of the Shinde-led Shiv Sena, had said.



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis

Later, Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde demanded for independent inquiries into the matter.

According to officials, Fadnavis ordered an investigation after a delegation from the Siddhivinayak Temple Trust met him and presented a detailed account of the collections between 2023 and 2026.

Fadnavis has sought the investigation report at the earliest.

Last month, Shinde had sought an independent inquiry and instructed officials concerned to begin the process.

The controversy came to the fore after Raj Thackeray alleged that nearly Rs 18 crore was siphoned off annually from the temple donations.

Following this, Sada Sarvankar, chairman of the Siddhivinayak Temple Trust and a leader of the Shinde-led Shiv Sena, said nine employees were arrested in connection with the alleged theft.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, SHER MOHAMMED, S/o-Mohd Zakir, R/o Plot No. A/8/4 & A/9/2, Kh. No-135, 3rd Floor, Street, No.9, Near-Isha Masjid, Wazirabad, Burari, Delhi-110084, have changed my name, from SHER MOHAMMED to ABDUL QADIR, and my correct-Date of Birth is 06.01.1993, for all, future purposes. 0040870916-10

I, Niranjan Barman, S/o-Paresh Barman, R/o Village-Gijhore, Sector-53, Noida, declare that name of my minor daughter has been wrongly-written as LAKHI BARMAN in her School-record. The actual-name of my daughter is LAKSHMI BARMAN. 0040870961-6

I, RITIKA SETIA ALIAS RITIKA SHARMA D/O ASHOK KUMAR SETIA W/O RITESH SHARMA R/o A-12 ASHOKA ENCLAVE NEAR PEERAGARHI METRO STATION PEERAGARHI SUNDER VIHAR PUNJABI BAGH DELHI - 110087 have changed my name to RITIKA SHARMA. 0071053010-1

I, Geeta D/o Sh. Kanwar Lal Khattar, W/o Sanjeev Kumar, R/o F-79, F-78 and 79 Upper Ground Floor, Kh. No. 40/1, Rajendra Park Extn, Nangloi, Dist: West Delhi, Delhi-110041 have changed my name to Geeta Sharma for all purposes. 0040870818-5

I, KM. SADHNA DEVI, W/O-AJEET SINGH TOMAR, R/o-Flat No. 102, Tower No. 8, NRI-City, GH-01, Sector-Omega-2, Greater-Noida, Gautambuddha Nagar (U.P.) have changed my name to SADHANA TOMAR. 0040870927-8

I, ANBARI KHATOON W/O MOHD SALEEM residing at A-424 I.K.V Okhla ph-1 New Delhi-110020, have changed my name to ANVARI KHATOON 0040870139-1

I, Devinder, S/o-Charan Jit Singh, R/o-97/46 punjabi Ramleela Ground Pratap chowk Rohtak, Haryana-124001, Have changed my name to Davinder Singh for all purposes 0040870916-3

I, MUDITA SADANA, W/O-NAV TESH MALIK, R/O C-93, 3rd FLOOR, NARAINA-VIHAR DELHI-110028, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MUDITA SADANA MALIK. 0040870927-1

I, K Chinna Raju Service No. 825476, NCE(E), Service at AIR FORCE HQ, VAYU BHAWAN, MOTILAL NEHRU MARG, NEW DELHI 110011. That my wife's name is wrongly mentioned as PAVITHRA in my service record but my wife's actual name is PAVITHRA BAI R. 0040870971-2

I, Arun Kumar Saboo, S/O Ramsaroop Saboo, R/o H no 679, Near Euro International School, Sector 10, Gurugram, Haryana 122001 have changed my name Arun Kumar Sabu 0071053015-1

I, Bijender Kumar, S/O Madan Lal, R/o-15, 1st Floor, Pocket-4A, Sector-23, Rohini, Delhi-110085, have changed my name to Vijender Bansal 0040870961-1

I, Arun K Masih, S/O Kamil Masih, R/O D-1/16, First Floor, St Stephen, Hospital Staff Quarter-4, Rajpur Road, Civil Lines, Delhi-110054, have changed my name to Arun Kamil Masih. 0040870916-5

I, MUNESH S/O, Rampal R/o-B-1428 Jahangir Puri New Delhi-110033, have changed my name to MUNESH KUMAR for all purposes 0040870916-7

I, POOJA, W/O MUKESH RAGHAV, R/O E3-407, BHARAT-CITY, INDRAPRASTH YOUNA GHAZIABAD UTTAR PRADESH-201003, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO POOJA RAGHAV. 0040870927-3

I, Anupriya W/O Priyank Agarwal R/o Flat No-5 Building No-4, Gali No-4, Saidulajab, Saidul Azaab, South Delhi, Delhi-110030, have changed my name to Anupriya Gupta for all future Purposes. 0071053048-1

I, SACHIN JINDAL, F/O RASSHEE R/O-DUPLEX FLAT NO-16, SEC-108 NOIDA, GAUTAM BUDH NAGAR, U.P.-201304, HAVE CHANGED MY MINOR DAUGHTER NAME TO RASSHEE JINDAL, Permanently 0040870961-3

I, HEMANT SINGH, S/o SHYAM SINGH RAWAT, R/o B503, SETHI MAX ROYAL SECTOR-76, NOIDA, Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201304, have changed my name to HEMANT SINGH RAWAT for all future purposes 0071053002-1

I, Sanjay Kumar S/o Shri Sudershan Kumar, R/o D -9/11, Model Town-2, Delhi-110009, have changed my name to Sanjay Kumar Singhal for all purposes. 0040870818-2

I, VINEY GAMBHIR, S/O-RAMSARUP GAMBHIR, R/O FLAT NO.733 GURU APARTMENT SECTOR-14 ROHINI DELHI-110085, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO VINAY GAMBHIR. 0040870927-5

I, Viswanadham Chandra Kala W/o Viswanadham Venkata Srinivasa Rao R/O H-No-10/40, Pillavani Tota, Chodavaram Mandalam, Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh-531036, have changed my minor Son name from Viswanadha Jignesh Aged 15 Years to Viswanadham Jignesh forever 0071053050-1

I, Ithiertho known as SHARADA GUPTA W/O NARESH GUPTA, R/o-Near Shiv Mandir, Shiv Colony, Railway Station, Kosli, Dist:- Rewari, Haryana-123302, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as SHARDA GUPTA. 0130067794-1

I, RAKHI YADAV, W/O-SUDEEP YADAV, R/O FLAT NO-UG-2, GROUND FLOOR KAUSHAMBI, PLOT NO-D/56, VASUNDHARA GHAZIABAD-201012, UP, have changed my name to RAKHI, for all, future purposes. 0040870916-9

I, Sushil Kumar, S/o-Subhash Chand Sharma, R/o-A-19 Jain-Colony Shahabad Mohammad Pur, South West-Delhi-11006, have changed my name to Sushil Sharma, for all, future purposes. 0040870961-5

I, GINNI VIJRAY W/O LOVENEET KUMAR R/O A-180 OLD GUPTA COLONY NORTH WEST DELHI-110009 have changed my name VIJAY LAXMI for all future purpose 0071053009-1

I, Vijay Kumar Tuteja S/o Late Sh. B. D Tuteja, R/o 296-297, Pocket A-2, Near M2K, Rohini, Sector-8, Rohini, Delhi-110085 have changed my name to Vijay Tuteja for all purposes. 0040870818-4

I, Baljit Kaur W/o Gurcharan Singh, R/o WZ-283/269A, Street No-9, Vishnu Garden, Tilak Nagar, Delhi-110018, have changed my name to Baljeet Kaur. 0040870927-7

I, Keshri Gupta S/o Ram Baran R/o 1512, Khasha No.-104/1/G-7, Block-B, Baba Colony, Burari, Delhi-110084 have changed my name as KESHRI PRASAD GUPTA permanently. Keshri Prasad Gupta and Keshri Gupta both are same and one person. 0040870832-1

I, KM ARCHANA W/O VED PRAKASH, R/O-Plot No-39, Kh No-1040, 2nd Floor, Utsav Homes Guldhar-2nd, Sector-23, Sanjay Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-291002, have changed my name to ARCHANA CHAUDHARY 0040870916-8

I, Sunita Singh, alias Sheela, wife of Ajay Kumar, resident of F-106, Mangal Bazar, Laxmi Nagar, Delhi-110092, hereby declare that Sunita Singh and Sheela are one and the same person and that I shall be known as Sunita Singh, for all, future purposes. 0040870916-2

I, RAJENDER KUMAR S/o-Shri Ganga Ram R/o No-360, Vasant Enclave, VASANT VIHAR-1, DELHI-110057 have changed my name to RAJINDER KUMAR for all purpose. 0040870868-1

I, LOVENEET KUMAR S/O HARINDER KUMAR VIJRAY R/O-A-180 OLD GUPTA COLONY MODEL TOWN DR. MUHKERJEE NAGAR MODEL TOWN NORTH WEST DELHI-110009 have changed my name LOVENEET KUMAR VIJRAY for all future purpose 0071053012-1

I, ANAND BAWA, S/o Rajinder Singh Bawa, R/o, D-10/19, First Floor, MIG Flat Rohini, Sector-15 Delhi-110099, inform that my name ANAND SARUP SINGH BAWA and ANAD BAWA is same-person. 0040870927-9

I, GIRISH KUMAR ARANKAVI PAMACHANDRAN, S/O Late Shri Ramachandran Nair Chandralayam Narayan, R/O L-1, 402, Amrapali Golf Homes, Greater Noida West, U.P. 201301, changed my name to Girish Kumar AP 0050294767-1

I, Km. Soni Barola, W/O Rahul Gautam R/o Plot No-KA-322, Flat No. R4-07, 5th Floor, Sector-12, Pratap Vihar, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201009 have changed my name to Soni Barola. 0040870916-4

I, MUKESH RAGHAV, S/O-VEER SINGH RAGHAV, R/O-E3-407, BHARAT-CITY, INDRAPRASTH YOUNA GHAZIABAD UTTAR PRADESH-201003, HAVE CHANGED MY DAUGHTER'S NAME, FROM HARSIKA RAGHAV TO HARSHIKA RAGHAV. 0040870927-2

I, Pushpa W/o Vijender Kumar R/o E-1/148, Block-E-1, Nand Nagri, North East Delhi-110093, Confirm that my first marriage was with Rakesh Kumar, which ended in divorce by court order Year 1997. Subsequently, Year-2018, I was married to Vijendra Kumar in accordance with Hindu rites/Customs. Therefore, wherever name of my former husband, Rakesh Kumar, appears in records, it should be removed, and replaced with name of my present/lawful husband, Vijendra Kumar. Furthermore, my correct date of birth-12.05.1975 should be recorded in my husband's records in place of the previously listed date of birth, 18.04.1966. 0071053016-1

I, Kavita wife of Late Vijay Kumar R/O D-180, Rishi Nagar Rani Bagh Delhi-110034, Have changed my name from Kamlesh to Kavita for all Future Purpose. 0040870873-1

I, Pawan S/o Hukum Chand, R/o-362, Pocket-5, Sector-22, Rohini, Delhi-110086, have changed my name to Pawan Kumar Singhal 0040870961-2

I, Ananmay Gupta or Anitej Gupta S/o Pranjal Gupta R/o F-902, Golf Avenue-1, Sector-75, Noida Gautam Budh nagar UP 201301 have changed my name from Ananmay Gupta or Anitej Gupta to Archit Gupta. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Archit Gupta for all future purposes. 0071052994-1

I, Laxmi Bala, S/O Amarjeet Singh , Resident Of (Burari Delhi-110084), Hearby Declare That MyMother Name Is Recorded as Seema In My Class 10th Marksheet Whereas Her Name Is Recordedas Seema Chaudhary in Adhaar Card and other identity documcentI further declare that "Seema" and "Seema Chaudhary" are one and the same person. Thisdeclaration is made for my passport application and all other official purpose 0040870818-1

I, Prarthana A Masih, D/O Arun Kamil Masih, R/O, D-1/16 First Floor St Stephen Hospital Staff Quarter-4, Rajpur-Road, Civil Lines, Delhi-110054, have changed my name to Prarthana Masih. 0040870916-6

I, RAJINDER RANA, S/O DAL BAHADUR RANA, R/O SAMALKA SAMALKA VILLAGE DELHI-110037, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAJENDER RANA FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040870927-4

I, Neeatu Gupta W/o Rajesh Gupta R/O-7903 Vvip Address Raj Nagar Extension Ghaziabad have changed my name to Nitu Gupta. 0071053049-1

I, Davinder Singh Khurana S/o Tarlochan Singh, R/o Flat No.E/1-103, T.D.I City, Kingsbury Towar, Sec-59-60, Kundli, Sonapat, Haryana-310208, have changed my name to Davinder Singh. 0040870927-6

I, Isaraj Jan Ansari W/O Hanif Ansari R/O Plot No.1738, 12, Dayal Puram, Naubasta, Kanpur, Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-208021, have changed my name to Israt Jahan. 0040870170-2

I, Tajinder Pal Chawla, S/o Shri. Khairati Lal Chawla, Phase-I, House No.208A, Second-Floor, Vinobapuri, Near Centre-Market, Lajpat Nagar-II, New Delhi-110024, have changed my name to Tajinder Chawla with effect from 21.05.2012. Henceforth, I shall be known as Tajinder Chawla, for all purposes. 0040870813-1

I, K Chinna Raju Service No. 825476, NCE(E), Service at AIR FORCE HQ, VAYU BHAWAN, MOTILAL NEHRU MARG, NEW DELHI 110011. That my daughter's name is wrongly mentioned as SPRUTHI NANKU C in my service record but my daughter's actual name is K SPOORTHI NANKU. 0040870971-1

I, SUDEEP KUMAR, S/O-SURESH KUMAR YADAV, R/O-FLAT NO-UG-2 GROUND-FLOOR KAUSHAMBI, PLOT NO-D/56, VASUNDHARA GHAZIABAD-201012, UP, have changed my name to SUDEEP YADAV, for all future purposes. 0040870916-8

I, HARMANNAT SINGH SAWHNEY, S/O-JASMEET SINGH SAWHNEY, R/O- PLOT NO-6, FIRST-FLOOR, GYAN-KHAND-2, INDIRAPURAM, GHAZIABAD UTTAR PRADESH U.P.-201014, have changed My Name To HARMANNAT SAWHNEY, permanently. 0040870961-4

I, CHHANDINDAR OY CHODHURY W/O SH. PARTHA PRATHIM BHATTACHARYAYA R/O-27, POKKET-33, SECTOR-3, ROHINI, DELHI-110085 That my date of birth is wrongly mentioned in my 10th Class Certificate i.e. 14.12.1968 in place of 14.12.1967 That my actual and correct date of birth is 14.12.1967. 0071053005-1

I, Ramvati W/o Sh. Tejpal Singh, R/O H.No. 273/3, Gali No. 4, Shankar Marg, Mandawali Fazalpur, East Delhi, Delhi-110092 have changed my name to Rama Devi for all purposes. 0040870818-3

I, Mohammedsufiyan Mohd Jamil Sayyed S/O Jamil Sayyed R/O 1320/A, Muslim Ningapur Galli, Khanapur, Belgum, Karnataka-591302, have changed my name to Mohammed Sufiyan Jameerahmed Sayyed 0071053055-1

I, Hamza Ali Baqari, S/O-Furqan Haider, R/O-1-97, third floor back-side, muradi Road Battla, house Jamia-nagar, south Delhi-110025, have changed My Name to Hamza Ali Baquri for all purposes 0040870916-1

I, Ramesh Kumar S/o Sh. Dharam Singh R/O H.No. 881/25, Bhatnagar Colony, Jind, Haryana-126102 have changed my minor son name from Kartik to Kartik Kumar for all purposes 0040870978-2

LOST & FOUND

This is to inform the general public that the original ICSE Class X Marksheet in the name of Pranav Chaudhary, pertaining to the Indian Certificate of Secondary Education (ICSE) Examination, Passed in: 2020, bearing UID: 6840973, issued by Ingraham Institute English School, has been lost/misplaced. Despite diligent efforts, the document could not be traced and is therefore deemed lost. An application for the issuance of a duplicate marksheet is being submitted 0071053086-1

I, Virendra Singh R/o B1/58 Amrapali Dream Valley Techzone-4 Ek Murto Chowk Greater Noida West Gautam Buddha Nagar UP 201318, I have lost original documents (Builder Buyer's Agreement N089963) of Flat No. 910, Tower F6, Amrapali Centurian Park Terrace Home, Greater Noida West. 201318. 0040870884-1

I, Kavita wife of Late Vijay Kumar R/O D-180, Rishi Nagar Rani Bagh Delhi-110034, Have changed my name from Kamlesh to Kavita for all Future Purpose. 0040870873-1

I, Pawan S/o Hukum Chand, R/o-362, Pocket-5, Sector-22, Rohini, Delhi-110086, have changed my name to Pawan Kumar Singhal 0040870961-2

I, Ananmay Gupta or Anitej Gupta S/o Pranjal Gupta R/o F-902, Golf Avenue-1, Sector-75, Noida Gautam Budh nagar UP 201301 have changed my name from Ananmay Gupta or Anitej Gupta to Archit Gupta. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Archit Gupta for all future purposes. 0071052994-1

I, Laxmi Bala, S/O Amarjeet Singh , Resident Of (Burari Delhi-110084), Hearby Declare That MyMother Name Is Recorded as Seema In My Class 10th Marksheet Whereas Her Name Is Recordedas Seema Chaudhary in Adhaar Card and other identity documcentI further declare that "Seema" and "Seema Chaudhary" are one and the same person. Thisdeclaration is made for my passport application and all other official purpose 0040870818-1

I, Prarthana A Masih, D/O Arun Kamil Masih, R/O, D-1/16 First Floor St Stephen Hospital Staff Quarter-4, Rajpur-Road, Civil Lines, Delhi-110054, have changed my name to Prarthana Masih. 0040870916-6

I, RAJINDER RANA, S/O DAL BAHADUR RANA, R/O SAMALKA SAMALKA VILLAGE DELHI-110037, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAJENDER RANA FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040870927-4

I, Neeatu Gupta W/o Rajesh Gupta R/O-7903 Vvip Address Raj Nagar Extension Ghaziabad have changed my name to Nitu Gupta. 0071053049-1

I, Davinder Singh Khurana S/o Tarlochan Singh, R/o Flat No.E/1-103, T.D.I City, Kingsbury Towar, Sec-59-60, Kundli, Sonapat, Haryana-310208, have changed my name to Davinder Singh. 0040870927-6

I, Isaraj Jan Ansari W/O Hanif Ansari R/O Plot No.1738, 12, Dayal Puram, Naubasta, Kanpur, Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-208021, have changed my name to Israt Jahan. 0040870170-2

I, Keshri Gupta S/o Ram Baran R/o 1512, Khasha No.-104/1/G-7, Block-B, Baba Colony, Burari, Delhi-110084 have changed my name as KESHRI PRASAD GUPTA permanently. Keshri Prasad Gupta and Keshri Gupta both are same and one person. 0040870832-1

I, RAJENDER KUMAR S/o-Shri Ganga Ram R/o No-360, Vasant Enclave, VASANT VIHAR-1, DELHI-110057 have changed my name to RAJINDER KUMAR for all purpose. 0040870868-1

I, GIRISH KUMAR ARANKAVI PAMACHANDRAN, S/O Late Shri Ramachandran Nair Chandralayam Narayan, R/O L-1, 402, Amrapali Golf Homes, Greater Noida West, U.P. 201301, changed my name to Girish Kumar AP 0050294767-1

I, Km. Soni Barola, W/O Rahul Gautam R/o Plot No-KA-322, Flat No. R4-07, 5th Floor, Sector-12, Pratap Vihar, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201009 have changed my name to Soni Barola. 0040870916-4

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I, Davinder Singh Khurana S/o Tarlochan Singh, R/o Flat No.E/1-103, T.D.I City, Kingsbury Towar, Sec-59-60, Kundli, Sonapat, Haryana-310208, have changed my name to Davinder Singh. 0040870927-6

I, Isaraj Jan Ansari W/O Hanif Ansari R/O Plot No.1738, 12, Dayal Puram, Naubasta, Kanpur, Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-208021, have changed my name to Israt Jahan. 0040870170-2

I, Keshri Gupta S/o Ram Baran R/o 1512, Khasha No.-104/1/G-7, Block-B, Baba Colony, Burari, Delhi-110084 have changed my name as KESHRI PRASAD GUPTA permanently. Keshri Prasad Gupta and Keshri Gupta both are same and one person. 0040870832-1

I, RAJENDER KUMAR S/o-Shri Ganga Ram R/o No-360, Vasant Enclave, VASANT VIHAR-1, DELHI-110057 have changed my name to RAJINDER KUMAR for all purpose. 0040870868-1

I, GIRISH KUMAR ARANKAVI PAMACHANDRAN, S/O Late Shri Ramachandran Nair Chandralayam Narayan, R/O L-1, 402, Amrapali Golf Homes, Greater Noida West, U.P. 201301, changed my name to Girish Kumar AP 0050294767-1

I, Km. Soni Barola, W/O Rahul Gautam R/o Plot No-KA-322, Flat No. R4-07, 5th Floor, Sector-12, Pratap Vihar, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201009 have changed my name to Soni Barola. 0040870916-4

I, MUKESH RAGHAV, S/O-VEER SINGH RAGHAV, R/O-E3-407, BHARAT-CITY, INDRAPRASTH YOUNA GHAZIABAD UTTAR PRADESH-201003, HAVE CHANGED MY DAUGHTER'S NAME, FROM HARSIKA RAGHAV TO HARSHIKA RAGHAV. 0040870927-2

I, Pushpa W/o Vijender Kumar R/o E-1/148, Block-E-1, Nand Nagri, North East Delhi-110093, Confirm that my first marriage was with Rakesh Kumar, which ended in divorce by court order Year 1997. Subsequently, Year-2018, I was married to Vijendra Kumar in accordance with Hindu rites/Customs. Therefore, wherever name of my former husband, Rakesh Kumar, appears in records, it should be removed, and replaced with name of my present/lawful husband, Vijendra Kumar. Furthermore, my correct date of birth-12.05.1975 should be recorded in my husband's records in place of the previously listed date of birth, 18.04.1966. 0071053016-1

I, Kavita wife of Late Vijay Kumar R/O D-180, Rishi Nagar Rani Bagh Delhi-110034, Have changed my name from Kamlesh to Kavita for all Future Purpose. 0040870873-1

I, Pawan S/o Hukum Chand, R/o-362, Pocket-5, Sector-22, Rohini, Delhi-110086, have changed my name to Pawan Kumar Singhal 0040870961-2

I, Ananmay Gupta or Anitej Gupta S/o Pranjal Gupta R/o F-902, Golf Avenue-1, Sector-75, Noida Gautam Budh nagar UP 201301 have changed my name from Ananmay Gupta or Anitej Gupta to Archit Gupta. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Archit Gupta for all future purposes. 0071052994-1

I, Laxmi Bala, S/O Amarjeet Singh , Resident Of (Burari Delhi-110084), Hearby Declare That MyMother Name Is Recorded as Seema In My Class 10th Marksheet Whereas Her Name Is Recordedas Seema Chaudhary in Adhaar Card and other identity documcentI further declare that "Seema" and "Seema Chaudhary" are one and the same person. Thisdeclaration is made for my passport application and all other official purpose 0040870818-1

I, Prarthana A Masih, D/O Arun Kamil Masih, R/O, D-1/16 First Floor St Stephen Hospital Staff Quarter-4, Rajpur-Road, Civil Lines, Delhi-110054, have changed my name to Prarthana Masih. 0040870916-6

I, RAJINDER RANA, S/O DAL BAHADUR RANA, R/O SAMALKA SAMALKA VILLAGE DELHI-110037, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAJENDER RANA FOR ALL PURPOSES. 0040870927-4

I, Neeatu Gupta W/o Rajesh Gupta R/O-7903 Vvip Address Raj Nagar Extension Ghaziabad have changed my name to Nitu Gupta. 0071053049-1

I, Davinder Singh Khurana S/o Tarlochan Singh, R/o Flat No.E/1-103, T.D.I City, Kingsbury Towar, Sec-59-60, Kundli, Sonapat, Haryana-310208, have changed my name to Davinder Singh. 0040870927-6

I, Isaraj Jan Ansari W/O Hanif Ansari R/O Plot No.1738, 12, Dayal Puram, Naubasta, Kanpur, Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-208021, have

On rural jobs, the 60:40 dilemma



OFF THE RECORD
BY P VAIDYANATHAN IYER

NO STATE likes it when the Centre asks it to share a burden it never did in the past. More so in these times, when political parties have, in a race to the bottom, made fiscally unsustainable promises to win Assembly elections. Naturally then, states, particularly those ruled by the Opposition, threw a fit after the Centre suddenly changed the rules of the game and asked them this year to partly provide for the big-ticket National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme. For 20 long years, all states were happy when it was fully funded by the Centre — in the first 10 years by the UPA government after it launched the scheme in 2006, and later by the NDA government. Under the scheme, now rechristened as Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) or VB-G RAM-G, if a state requires Rs 100 crore in a year, the Centre will give Rs 60 crore from the Union Budget, and the state will give Rs 40 crore

from the state Budget. For Himalayan and Northeastern states, the Centre-state split is 90:10; for Union Territories without legislatures, the Centre will fully fund the scheme. Earlier, the Centre provided the entire amount of wages for all states. It is not just the Opposition, but also those where the BJP is in power, which feel the fiscal stress of the change in rules. They, too, complain, but in private, because the resource kitty is limited, significant expenditure remains sticky and inflexible, and they, too, have to make tough choices on how and where to spend the scarce revenues they earn. The opposition to the Centre's move is not just political, but social, economic and fiscal too. Political, understandably, because this was a flagship scheme introduced by the Congress but never seen as transformative by the BJP. Social, since it offered livelihood and a minimum income security to poor farmers and labourers who could not get any other job. Economic, because the NREGA wage acted like a floor, and NREGA job card holders leveraged it to deny work offers with wages lower than this. Fiscal, because states are perpetually strapped for cash. While the Finance Ministers of BJP states have little choice but to toe the national party line, those of Opposition states — Karnataka, Kerala, Telangana, Punjab, Tamil Nadu and Jharkhand — spoke out. In Budget speech after speech, they condemned the Centre for requiring them to take care of 40% expendi-

Given the states' opposition to the funding pattern of VB-G RAM-G, why would they make budget allocations? One, they have little choice. But more importantly, it is true the scheme has transformed the way the rural economy works

ture. Some wanted the Centre to uphold the principles of decentralised governance and rights of rural workers, others demanded restoration of 100% funding, and yet others threatened legal recourse. In his March 20 Budget speech, Telangana Finance Minister Bhatti Vikramarka Mallu said: "This is not just a scheme; it is an 'employment right' provided to the common person. Over the past two decades, this scheme has brought about a silent revolution in villages." Then Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah, who also held the Finance portfolio, was more frontal in his attack. "Our Government remains committed to pursuing all appropriate recourse, including legal measures, to safeguard the rights of rural workers and uphold the principles of decentralised governance," he said in his March 6 Budget speech. Every other Opposition state i.e., Tamil Nadu, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Punjab and Kerala, said the rule change is not right, and hurts rural worker's interests. All this makes for good optics in the political theatre. But despite the restrictions and new funding pattern, Opposition states have embraced realpolitik, and for good reasons. This shows in their budget allocation for VB-G RAM-G scheme in this financial year. In his Budget speech on August 5, Tamil Nadu Finance Minister N Marie Wilson said the state has made an "unprecedented" contribution of Rs 5,057 crore. This translates to exactly 40% of the total VB-G

RAM-G budget of Rs 12,642 crore for the state in 2026-27. Three other states provided 40% of their share: Karnataka Rs 3,806.61 crore (40% of Rs 9,516 crore), Telangana Rs 2,550.21 crore (40% of Rs 6,375 crore) and Jharkhand Rs 1,853 crore (40% of Rs 4,558 crore). Tamil Nadu, in fact, went a step ahead and said it will provide 150 days employment (25 days more than the VB-G RAM-G scheme) by bearing an extra expenditure of Rs 100 crore. Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan said he has allocated Rs 1,422 crore; this is just 27% of the Rs 5,226 crore VB-G RAM-G total estimated budget for the state) in the first phase, Punjab Rs 608 crore (27% of Rs 2,218 crore total estimated budget), and Himachal Rs 50.94 crore (4% of Rs 1,337 crore as against the required 10%). It is pretty certain states will provide fully for it during the course of the year. Given such strident opposition, why would all states do it? One, they have little choice. But more importantly, it is true the scheme has transformed the way the rural economy works, providing not just employment security, but wage security too. Nobody quite bothers about the Minimum Wages Act. But for this scheme, rural wages in states will collapse. States are, at the end of the day, putting their money where their mouth is.

The writer is Managing Editor, The Indian Express.
Off the Record is a fortnightly column

An ill wind blows



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

IF I were young and Indian, I would be in the Cockroach Janta Party. Ironically, for the same reasons that I once became a Modi Bhakt. Having spent my entire life in the shabby, squalid, socialist country that was created under successive Congress prime ministers, I supported Modi because I thought he would bring radical changes to rectify what had gone wrong. Among the things that had gone most wrong was the inexplicable lack of investment in the human capital of this ancient land. It should surprise no political pundit that the cockroaches made education their first cause. The trigger was the leak of NEET exam papers, but it was only a trigger. The condition of ordinary government schools across India is truly awful. Last week, if you were watching the news channels, you would have seen children in Madhya Pradesh leaping from one pillar to the next to cross a raging dam while going to school. This state has been governed by a 'double-engine' government for more than a decade. After the Jantar Mantar protest, schoolgirls in another BJP state took to the streets to say that their school had neither teachers, toilets or drinking water. I have seen rural schools where barefoot children come and sit in classrooms bereft of desks, chairs and textbooks. They come just to eat the mid-day meal. These meals are often cooked on primitive mud stoves in hovel-like, rodent-infested kitchens and many children get very sick from eating their midday meal, but for millions of Indian schoolchildren, this is the only real meal they get to eat.

Modi and his ministers like to boast about the millions of Indians they have freed from poverty in the past twelve years. But keep in mind that 800 million Indians receive free government foodgrain rations, and you will remember that there are millions more still shackled by poverty and degradation. When they come to the cities in search of jobs, they are forced to live in shacks in squalid shanties. The jobs they manage to get are usually of a menial kind, even if they have learned to read and write. But life is better here because little girls do not have to spend their mornings searching for water for the family.

When none of these ugly realities changed under Modi, I stopped being a devotee. From the recent protests, it is evident that millions of young Indians have also lost hope. Many would have come from homes where parents placed their own hopes in Modi and voted for him in three general elections. But older Indians seem able to absorb despair. Not so, the young. So, if I had been an Indian between the ages of eighteen and thirty, I would have been marching in step with the protesters. It now seems the RSS is also marching in step. It came as a pleasant surprise last week when its chief, Mohan Bhagwat, spoke out in open support of the protesters. He said, 'If Gen-Z and Gen-Alpha are protesting, it does not make them anti-national. They are more honest than older generations.' I am always wary of the RSS, but Bhagwat made an important speech. And the Prime Minister would do well to call him for chai and a private chat to seek his advice on how to move forward.

In his own attempts to sound sympathetic to the protesters, Modi has ended up saying too many things the wrong way and has inspired many memes of much higher quality than anything produced by the BJP's IT cell. The result is that the young people he is trying to reach continue to mock him with songs that are irreverent and hilarious. Nobody has laughed at Modi ever, so he has shown himself incapable of dealing with what is going on. His minions in the media are trying to help as best they can by mocking the Cockroach leaders on their nightly TV shows but to little effect. When minion anchor 'numero uno' screeched last week that he was proud of Modi's 'Indian accent', he just ended up looking like a goof. Then, as if the times were not bad enough, arrived that result from Bihar in which Prashant Kishor (PK), a hero of mine, ended up trashing the BJP in a constituency that was considered the impregnable fortress of the man who is now national president of the party. In the speeches he made after winning, PK talked of the need to improve education in Bihar. And he talked of the rampant corruption in our poorest state. The things he said could apply to most states in our proud and ancient land.

There is no question that for Modi, there is an ill wind blowing, but there is no sign yet that this will benefit the opposition parties when the next round of elections happens a few months from now. Every so-called leader in the INDIA bloc comes from privilege and entitlement, and every political party in it is little more than a private limited company. If there is any hope in this dismal time, it comes from young people who are unafraid to publicly declare that they are sick to death of what their country has become and they are there to change it. Modi's minions can screech about the cockroaches being funded by anti-India agents, but this rant is stale and old.



INSIDE TRACK | BY COOMI KAPOOR

LAMPPOSTS LEAVE LACUNAS

The education ministry will be under intense scrutiny in the wake of student protests, but Dharmendra Pradhan's successor, Pralhad Joshi, already has his plate full. He holds the portfolios for consumer affairs, public distribution, and new and renewable energy. There have now been 5 education ministers and 7 ministers of information and broadcasting under Prime Minister Modi, compared to relative continuity in other ministries, such as finance, defence and home. One reason for Joshi's hasty selection is his proximity to the RSS, which constantly interferes in the ministry, whether on curricula, appointments or educational institutes. Many apprehend that the BJP high command's cavalier, unilateral selection of senior positions has harmed the party's public perception. The surprisingly unsuitable CM picks in states such as Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Delhi and Bihar without democratic discussion, sometimes largely on caste calculations and electoral strategies, have begun to backfire. Prashant Kishor's spectacular win in BJP's Bankipur assembly bastion was a referendum against both Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and BJP President Nitin Nabin, both considered unsuitable choices. When an untested Nabin was named the president, many wondered whether senior experienced party organisers would be willing to work under him. Nabin failed in his first test as president — selecting the BJP candidate for his former constituency. Some compare the party's recent appointments to Indira Gandhi's hubris in the 1970s when she assumed that even a lamppost could win if propelled by her own popularity.

DIVIDED HOUSE

Also disturbing are the visible cracks in a party, which takes pride in its cadres' discipline. Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari's followers suspect he was deliberately targeted on the government's ethanol policy, even though it was not his decision, by enemies within, backed by the petroleum lobby. Influencers active in the anti-Gadkari campaign have earlier worked on some BJP election campaigns. Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde has complained repeatedly to the PM that Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis does not keep him in the loop. The universally respected Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav was taken aback to find that most of his personal staff had been replaced overnight. After his resignation, Dharmendra Pradhan was pointedly felicitated by senior colleagues, and he also met RSS General Secretary Dattatreya Hosabale. Some disgruntled BJP members felt UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath acted with unseemly haste in ordering an SIT to investigate the 'chanda chori' allegations at Ayodhya, without an FIR. In fact, the CM was conscious that his political opponents would try to gain mileage from the scandal in next year's assembly elections.

SUDDEN VULNERABILITY

The BJP government's sudden vulnerability after its brush with Generation Z is compared to the moment of truth during the 2024 poll results, when it found itself 32 MPs short of a majority. The ruling party made up lost ground and defied the odds to win a string of uncertain assembly elections, with Bengal its crowning triumph. But now the wheel of fortune appears to have turned against it, and there are signs of a more accommodating government outreach. It is not the traditional opposition parties that pose the real challenge, but a restless, aspirational young India. The BJP has lost ground in two spheres once considered its core strengths — youth leadership and communication. Potential BJP youth leaders have either been sidelined or have lost their fire after being co-opted into the system. After 12 years in power, the party's narrative builders appear arrogant and intimidating; their messages do not click with Gen Z. Pertinently, 52 per cent of our population is under 30. Caste and religious divides or direct doles may not be the magic mantra for future elections. Government accountability may matter most.

ART OF SPEAKING SOFTLY

Sunil Kanugolu, the McKinsey-trained poll analyst, usually accompanies Congress general secretary KC Venugopal for discussions on election strategy. A recent meeting with Punjab Congress leaders Charanjit Channi and Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa in Delhi did not go well. Venugopal, armed with the statistics supplied by Kanugo, rudely ticked off the two Punjab strongmen, claiming they overestimated their electoral clout. Such blunt speaking may work in South India, but the two proud Punjabis, one a former CM and the other a deputy CM, took offence and walked out of the room.

CLUBBED DOWN?

Delhi's hallowed Gymkhana Club has virtually stopped taking bookings for its premises for September. Shaken members fear their worst nightmare — the club's actual closure.

Sabiha Khanum

WHEN THE first copies of *Fractured Communities, Adivasi Histories and Power* arrived at our home, my husband and I opened the parcel together. We looked at the cover for a long time. It should have been a happy afternoon. Our son should have been there, signing a copy for us, smiling at our excitement. Instead, he remains in prison under UAPA, where he has spent nearly six years without his trial even beginning. Umar's book grew out of his doctoral research at Jawaharlal Nehru University. He submitted his thesis in July 2018. By then, he had already been charged with sedition, had already spent time in prison, and had been rusticated from the university he spent years at. I remember him writing whenever he could, fitting it around his arrest, vicious media trial, risks to his physical safety, and court hearings. Some people imagine a thesis as something produced in the comfort of libraries. His was written in the shadow of uncertainty, and the constant knowledge that his freedom is now conditional for life. In the book, Umar looks at the Adivasi communities of Singhbhum during British rule. He argues that they were never a single, unified group, but communities who responded to colonial rule in different ways; that their histories cannot be reduced to one narrative. Reading it now, I find myself thinking that this is true far beyond the history of Adivasi communities. For years, I have seen people reduce my son to whatever version of him suits them. Those who support him often see only one part of him. Those who oppose him see even less. This book, however, asks us to listen, and to allow complexity over binary and certainty. Ramachandra Guha, who wrote the foreword, describes it as one of the finest doctoral dissertations by an Indian scholar that he has read. As Umar's mother, I felt proud reading this. I wonder if I am proud of him for surviving these years in unlawful incarceration with such grace and courage or I am more proud of him for the words in front of me. No parent expects to measure their child's achievements against the passing years of incarceration. Yet that is what these years have become.

It makes me sad that Umar cannot step into a bookshop and see his own book. He cannot attend its launch or speak to its readers. But I am also happy to see that the book has begun its own journey. It can travel freely in ways its author cannot. I do not know what it means for a democracy when a man's scholarship can be published, praised, and read widely while the state that holds him has still not managed, after six years, to bring the case against him to trial. The waiting itself has become the punishment, regardless of what a court eventually decides. Not long ago, the Delhi High Court granted bail to a Kashmiri human rights activist, Parvez Khurram, who had spent four-and-a-half years in prison under the UAPA. The court said that the long period spent in custody, and the fact that his trial was unlikely to end soon, were important reasons to grant him bail. The bench was headed by the same judge who, only a few months earlier, had refused Umar bail. By then, Umar had already spent five years in prison without trial. Sharjeel Imam had spent even longer. In that order, the court said that the delay in trial was not enough to justify bail. How can the same law, before the same judge, lead to such different conclusions? The Supreme Court's own benches have disagreed with each other on this. One judgment questioned how a later ruling could be allowed to override the precedent set by KA Najeeb, which had held that when a person has already spent years in custody with no trial in sight, the harsher



In his book, Umar Khalid looks at the Adivasi communities of Singhbhum during British rule

provisions of the UAPA ought to give way, and the constitutional promise of liberty should take precedence. For those watching from outside, these may appear to be legal questions. For families like ours, they are measured in parents who grow frailer with every passing year, sisters who have celebrated one festival after another without their brother, nieces and nephews who have grown from toddlers into schoolchildren without ever knowing what it is like to have their uncle at home, and years that cannot be returned. I have come to believe that a democracy is judged not only by the laws it makes, but by how it treats those who live under them. It is judged by whether people are given a fair chance to defend themselves, by how long they are made to wait, and whether justice can still be served before a life has passed by. If you choose to read *Fractured Communities*, read it not only because its author is in prison, but because it is a serious work of scholarship. The conversation it begins about history, power and the lives of people we simplify too easily is enough for you to ask what kind of power structure keeps the author in jail for years without trial. Perhaps, in reading it, you may also come a little closer to the person who has so long been spoken about, by others in the ways they perceive him. By reading his book, you will get to listen to him in his own voice.

The writer is an entrepreneur

Before I do: What private eyes reveal about marriage

NOT ALL that long ago, arranging a marriage involved merely matching janampatris and horoscopes, gotras and castes. Families depended on relatives and chit-chat from their communities to veto a prospective spouse. Some amount of premarital due diligence is not new, but private investigators across India have reported a huge jump in enquiries for background checks post the Lohagad Fort tragedy. It turns out people are spooked by the story of 20-something Siya Goyal who allegedly pushed her fiancé Ketan Agarwal into a gorge. Today, the first question raised by either side is: has the bride or groom been verified? Fresh data reveals a profound sociological shift in that signs of dissipation are no longer presumed to be the sole preserve of men; women are being thoroughly scrutinised as well. Post Siya, a respectable family name is no longer a guarantee of having raised an innocent damsel of stellar character.

A quick Google search revealed the exhausting checklist agencies suggest in the age of online matrimony, beginning with identity fraud. This cynical approach may be the need of the hour, but I can't help but wonder how the young and hopeful wrap their heads around such depressing protocols. Should someone even be in the reckoning as a life partner if you can't be sure their Aadhaar and PAN Card are genuine? The agencies sternly warn against precisely this kind of starry-eyed sentimentality by stressing that verification isn't about suspicion — rather about making an informed decision, knowing the facts on hand. After perusing a private eye's financial and legal background questionnaire, I noticed with some alarm that I would have totally failed this test. Who, in their mispent youth, hasn't defaulted on a few credit card bills? Or, not got along with a boss? Maybe, even two-timed a bit. Goof-ups are part of growing up, and there's the thought that not everybody is super enthused by the pillar-of-society type.



ON THE LOOSE
BY LEHER KALA

If you really want to dig up dirt on somebody, it's not that difficult. Considering how normalised surreptitiously delving into potential partners' histories is, it's clear that it's only in our imaginations we believe that marriages are made in heaven. On earth, a canny instinct kicks in, telling us a background check will stand us in good stead. It's also true that for most of history, people have viewed marriage as a financial arrangement rather than a romantic ideal. As Jane Austen observed wryly in *Pride and Prejudice*, happiness in marriage is entirely a matter of chance. Deep knowledge of a partner's flaws does not necessarily guarantee a happy union; at best it makes for fewer unpleasant surprises. In a modern scenario, the saying 'forewarned is forearmed' has taken hold of our psyche. Today's young move in pursuit of careers, marry later and lead lives invisible to parents back home. It's the lifestyle between college and marriage that these agencies investigate for red flags, mainly to see whether someone's personality aligns with their claims.

No doubt, this determined quest for transparency stems from a place of existential self-protection; indeed, everyone needs to safeguard themselves from getting embroiled in the horrors of India's divorce courts. Risk mitigation — the process of planning and taking action to reduce potential threats — when applied to marriage sounds clinical and unromantic, maybe even wrong. It's saying, before a relationship has even begun, that emotions alone don't sustain anything. While that's true, as thinking, feeling human beings, it's hard to acknowledge that a new journey must begin with a deficit of trust, but that if one is willing to adjust the framing, it's possible to create something real. We tend to believe that the future of marriage will be more civilised than the past, having ironed out so many imperfections along the way. Much as we try to gather truths and reason our way through life, it's anybody's guess how things work out.

The writer is director, Hutkay Films

US reviews plan to end 60-day grace period for foreign workers to find new jobs

Press Trust of India
Washington, August 8

THE US is reviewing a proposal to eliminate the 60-day window for foreign workers holding non-immigrant visas to find employment after a job loss, a move that may force them to leave the country immediately.

A proposal from the Department of Homeland Security is currently under review at the federal Office of Management and Budget (OMB), according to its website.

If finalised, the proposed regulation would eliminate the 60-day grace period given to certain principal non-immigrants and their dependents if the principal's employment ceases before their period of stay expires. Further details of the proposal are not immediately known.

The 60-day grace period was introduced in 2017 to allow foreign workers and their dependents to stay in the US while searching for new employment after a job loss.

Immigration consultants said the Department of Homeland Security has the discretion to shorten or refuse the grace period, but has rarely done so.

It applies to E-1, E-2, E-3, H-1B, H-1B1, L-1, O-1 and TN categories of non-immigrant visa holders and their dependents.

IRGC SAYS U.S. ACCEPTANCE OF TEHRAN'S CONDITIONS KEY TO REOPENING THE STRAIT

Iran: Hormuz deal with Oman near, reopening hinges on US concessions

UAE says Tehran struck a ship in strait with a missile

Reuters
Cairo, Washington, Riyadh, August 8

IRAN SAID on Saturday that a deal with Oman on control of the Strait of Hormuz was close but would not be enough to free up the waterway, and the United Arab Emirates said Iran had hit another ship there.

Agreement between Iran and Oman over the strait is seen as vital to a wider deal to end the war that began with US and Israeli attacks on Iran on February 28 and led to Tehran establishing a chokehold over the major energy export route.

A US official, who declined to be identified, had said on Friday that Washington anticipated an agreement soon between Iran and Oman, which sit on either side of the strait, so that normal oil traffic could resume.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said Iran and Oman were "very close" to agreement on a new shipping route through the strait but that reopening it depended on other conditions, including US compensation to Iran.

The secretary of Iran's top national security body, Mohammad Bagher Zolqadr, listed other demands including ending US threats against Iran, stopping aggression against Iran and its Lebanese, Palestinian, Yemeni and Iraqi allies, lifting a blockade and sanctions on Iran and freeing Iranian assets.

Oman condemned what it described as repeated attacks on vessels while transiting the strait, without assigning blame, and said that negotiations with Iran on arrangements for shipping through Hormuz were "positive and constructive".

"Oman stresses the importance of avoiding any actions that could affect these negotiations and the progress achieved in a manner that takes into account the interests of all parties," the foreign ministry said.

Araghchi said the previous shipping traffic separation scheme through the strait was no longer acceptable to Tehran and that Iran was discussing a temporary route with Oman while technical and legal issues surrounding a permanent route were resolved.

Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian, a relative moderate, said he believed now was the best time for an agreement.

"There is cohesion, strength, and unity in the country, and as far as I know, Iran is considered victorious and powerful in this war," Iranian news agencies quoted him as saying.

Iran has responded to the US attacks by targeting US bases in Gulf states and Jordan as well as striking shipping in the strait.

The UAE said on Saturday that Iran had attacked a carrier affiliated with its state oil company with a missile as it transited the Strait of Hormuz, with no injuries reported, in the latest escalation in attacks on shipping there. There was no comment from Iranian authorities.

In recent weeks, the Trump administration has repeatedly signalled that a deal to open the strait could be close, only to have Iran deny that talks are under way. "Once the deal is announced to restore commercial shipping without impediments, the United States will lift the blockade of Iranian ports," the US official told Reuters on Friday. US actions would be tied to Iran's implementation of its commitments, he said.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards (IRGC), who have targeted ships, said on Saturday that reopening the Strait of Hormuz depended on Washington accepting Iran's conditions and was not related to the Iran-Oman negotiations.

"Whenever US accepts Iran's conditions, the Strait of Hormuz will certainly be reopened," said Guards spokesperson Hossein Mohebbi, according to Iran's Tasnim news agency.

A proposed deal between Iran and Oman to help the war between Iran and US would give Tehran control over ships entering the Gulf through strait, a senior Iranian source and two regional officials told Reuters Wednesday, one of the biggest concessions yet to Iran.



People gather on beach as commercial ships anchor off Bandar Abbas in Iran on Saturday. AP

hoods and a sprawling displaced persons' camp near the city of Marib, killing two people and injuring 14 others, including children, according to Yemeni government.

On Saturday, Majed al-Nuzaili, a spokesman for Yemeni military, said that its forces had "carried out military action against terrorist elements" of the Houthi militia in several areas. He did not provide further details.

The Yemeni government, backed by Saudi Arabia, has been at war with the Houthis since 2014, when the group seized Yemen's capital, Sanaa, with Iranian support. A year later, Saudi Arabia led a military coalition in support of the government, but its devastating bombing campaign ultimately failed to oust the Houthis from power.

Since then, Yemen has been effectively divided into two states, with the Houthis in control of large swaths of the north. Observers fear that a fragile truce hatched in 2022 has now all but collapsed. A sustained Houthi push into Yemen's resource-rich eastern regions would threaten the government's economic lifeline and risk triggering a fresh humanitarian crisis among millions of vulnerable Yemenis.

The fighting in Yemen has taken on broader significance amid the war that the United States and Israel launched against Iran in late February.

The conflict prompted Iran's allies in the region, like the Houthis in Yemen and Hezbollah in Lebanon, to mount their own attacks.

NYT

Yemen on brink of civil war as regional tensions mount

Ismaeel Naar & Aaron Boxerman
Dubai, Jerusalem, August 8

THE INTERNATIONALLY recognized government of Yemen said its forces had retaliated on Saturday against Iran-backed Houthi rebels after days of attacks on the military, the latest in a surge of fighting that threatens to tip the country back into full-scale civil war.

The escalation reflected how the stability of the Middle East now hangs in the balance across multiple fronts. Despite a lull in fighting between the United States and Iran, the region is waiting to learn whether a deal can be finalized to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, and stave off another round of conflict.

The Yemeni government's counteroffensive follows a rapid escalation that began two days ago, when the Houthis struck military positions in the oil and gas-rich provinces of Marib and Hadramout, killing at least 17 soldiers.

The violence persisted Friday, with Houthi attacks reported on civilian neighborhoods.

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Since then, Yemen has been effectively divided into two states, with the Houthis in control of large swaths of the north. Observers fear that a fragile truce hatched in 2022 has now all but collapsed. A sustained Houthi push into Yemen's resource-rich eastern regions would threaten the government's economic lifeline and risk triggering a fresh humanitarian crisis among millions of vulnerable Yemenis.

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NYT

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NYT

Zelenskyy visits Moscow ally Serbia as Russian strikes near Kyiv kill four

Associated Press
Belgrade, August 8

PRESIDENT VOLODYMYR Zelenskyy denounced Russia's latest deadly attacks on Kyiv on Saturday as he visited Serbia, one of the few European countries that has maintained friendly relations with Moscow throughout invasion of Ukraine.

Four people, including a child, were killed in the overnight strikes on Kyiv and the surrounding region. Ukrainian forces hit Russian oil facilities.

Zelenskyy arrived in Belgrade on Friday for his first official visit to Serbia.

Speaking at a press conference in Belgrade with Zelenskyy, Serbian President Aleksandar Vucic described Ukraine as a "friendly nation" and said he was honored to welcome the Ukrainian leader — the first visit by a Ukrainian president in eight years.

The two leaders discussed their countries' efforts toward joining the EU, bilateral ties and ways to expand cooperation.

Vucic, who has maintained close ties with Moscow and refused to sanction Russia over the invasion, drawing pressure from the EU to change course, reiterated Serbia respects Ukraine's territorial integrity and said that position would not change.

"The situation in Ukraine is difficult," Zelenskyy said at the press conference. "There was another missile strike last night — ballistic missiles targeting our infrastructure. There were also attack drones."

Zelenskyy said that deliveries of Patriot air defense interceptors — the sole air defense weapon in Ukraine's arsenal able to shoot down ballistic missiles — have slowed compared with a year ago. "There are fewer of these missiles in 2026. In 2025 there were more, I'll tell you honestly, in terms of monthly supplies," he said.

Zelenskyy said Washington has agreed to let Ukraine manufacture its own Patriot air defense interceptors, but are "stuck dealing with paperwork."



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy with Serbian President Aleksandar Vucic in Belgrade on Saturday. AP

US senate confirms Trump ally Blanche as Attorney General after narrow vote

Associated Press
Washington, August 8

THE SENATE confirmed Todd Blanche as attorney general in a vote early Saturday, cementing the command of President Donald Trump's former personal lawyer at a Department of Justice that Trump has sought to bend to his will.

The Republican-led Senate voted 50-49 to make Blanche the second confirmed attorney general since Trump returned to the White House last year with a stated desire to use the law enforcement agency to investigate his political enemies.

While Blanche has already been leading the department in an acting capacity, his confirmation could free him to pursue the administration's agenda even more aggressively.

Blanche said on social media that he was "deeply honored by the trust and confidence President Trump has placed in me," adding that he was "grateful" to senators for working late to confirm him.

The vote followed a tumultuous confirmation fight that exposed deep concerns — from some Republicans as well as Democrats — about installing Trump's close ally atop a Justice Department that historically prided itself on its independence from the White House.



Attorney General Todd Blanche

• BRIEFLY

TAIWAN

President Lai oversees coastal strike exercise during annual war games



President Lai Ching-te during Han Kuang drills in Kaohsiung. REUTERS

TAIWAN PRESIDENT Lai Ching-te oversaw coastal strike drills on Saturday during annual war games, boarding a fast attack missile boat and watching the deployment of low-flying attack drones to simulate beating off a Chinese assault. "The purpose of the Han Kuang exercise is to use live troops, live terrain and live equipment to test command coordination, combat responsiveness and homeland defence capabilities," he said. In face of "external threats and challenges", the government will continue to work to strengthen defence capabilities, Lai said. REUTERS

CONGO

IS-linked group kill at least 13 in village attack

MILITANTS AFFILIATED with the Islamic State group attacked a village in Congo near the border with Uganda early Saturday, killing at least 13 people and burning and looting homes, a local civil society group said. Marie-Noelle Anotane, the head of the New Civil Society of Congo/Mambasa said that the Allied Democratic Forces, or ADF, were behind the violence. AP

CANADA

Fast-moving wildfire forces 20,000 to flee

MORE THAN 20,000 people were ordered to leave their homes in western Canada as a fast-moving wildfire grew rapidly and raced toward towns along British Columbia's Okanagan Lake, destroying homes in its path. The entire community of Summerland, home to about 12,000 people, was ordered evacuated, along with about 8,000 people in and around nearby Peachland. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

SRI LANKA

3 inmates killed, over 20 injured in fresh prison riots

THREE INMATES were killed and 23 others injured in separate clashes at two prisons in Sri Lanka over the past 24 hours, officials said Friday. "The immediate trigger for appears to have been detection of a package containing narcotics and subsequent arrest. It is evident it was response to government's anti-narcotics drive," Justice Minister Harshana Nanayakkara told reporters. PTI

PAKISTAN

3 injured after drone attack in KPK province

At least three people were injured in a quadcopter attack in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan on Saturday, police said. The incident occurred in Ghwa Khwah area of Wana tehsil in Lower South Waziristan district of the province. The injured were shifted to the District Headquarters Hospital in Wana for treatment, the police added. PTI

US plans \$1bn security aid for Colombia's new govt

Reuters
Washington, August 8

THE US State Department said on Friday that President Donald Trump's administration plans to provide \$1 billion in security assistance to government of Colombia's new right-wing President Abelardo De La Espriella.

"As a cornerstone of this renewed partnership, the United States, working with Congress, intends to announce \$1 billion in assistance as part of a security package to support President De La Espriella's Administration in achieving our shared goals," the State Department said in a statement.

Colombia's new president, who has promised a crackdown on crime and an economic revival, was sworn in on Friday. Trump had endorsed him during the elections.

The State Department said the Trump administration welcomed Colombia into the



Colombia's President Abelardo de la Espriella salutes after taking the oath of office in Cali, Colombia on Friday. AP

"Shield of the Americas," a Trump-created military alliance of right-wing leaders pledging to fight drug trafficking.

Trump has moved to increase US presence and influence in Latin America.

He ordered the seizure of ousted Venezuelan leader Nicolas Maduro in a deadly raid and the US military has carried out multiple strikes on alleged drug boats in the Caribbean that have killed dozens.

• NEARLY 10,000 PUNJABI SOLDIERS WHO DIED IN WORLD WAR I HAVE BEEN ADDED TO CASUALTY RECORDS FOR THE FIRST TIME

They died unrecognised in Britain — a century later, their sacrifice is being honoured

Leo Sands
London, August 8

THE YOUNG soldier died fighting for Britain, yet for over a century he did not appear on the country's official list of war dead.

According to his family, Kesa Singh left his village in India — a British colony at the time — to fight in what is now Iraq during World War I. He never returned, and few details of his life and military service were known beyond the memories of his wife and two young sons.

That changed this summer, when Singh became one of nearly 10,000 Punjabi soldiers whom researchers identified as having died for Britain in that war without being recognized for it by authorities — result of

bureaucratic failings historians say reflected views of colonial administrators toward non-British troops from their empire.

"These men served honestly, they died sadly, and they weren't afforded the same treatment as the other men whom they served alongside," said Aman-deep Madra, a British historian and chair of the UK Punjab Heritage Association, who helped lead the research effort.

Half a million Punjabi soldiers took part in the grueling Mesopotamia campaign from 1914 to 1918, battling the Ottoman Turks to capture modern-day Iraq and its strategic oil fields for the British Empire. About 1.4 million soldiers from the Indian subcontinent served in the British Indian Army during the war.

For more than a century, the officials maintained careful casualty lists of British troops who were killed in the two world wars, more than 1 million in total. But the same efforts were not afforded to over 100,000 soldiers and other personnel who died for the crown but hailed from colonies in Asia and Africa.

The handwritten names of the group of Punjabi soldiers were uncovered in archives at the Lahore Museum in Pakistan, which revealed their identities, their hometowns and in some cases the circumstances of their deaths.

The discovery is the result of a years long effort by historians and British authorities to address racial inequities in how the country has commemorated its war dead. The push comes amid a wider reckoning among British institutions with the legacies of the empire.

For the descendants of Kesa Singh, his recognition corrects an omission in the historical record. "I feel a bit more complete," said his great-grandson Dr. Inder Singh Palahey, a dentist from Leicester, England, who researched his ancestor's fate for



Sikh and British servicemen in Southampton in November 1914. UKPHA

years without finding answers.

According to the newly unearthed records, Singh died from combat wounds sustained in Ottoman territory as he traveled home with his regiment. The records did not specify his age or date of death.

His omission stemmed from a combination of discriminatory attitudes and the practical challenges of record-keeping in a military conflict that spanned three continents, said George Hay, the official historian at the Commonwealth War Graves Commission, which was established in 1917 to list and commemorate the deaths of service members who fought for Britain in the two world wars.

Hay's predecessors had tried to obtain the names of fallen Indian soldiers, he said, but they were rebuffed by colonial administrators who seemed unable or unwilling to produce complete lists in the immediate aftermath of the war.

Another challenge was inconsistent rules for which deaths counted as war casualties. Unlike their British counterparts, Indian service members who died outside the conflict zone — including from injuries or disease sustained in combat — were not considered by authorities to be worthy of commemoration, Hay said.

The lack of official recognition was partly because of racism, an inquiry found in 2021.

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hore Museum. With the help of archivists, historians at the University of Greenwich and volunteers at the Punjab heritage association, researchers were able to digitize the collection and cross-reference the list with the Commonwealth War Graves Commission's records.

After screening for duplications, the researchers identified 9,909 soldiers from the historical Punjab state who died in World War I but did not appear on the official list.

After verifying the names, the commission added them to its register last month, the largest single update to its casualty record in 80 years. Hay said the commission would seek to place the names on some form of physical memorial.

NYT

‘THE CENTRAL BANK WANTS TO BUY MORE TIME AS GROWTH, INFLATION TRAJECTORY IS NOT CLEAR’

‘RBI’s focus on core inflation is slightly confusing for markets’

INDIAN MARKETS have been left “confused” by the Reserve Bank of India’s (RBI’s) focus on inflation excluding food, fuel, and precious metals in its monetary policy decision on Wednesday, according to Murthy Nagarajan, Head of Fixed Income at Tata Asset Management. “RBI has said it is looking at headline inflation. But the language which has been used shows that it is looking at core inflation,” Nagarajan told **Siddharth Upasani** in an interview. He also discussed how the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) may act in the future and Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits possibly touching \$100 billion. *Edited excerpts:*

Do you agree with the view the RBI was unexpectedly dovish in its latest meeting?

Yes. Just a week ago, the governor gave an interview where he made similar statements. So, the market was expecting this to be a dovish policy. But the way in which he spoke on Wednesday was still a surprise. While he was expected to talk about inflation, he has changed the context. Now the general view is that the RBI is looking at core in-

flation and core inflation excluding precious metals, which is projected to rise from around 2.5% and move towards 4%. If that is the case and 4% is the target, the feeling is that most probably in our view there will not be any rate hikes in 2026-27.

It is slightly confusing for the market. My reading is that because there is so much uncertainty, the RBI wants to keep the powder dry right now.

Moreover, FPI flows into debt have been strong and FCNR(B) inflows could be \$80 billion-\$90 billion at least and possibly touch \$100 billion. In this situation, there doesn’t seem to be a worry about forex. Back in February, the view was that Brent oil prices will go below \$70 per barrel. If we were to move towards that, should things clear up, then there may not be a need to hike rates. And if growth is strong, equity inflows can start coming back.

Is the MPC actually targeting core inflation excluding precious metals and the headline number is only a target on paper?

Yes. But, from the RBI’s perspective, it does not know when the war will end, there was a 40% rainfall deficit in June and



11% or so now. Oil prices are another uncertainty — so it is really difficult to take a call. It’s difficult to make predictions even in a normal environment.

I think the RBI also wants to defer its interest rate decision because if headline inflation is forecast to be above 5% for three consecutive quarters starting Q3 this year, then you should have hiked now — one-year forward, inflation is projected at 5.3% and the repo rate is 5.25% right now. So, you are in a negative real interest rate territory. The only way you can justify that is by focusing on core inflation. Essentially, the RBI wants to buy more time because the growth and inflation trajectory is not clear. Ob-

viously, we are required to stabilise interest rates; whether it should be done now or after six months, that is the question. I think the RBI has taken a call that it’ll be prudent to do it after six months. They have first decided they don’t want to hike rates and then looked at the (reasons).

RBI has said it is looking at headline inflation. But the language which has been used shows that it is looking at core inflation. I think over the next 3-6 months they will start looking at headline inflation and make a decision.

Apart from the forecast of 5%+ inflation, the RBI’s assessment of growth is encouraging. And yet it is dovish. Is there some policy inconsistency?

For us sitting in India, it almost feels like there is no war going on: growth seems to be strong, fiscal deficit numbers look good, and there is strong credit growth — it does not feel like the first quarter of a financial year, when there is normally some slack.

I think the RBI has got time to normalise interest rates. They have said any excess liquidity will be taken out over

a period of time because it has a forward book of around \$100 billion right now. Forex reserves may be around \$692 billion, but \$100 billion of that is gold and another \$20 billion or so are the Special Drawing Rights and the Reserve Position in the IMF. You remove all that and it’s around \$550 billion. And you can’t have a forward position which is more than 20% of that; it can’t be that high.

If you want to control inflation, the best way is through money supply. I think the RBI will squeeze money supply if inflation goes above 5-5.5% and the operating rate may be 5.5-5.75% even if the repo rate stays at 5.25%. The RBI has the tools to do that. What also matters is the potential growth rate: is it 7% or 8%? Nobody knows, because the GDP series is new. If you think it’s 7.5-8%, then there is some amount of slack if you are growing at 6.7%, which is the RBI’s forecast for 2026-27.

If the RBI thinks there is some slack in the economy, then it may not have to hike rates as much and 50 bps in 2026-27 may be enough. I think it will start raising the repo rate in December.

FULL INTERVIEW ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Participation of mining operators sought to push uranium output

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 8

THE CENTRE should come up with a policy roadmap to ensure the participation of mine developer-cum-operators (MDO) in uranium mining, a Parliamentary committee has suggested, amid concerns that India’s domestic uranium production may not be enough to meet the future fuel requirements of its indigenous pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWRs).

The panel also recommended that any MDO participation in the sector should remain under the strict oversight of the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE). An MDO is a contractor engaged by the mine lease holder, typically a government or public-sector entity, to develop and operate the mine and undertake mining activities on its behalf.

The recommendations come at a time when the country seeks to expand its civil nuclear power capacity from the current 8.7 gigawatt-electric (GWe) to 100 GWe by 2047.

India’s indigenous PHWRs use natural uranium. And their fuel requirements are currently met through a combination of domestic production from state-owned Uranium Corporation of India Ltd (UCIL) mines and imports. Enriched uranium used in the two light water reactor (LWR) variants — Tarapur Nuclear Power Plant and Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant — is entirely imported.

UCIL, which alone has the mandate to mine and process uranium ore in the country, operates multiple underground and open-pit mines with processing plants in Jharkhand and Andhra Pradesh, and sends uranium concentrate to National Fuel Complex (NFC) for fuel fabrication for reactors operated by state-owned Nuclear Power Cor-

● **MINING ROADMAP**

THE RECOMMENDATION by a Parliamentary Committee comes at a time when the country seeks to expand its civil nuclear power capacity from the current 8.7 GWe to 100 GWe by 2047

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MINE DEVELOPER-cum-operator (MDO) is a contractor engaged by the mine lease holder, typically a government or public-sector entity, to develop and operate the mine and undertake mining activities on its behalf

poration of India Limited’s (NPCIL). “As per NPCIL’s capacity expansion trajectory, PHWRs alone could require approximately 5,400 tonnes U3O8 (uranium oxide, or yellowcake) per annum for about 25 GWe, while UCIL currently estimates catering to about 30% of this need,” the panel on public undertakings noted.

The panel said this would imply continued reliance on imports unless domestic uranium production is accelerated and supply sources are diversified.

‘Expedite acquisition global uranium assets’

The parliamentary panel also noted that India currently imports uranium from Kazakhstan, Russia, Uzbekistan and Canada, with the long-term supply contract with Uzbekistan valid until 2026. The panel sought an update on the government’s plans to secure long-term uranium supplies from Uzbekistan beyond 2026. “The Committee believes that establishing strategic uranium stockpiles, calibrated to refueling cycles and

● **BRIEFLY**

Diageo’s whisky aging claim misleading: Govt

New Delhi: The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) warned liquor giant Diageo that it misleadingly claimed one of its top-selling whiskies was “matured in American oak casks”, when most of the product had not been matured, a confidential government notice shows. The previously unreported July 20 notice from the FSSAI, reviewed by *Reuters*, reveals another complaint by the regulator, in addition to an assertion of improper flavouring that prompted the authorities to ban some spirits this month. **REUTERS**

Aditya Birla Fashion reports Rs 249 cr Q1 loss

New Delhi: Aditya Birla Fashion and Retail Ltd (ABFRL) on Saturday reported widening of its consolidated net loss to Rs 248.73 crore for June quarter FY27. The company had

outage risks, is essential to sustaining reactor operations during supply disruptions,” it noted.

The panel sought a comprehensive report from the DAE on the timelines for the UCIL-NTPC joint venture and plans for future fuel sourcing and the proposed framework for MDO participation in domestic uranium mining under DAE oversight. DAE also informed the panel that it is pursuing an amendment to the MMDR Act to allow a one-time extension of mining leases for uranium minerals by up to 10% of the existing lease area. The proposed change is aimed at addressing instances where newly identified or deeper extensions of ore bodies extend beyond existing lease boundaries.

Under the current framework, such extensions require separate leases and clearances, which can affect the techno-economic viability of projects, particularly for deposits located at depths beyond 600 metres. According to the panel, Atomic Minerals Directorate for Exploration and Research (AMD) has established about 4,31,000 tonnes of in-situ uranium oxide resources, but only about 80,423 tonnes have been transferred to UCIL under the provisions of Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act (MMDR) and the Atomic Minerals Concession Rules.

Of this, 39.22% has already depleted, leaving about 60.78% currently available. At current production rates, these reserves can last about 40 years if no new reserves are added, it noted.

The panel also noted that UCIL faces challenges including ore body depth, low ore grades, land acquisition hurdles, public resistance and tailings management, which could affect production schedules.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NBFC gold loan growth touches 69% in June, industry credit slows

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, August 8

CREDIT AGAINST gold jewellery extended by non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) surged 69.3% year-on-year to Rs 3.41 lakh crore in June 2026, emerging as the fastest-growing major retail lending segment, according to data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

Gold-loan growth by NBFCs accelerated sharply from 40.6% in June 2025, even as overall credit growth by NBFCs, including housing finance companies (HFCs), rose to 14.4% in June 2026 from 11.1% a year earlier. The surge in gold prices has prompted people to pledge gold holdings for the finance requirements.

The RBI data show that outstanding credit extended by NBFCs stood at Rs 59.31 lakh crore at the end of June 2026, compared with Rs 51.86 lakh crore in June 2025.

The figures are based on a sample covering NBFCs in the Upper and Middle Layers and HFCs, accounting for about 87% of total NBFC credit.

Almost all NBFCs, led by Muthoot Finance, in the Upper Layer category of the RBI are active in the gold loan business.

Retail lending remained the key driver of the expansion, with growth accelerating to 20.3% in June 2026 from 14.35% a year earlier.

Outstanding retail credit increased to Rs 25.62 lakh crore from Rs 21.29 lakh crore, RBI said. Within retail lending, loans against gold jewellery recorded the sharpest growth at 69.3%. Consumer durable loans also expanded rapidly, rising 46.8% year-on-year, while vehicle loans grew 15.2%. Housing



The surge in gold prices has prompted people to pledge gold holdings for the finance requirements. **REUTERS**

loans, including lending by HFCs, grew 11.4% to Rs 8.44 lakh crore.

The acceleration in retail lending was accompanied by stronger growth in credit to agriculture and allied activities. Credit to the sector grew 179% in June 2026, sharply up from 5.1% a year earlier. Outstanding credit to agriculture and allied activities stood at Rs 79,684 crore, RBI said.

In contrast, credit growth to industry moderated.

Industrial credit grew 6.7% year-on-year in June 2026, compared with 10.3% in June 2025. The moderation was primarily driven by subdued growth in infrastructure, the RBI said. Infrastructure credit grew 5.1% during the period, against 9.7% a year earlier.

Within infrastructure, credit to the power sector expanded 4.9%, it said.

Credit growth in the services sector also moderated, although it remained relatively

strong at 17.6% in June 2026, compared with 22.4% a year earlier. Commercial real estate was a notable exception, with credit rising 33.8% year-on-year to Rs 1.11 lakh crore.

Growth in credit to trade and transport operators, however, moderated to 17.1% and 9.8%, respectively.

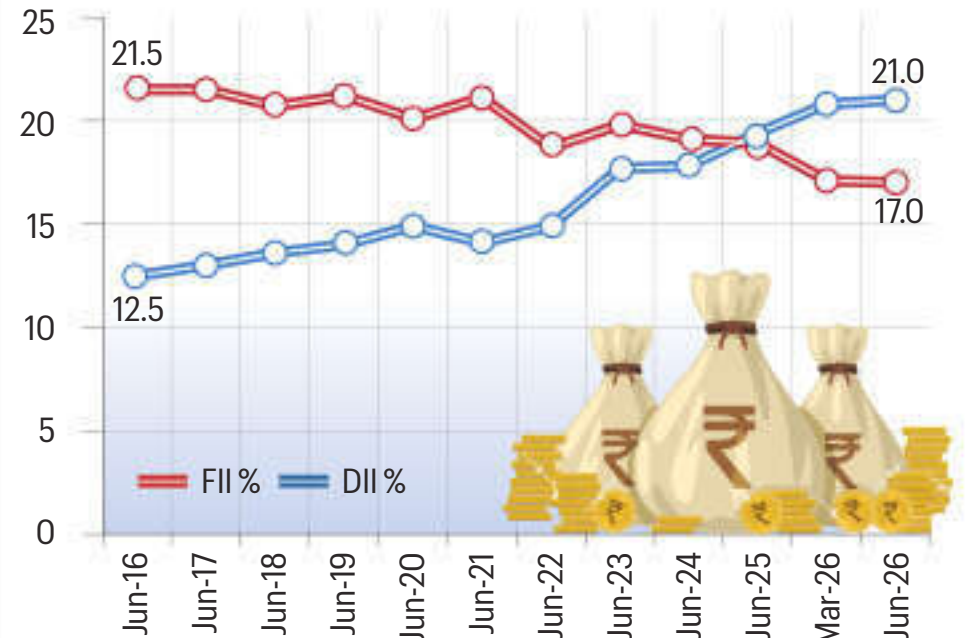
The RBI data also showed a reversal in the “other loans” category, which grew 17.5% year-on-year in June 2026, compared with a contraction of 19.5% a year earlier.

The central bank said the sectoral credit data are provisional and based on information reported by the sampled entities on the last day of the month.

The sample covers NBFCs in the Upper and Middle Layers and HFCs and accounts for about 87% of total NBFC credit, based on the benchmark cited in the RBI’s Report on Trend and Progress of Banking in India 2024-25.

● **DII holding in large companies up for 9th quarter**

Domestic institutional investors (DIIs) increased their ownership share in India’s biggest companies to 21% at the end of June, up from 20.8% at the end of March and 19.4% in June 2025. Meanwhile, the share of foreign institutional investors (FIIs) in Nifty 500 companies declined to 17%



● According to Motilal Oswal Financial Services, while FIIs have pulled out a net \$58 billion since September 2024 due to geopolitical uncertainties, cooling earnings growth, and elevated valuations, DIIs have pumped in a massive \$166 billion. ● Retail participation has been “resilient”, with around \$3 billion worth of money flowing in on average every month just from Systematic Investment Plans, or SIPs.

SOURCE: MOTILAL OSWAL FINANCIAL SERVICES

Govt examining Meta’s recommendation system

New Delhi: The Centre’s meetings with Meta have brought into focus a key question — whether the social media giant’s recommendation systems and paid content promotion fit in its status as an intermediary, government sources said adding the key issue is whether the company complies with the provisions under the IT Act or crosses into the role of a publisher by deciding “what content is shown to whom”.

Sources further said that the issue centres on whether a platform that actively decides what users see, can continue to claim intermediary status

under the Information Technology Act.

The issue assumes significance because Section 79 of the IT Act grants intermediaries a “safe harbour” from liability for third-party content, subject to compliance with the provisions of the law and due diligence requirements.

Sources said if Meta’s recommendation systems determine “what is shown to whom” and also “promote content for payment”, it raises the question of whether such functions are consistent with the legal definition of an intermediary. **PTI**

● **THE SANTA FE COURT RULED ON THURSDAY THAT META MUST PAY \$567 MILLION INTO A NEW MEXICO FUND FOR TEEN MENTAL HEALTH PREVENTION AND TREATMENT**

How New Mexico’s \$567 million ruling could reshape Meta’s platforms

Reuters
New York, August 8

A NEW Mexico state court ordered Meta Platforms, owner of Facebook and Instagram, to make major changes to its platforms and pay the largest sum yet in a growing wave of US litigation over claims that social media harms young people.

Here is a look at the decision and its potential consequences.

How much must Meta pay?

The court in Santa Fe ruled on Thursday that Meta must pay \$567 million into a New Mexico fund for teen mental health pre-

vention and treatment.

In an earlier phase of the case, a jury awarded New Mexico \$375 million on related consumer protection claims.

The combined \$942 million far exceeds other penalties in youth-related social media cases including a \$6 million verdict against Meta and Alphabet’s, Google, owner of YouTube, in a California case in March.

Meta said the claims misrepresented the facts and that it will appeal the ruling.

What did the court order Meta to change?

Judge Bryan Biedscheid in Santa Fe ordered Meta to im-

plement measures for users in New Mexico intended to protect youth on Facebook and Instagram. The ruling does not affect other states.

Meta must introduce more stringent age verification, restrict users under 18 to no more than 90 hours a month and shut off push notifications overnight and during school hours. Parents must consent to the number of “likes” on a child’s post being shown, the ruling said.

Meta must also ban sexualized chatbot interactions with minors and blur images suspected of containing nudity.

The judge rejected some of the changes New Mexico requested, including modifica-



New Mexico court directs Meta to strengthen protections for teens on Facebook and Instagram. **REUTERS**

tions to Meta’s algorithms and features such as infinite scroll and autoplay videos. The company said during the trial that

some changes the state sought were not technologically possible and could force it to exit the state.

What was the basis of the judge’s decision?

Biedscheid ruled that Meta created a public nuisance, agreeing with New Mexico’s claims that Facebook and Instagram were designed in ways that addicted young users and did not adequately protect them from sexual exploitation.

Reuters last year reported on company documents that showed Meta’s AI chatbots could “engage a child in conversations that are romantic or sensual.”

The judge rejected Meta’s call to dismiss the case under Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act, which generally shields online platforms from liability over user content.

What is a public nuisance?

Public nuisance claims traditionally have been used in cases involving threats to public health or safety, such as pollution. More recently, governments have brought them in lawsuits against companies that sold or marketed tobacco and opioids.

In the New Mexico case, the judge found that the harms from Meta’s platforms extended beyond individual users and imposed broader costs on families, schools, hospitals and law enforcement.

Meta argued at trial that it had not violated any public right such as access to air

or water, that its social media platforms are not the only ones used by the state’s young residents and that the case ignored the impact of other apps.

How does this affect other cases?

The New Mexico case does not directly impact thousands of other pending lawsuits by children and families or public nuisance claims by more than 40 states and 1,300 school districts. But New Mexico Attorney General Raúl Torrez has called the decision a “blueprint” for governments seeking to force changes on social media platforms through the courts.

BRIDGE

Hoping for the Best" is a recurrent theme in these columns- particularly hoping for the best when everything seems to be going wrong. In such cases take care to see that whatever assumptions are made by you are consistent with the bidding and play of the cards till then.

DEALER: East

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ J53	♥ Q852	♠ AK1042	♥ A74
♦ AQJ6	♣ A3	♦ K8	♣ KQ2

SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
1♣	pass	2♦	pass
3NT	pass	4♣	pass
5♣	pass	5♣	pass
6♣	pass	pass	pass

Club six, ace, five, deuce. Spade three, six, ace, heart nine. Plan the play. There are times to be prepared for the worst and there are times to hope for the best. When do to do which is of great importance to a bridge player. When everything looks rosy and the contract seems to be in the bag, think what can go wrong and prepare for the worst. But when your contract needs the cards to be placed in a favourable way for your contract to succeed, just assume them to be so. Of course when you hope for the best hope for the smallest best needed so that Bridgetta (your self-appointed Goddess of Bridge) may grant you your wish.

WEST HAND ♠— ♥K1963 ♦1074 ♣108764
EAST HAND ♠Q9876 ♥10 ♦9532 ♣J95

After winning the opening lead, South should cash one high trump (getting the bad news about the five-zero split). Declarer must not lead a second spade, which would automatically lead to the loss of two trump tricks. The only chance is to find East with a very favorable distribution in the side suits. South must cash the ace of hearts and the rest of the clubs, then four diamond tricks to discard two low hearts from his hand, and now lead a heart from dummy. East, down to all trumps, must ruff this heart lead; declarer can make the contract by under trumping. East must then lead from the queen-nine-eight of spades, while South has king-ten-four and dummy the jack-five. East's potential second spade trick vanishes into thin air. Your problem for the week:

DEALER: West VULNERABLE: East/West

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ J1095	♥ A6	♠ 8632	♥ 97
♦ A862	♣ AKJ	♦ 743	♣ Q742

SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
—	1♥	dbl	2♥
pass	pass	dbl	pass
2♣	pass	pass	pass

West leads the king of hearts. Plan the play.

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

QUICK CLUES ACROSS

1. Beat very convincingly (7)
5. Harder on the ears (7)
8. Scapegoat (5)
9. Assumption or proposition (9)
11. Exaggeration (13)
13. Make or be visible or conspicuous (4,2)
16. Self-important (8)
18. Confused or obscured (8)
19. Gasoline (6)
24. Horsemanship (13)
26. Gujarat city (9)
27. Part of a Flintstone yell (5)
28. Singer, dancer (7)
29. Provided means of support (7)

DOWN

1. Abundant (7)
2. Active, busy (2,3,2)
3. William and Stephen (5)
4. Say again (6)
5. Bird's savings - should we say ? (4,4)
6. Quitter's words (1,4)
7. Smells strongly of (5)
10. Pertaining to the womb (7)
12. Former Yugoslav leader (4)
14. Listen to (4)
15. No longer stuck (7)
17. Achievable, possible or practical (8)

CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS

1. He sounds like a wheeler-dealer (7)
5. Derided for having tucked in too heartily (3)
8. It's this if a good bargain (1,4)
9. Rudest drunk rubs against chase (9)
11. Holding the scales with what money you have left ? (7,2,4)

DOWN

1. Wrecked boat, and peg out in a swamp (4-3)
2. Many a fisherman are obviously this ! (7)
3. Right-wing extremist outcast, Redwood's first to go north (2,3)
4. Teased like a cage you carry (6)
5. It's obvious how you waste money (8)
6. Fled out around Jungfrau's peak - a high, bleak Scandinavian plateau (5)
7. Song of the sailor's bag (5)
10. Fourth district (7)
12. Girl making a point at Wimbledon, I being there as supporter (4)
14. It could hold about half a gallon - or more (4)
15. People in court can catch it ! (3-4)
17. Determined in advance Democrat needs it badly (8)
20. The unknown escaped Quixote's fingers, indeed (5,2)
21. Went to court about the paper sent back ? How sweet ! (7)
22. Stirrup cup for the hunter (6)
23. How I cared for a tree (5)
24. Keeps, in vases, bananas (5)
25. Outlaw going to Dee Why with a donkey (5)

SOLUTIONS TO 2593 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 1 Dashboard, 6 Koala, 9 Someone, 10 Frantic, 11 Sorer, 12 Sweetener, 13 Sailplane, 15 Messi, 16 Nasty, 18 Cotillion, 20 Economist, 23 Ostia, 25 Concede, 26 Stringy, 27 Sadat, 28 Traverses DOWN: 1 Dusts, 2 Samurai, 3 Biography, 4 Abets, 5 Different, 6 Krai, 7 Attends, 8 Accordion, 13 Sentences, 15 Melbourne, 17 Swooned, 19 Intones, 21 Olent, 22 To sea, 24 Abyss CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS: 1 Fingertip, 6 Mitre, 9 Bittern, 10 Run riot, 11 Eliza, 12 Perennial, 13 Carbonari, 15 Blini, 16 Reims, 18 Mastering, 20 Womaniser, 23 Knees, 25 Effendi, 26 Frontal, 27 Laity, 28 Estonians DOWN: 1 Fable, 2 Nattier, 3 Elevators, 4 Ton-up, 5 Portraits, 6 Menon, 7 Tbilisi, 8 Extolling, 13 Cartwheel, 14 Armistice, 15 Break down, 17 In mufiti, 19 Iced tea, 21 Ninny, 22 Refit, 24 Sells

2594

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY AUGUST 9: Take inventory of your life. Let go of the people, places and things from the past that held you back. Do some internal and external house-cleaning. Commune with nature.

MONDAY AUGUST 10: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes in your life. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future. Prepare for leadership roles.

TUESDAY AUGUST 11: This is a slower-paced year. Rest and rejuvenate your energy. Focus on your relationships. Concentrate on what brings you happiness.

WEDNESDAY AUGUST 12: Socialise and enjoy your world this year: your desire for life is at a pinnacle. Nurture the happiness and beauty you have within. Let your guard down and loosen up.

THURSDAY AUGUST 13: This is a year of work and construction. You will build foundations externally and internally. Take charge of your health. Simplicity is key. Stay grounded and levelheaded.

FRIDAY AUGUST 14: Exciting changes will give you increased personal freedom this year. Let go of whatever has been holding you back. Trust your intuition.

SATURDAY AUGUST 15: This is a year of service for you, perhaps service to family. Take care of yourself so that you can be a resource for those who turn to you for guidance and courage.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Tread carefully when talking to family members, as well as partners, and close friends, because confusion is rampant today. It's easy to misunderstand someone. This Week: Increased activity at home.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): When talking to others about work or health, be extra clear in your communications, because Neptune can create confusion in conversations today. Family discussions, especially about home repairs, might take place today. This Week: Accelerated daily pace.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a poor day to make financial decisions because the Moon is in your Money House at odds with both Venus and Neptune. If you feel tempted to buy something luxurious, beautiful or artistic — clothing, jewelry or art objects — think twice. Wait until tomorrow. This Week: You're spending money.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): If you're talking to parents, bosses, teachers, VIPs or the police today, take extra care to clarify what you mean. Furthermore, make sure you know what they require of you or what they are saying. This is because confusion and misinterpretations are likely today. This Week: Enthusiasm.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a tricky day. The Sun, Jupiter and chatty Mercury are all in your sign, which means you're eager to communicate to others. However, something is going on behind the scenes which could create misunderstandings. This Week: Best to work alone.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Because there's a strong possibility for confusion about financial transactions you might be wise to delay these exchanges until tomorrow. You can't believe everything you hear today because you might misinterpret it. This Week: Coordinate with others.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Because you love beautiful things and harmonious relations, be careful shopping today because you might go overboard, something that you will later regret. This Week: Your ambition is aroused.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Don't overreact if you think you're dealing with a passive-aggressive situation. Confused communications are happening everywhere today. People might be innocent due to misinformation or not enough information. This Week: Travel and learn.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Discussions with friends, groups or your kids might require money, funding or using someone else's property. Make sure everyone is on the same page. This Week: Increased passions.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Discussions with parents, and authority figures might be strained today. Someone might make assumptions that are wrong, or they might misunderstand someone else. This Week: Be patient.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Avoid controversial subjects today. Misunderstandings could make people riled up. The problem is that there's a strong potential for confusion today. This Week: Be productive.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Be very clear when talking to your kids today. Likewise, partners should be clear with each other to avoid misunderstandings that create hurt feelings and disappointments. Also be clear about financial matters. This Week: Play.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

The _____ you can make in life is to be continually fearing you will make one. - Elbert Hubbard (8,7)

LVEEE ELITTT

CAARS EUGKMS

ANSWER: The greatest mistake you can make in life is to be continually fearing you will make one. - Elbert Hubbard

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6405

	7							
		5	7		2			4
				1	5			
1	2					9		
9	5						7	6
		3				1		5
				1	8			
5	2		3		9	6		
							9	

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6404

8	5	2	9	6	3	4	7	1
9	4	1	2	7	5	6	8	3
3	7	6	4	1	8	9	2	5
7	6	4	3	8	9	5	1	2
5	3	9	6	2	1	8	4	7
1	2	8	7	5	4	3	6	9
2	1	5	8	9	6	7	3	4
6	9	3	1	4	7	2	5	8
4	8	7	5	3	2	1	9	6

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Brijesh** S/o Jai Prakash Singh R/o Gali No. 7, Jagram Chowk, Mukundpur, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence case **FIR No. 221/2026 U/S 317(2)/317(5)/61(2)/149/112 Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita at P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Brijesh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Brijesh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s **84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita** has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Brijesh** accused of **FIR No. 221/2026 U/S 317(2)/317(5)/61(2)/149/112 Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita at P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **16.09.2026**.

By Order: **Shri. Sahil Gupta,**
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07,
North, Court No. 6, Ground Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi.

DP/10779/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Samarjeet @ Vishal, S/o Jagan Nath R/o H.No.E-122, 1st Floor, 25 Foota Road, Chanakya Place, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.277/2026 dated 30.04.2026 u/s 8/21 NDPS Act, P.S. Dabri, Delhi (Special Staff)** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Samarjeet @ Vishal** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Samarjeet @ Vishal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Samarjeet @ Vishal of FIR No.277/2026 dated 30.04.2026 u/s 8/21 NDPS Act, P.S. Dabri, Delhi (Special Staff)** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.09.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Rahul Bhatia
Ld. Special Judge, (NDPS)-01, Court No.610
Sixth Floor, Dwarka Courts, New Delhi

DP/11027/Spl.Cell/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sahida, S/o: Ramesh, R/o: Jhuggi No- F-279, JJ Colony, Bawana, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 13/19, U/s: 411 IPC, P.S. Bawana, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Sahida** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Sahida** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sahida of P.S. Bawana, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.10.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Bharti Beniwal
JMFC-05, North, 1st Floor, Room No. 114,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/10636/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Arif, S/o Aslam, R/o B-6/47, Gali No. 1, Near Muskan Bakery, Kabir Nagar, Welcome, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 228/2024, U/s 129/55 G.Act, P.S. Welcome, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Arif** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Arif** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Arif** accused of **FIR No. 228/2024, U/s 129/55 G.Act, P.S. Welcome, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **09.10.2026**.

By Order - **Ms. Deepakshi Rana**
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Shahdara District, Room No. 19, 1st Floor
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/10726/NE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **1.Satish Tiwari S/o Lt. Sh. Suresh Tiwari R/o H.No. P-47, Pillanji Village, Sarojini Nagar, Delhi. 2.Shyam S/o Megha R/o H.No. P-201, Pillanji Village, Sarojini Nagar, Delhi** have committed (or is suspected to has committed) the offence under **FIR No. 012/2018 U/s 392/397/411/34 IPC.,** has been registered at **PS: Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **1.Satish Tiwari 2.Shyam** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **1.Satish Tiwari 2.Shyam** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **1.Satish Tiwari 2.Shyam** of under **FIR No. 012/2018 U/s 392/397/411/34 IPC.,** Registered at **PS: Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Vijayshree Rathore
JMFC-05, 1st Floor, Main Building
Patiala House, New Delhi

DP/10965/SW/2026
(Court Notice)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Letter No.: - DRM/C/AGRA/PARKING/E-AUCTION/2026 Dated :-07.08.2026

E-Auction Notice

On Behalf of The President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category :- Parking Auction Catalogue No :- PARKING-AGRA-4

Asset Details :- Agra Cant Railway Station - Towards 2nd Entry, Near Kharia Bridge/FCI Depo - Two Wheelers Parking

E-Auction Start Date & Time : Date:- 24.08.2026 Time:- 12:15

E-Auction End Date & Time : Date:- 24.08.2026 Time:- 12:45

Asset Details :- Agra Cant Railway Station - Towards 2nd Entry, Near Kharia Bridge/FCI Depo - Mixed (Two Wheelers and Four Wheelers) Parking

E-Auction Start Date & Time : Date:- 24.08.2026 Time:- 12:15

E-Auction End Date & Time : Date:- 24.08.2026 Time:- 13:05

Asset Details :- Idgha Jn. Railway Station, IDH Station PF-1, Circulating Area-Two Wheelers and Four Wheelers Parking

E-Auction Start Date & Time : Date:- 24.08.2026 Time:- 12:15

E-Auction End Date & Time : Date:- 24.08.2026 Time:- 13:15

Asset Details :- Idgha Jn. Railway Station, IDH Station PF-4, Side - Circulating Area-Two Wheelers and Four Wheelers parking

E-Auction Start Date & Time : Date:- 24.08.2026 Time:- 12:15

E-Auction End Date & Time : Date:- 24.08.2026 Time:- 12:55

Note :- Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. 1828/26 (AS)

North central railways @ www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ [CPRONCR](https://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in)

JODHPUR VIDYUT VITARAN NIGAM LIMITED

(MATERIAL MANAGEMENT & CONTRACT WING)

NEW POWER HOUSE, INDUSTRIAL AREA, JODHPUR-342003, PHONE: 0291-2742223, FAX: 0291-2745539

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

E-Procurement Tenders are invited for purchase of M.S. Forged Pins for 33 KV Pin Insulators (33 KV GI PINS) under **TN-2162 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00357)**, 33 KV, 3CX300sq. mm HT Power Cable Under **TN-2178 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00350)**, Four Core LT PVC Insulated and PVC Sheathed Armoured Cables Size 4Cx50 Sq.mm, 4Cx25 Sq.mm, 4Cx16 Sq.mm and 4Cx10 Sq.mm under **TN-2179 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00351)**, Composite Polymer Disc Insulators for 11 KV 45 KN T&C Type Under **TN-2180 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00352)**, LT Shackle Insulator & LT Pin Insulator **TN-2181 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00353)**, Galvanised M.S. Forged L.T. Pin For LT Pin Insulators and Hardware fitting for LT Shackle Insulators Under **TN-2182 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00354)**, 33 KV, 11 KV 45 KN T&C Disc Insulator Under **TN-2183 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00355)** and Hardware fittings for 11 KV 45 KN Disc-Insulator T&C Type under **TN-2184 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00356)**.

Details regarding Quantity, Tender cost, Earnest Money, Schedule date of tender opening for aforesaid tenders are available on our website at energy.rajjasthan.gov.in/jdvvn1 and also at info@sppo.rajjasthan.gov.in

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (MM&C)

For Electricity Complaints Toll free No. 1800 180 6045

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No.: Med/AGC/HVS/Gynaec/26 Date: 30.07.2026

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

ADVERTISEMENT FOR OUTSOURCING THE HONORARY VISITING SPECIALIST (ORTHOPEDIC) FOR DIVISIONAL RAILWAY HOSPITAL, AGRA CANTT, AGRA

This is to bring in your kind notice that services of Honorary Visiting Specialist (Orthopedic) for Divisional Railway Hospital; Agra Cantt is required for honorarium fix by Railway Board by Letter No. 2014/H-1/128/Policy Dated 19.06.2018 as below -

Specialty	Hours of Duty	Honorarium
Orthopedic	2 Hrs./Day/06 days/Week	Rs. 67,000/- per month

Qualification and experience: 1. Minimum PG Diploma/Post-Graduate degree from a recognized University (M.C.I. recognized). 2. Minimum 03 years' experience in the professional work related to concerned specialty after obtaining P.G. degree and in places where suitable candidates with PG degree are not available, PG Diploma holders with 05 years experience in the professional work related to concerned Specialty after obtaining P.G. diploma (preference to be given to MD/MS). 3. The specialist doctor must have earned reasonable amount of popularity, and Confidence in the City/Town.

Age Profile: 1. During first time engagement, the preferred age is between 30 years to 64 years. 2. Upper age limit of continued engagement is 65 years.

Kindly furnish documents regarding date of birth, Degree, Internship & PG Certificate & Certificate of experience with letter of acceptance within 15 days from the date of publication in the office of Divisional Railway Hospital/Agra of working hrs. From 10:00 AM to 05:00 PM.

Chief Medical Supdt. NCR, Agra

APPLICATION FORMAT

Application for engagement of Honorary Visiting Specialist over N.C. Rly. Hospital.

1. Name	12. If private whether attached to any corporate Hospital
2. Father's Name	13. Whether will available 6 days in a week:
3. Details of Address/with dot phone/mobile	Encl:
4. Date of birth/Sex	i. Two recent passport size photographs
5. Are you Ex. Rly. Doctors: If yes given details	ii. Certificate including the date of birth/SSC
6. Specialty	iii. MCI registration/ Certificate
7. Education / Professional Qualification examination year of passing: Medical College/University:	iv. MBBS Degree and Degree Certificate of higher medical qualification MD/MS (Recog. MCI)
8. Registration No. medical council & date	v. Internship certificate
9. Experience	vi. Registration certificate
10. Employed/Private	vii. Certificate of experience
11. If employee name of organization	

Declaration: I doctor.....having been complying with the eligibility criteria are mentioned above the scheme, do herewith opt for the scheme of Hon. Visiting Specialist in Rly. I also declare that all statements made in this application are true, complete and correct to the best of my knowledge and believe, I understand that in the event of any of the particulars or information given herein being found false or incorrect or in the event of my misstatement or discrepancy in the particulars being detected at any stage before or after my appointment, my contract is liable to be terminated forthwith independent of any civil or criminal legal action. The contract may be terminated at any time, on one month notice on either side. The administration reserves the right not to assign any reason for such termination.

Signature of candidate
Mobile No.:.....
Address:.....
Date:.....

1823/26 (PH)

North central railways @ [CPRONCR](https://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in) www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No: AGC/TRD/T/2026/19 E- Tender Notice Date : 06.08.2026

Sr. DEE/TRD/Agra for & on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on-line only (e-Tendering) for the following work:

Tender No.: AGCTRD T202819 | Period of completion : 12 months

Name of work: Modification in OHE due to Construction of 2 Lane ROB No. 157 by increasing Height and Rebuilding of Old ROB at km 83/5-6 between Agra Fort-Igdah Stations.

Approximate Cost: ₹ 50.37,978/- Earnest Money : ₹ 1,00,800/-

Note: (1) For full details & submission of the bid please see the Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in (2) Tender can only be submitted through web portal www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:30 Hrs. on date 31.08.2026. 1818/26 (MG)

North central railways @ [CPRONCR](https://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in) www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

SEE SECTION 84 BHARTIYA NAGARIK SURKSHA SANHITA

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused Persons namely **Om Pal @ Rinku S/o Nafe Singh, R/o H.No. 1997, Vill. Mandothi, Distt-Jhajjar, Haryana,** have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR/Case No. 54/2017 U/s 21/25/29 NDPS Act.,** has been registered at **PS: Crime Branch, ANTF Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Om Pal @ Rinku** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Om Pal @ Rinku** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused said, **Om Pal @ Rinku of FIR/Case No. 54/2017 U/s 21/25/29 NDPS Act.,** has been registered at **PS: Crime Branch, ANTF Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.09.2026**.

By Order
Puneet Nagpal
Ld. Special Judge (NDPS)
Room No. 222, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/11029/Crime/2026
(Court Notice)

Chola CHOLAMANDALAM INVESTMENT AND FINANCE COMPANY LIMITED

Corporate Office: "CHOLA CREST", C54 & 55, Super B-4, Thiru Vi Ka Industrial Estate, Guindy, Chennai - 600 032.

POSSESSION NOTICE (Rule 8 (1) (For Immovable Property))

Whereas the undersigned being the Authorised Officer of **M/s.CHOLAMANDALAM INVESTMENT AND FINANCE COMPANY LIMITED,** under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(2) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice Dated 18.05.2026 (Loan Account Nos.TL01NDL00000665782 and TL01NDL0000066183 calling upon the Borrower / Co Borrowers (t. M/s Raghukul Organic Farm, (Borrower), 2.Mr.SUBHASH, 3.Mrs. MANJU, 4. Mr. ANKIT CHAUHAN) to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs.1,30,76,740/- (Rupees One Crore Thirty Lakhs Seventy-Six Thousand Seven Hundred Forty Only) towards loan No.TL01NDL00000665782 and Rs. 5,11,498/- (Rupees Five Lakhs Eleven Thousand Four Hundred Ninety-Eight Only) towards loan account No. TL01NDL0000066183 together with further interest and charges thereafter within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The borrower / Co Borrowers having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower / Co Borrowers and the Public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described herein below in exercise of the powers conferred on him under Sub-Section (4) of Section 13 of Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest Enforcement) Rules, 2002 at this 5th day of August 2026.

The borrower's / Co Borrowers' attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets. The borrower / Co Borrowers in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of **M/s CHOLAMANDALAM INVESTMENT AND FINANCE COMPANY LIMITED,** for an amount Rs. 1,30,76,740/- (Rupees One Crore ThirtyLakhs Seventy-Six Thousand Seven Hundred Forty Only) towards loan No.TL01NDL00000665782 and Rs. 5,11,498/- (Rupees Five Lakhs Eleven Thousand Four Hundred Ninety-Eight Only) to wards loan account No. TL01NDL0000066183 and interest thereon.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

Property area measuring 146.32 Sq. Mtrs. Out of Khassra No.-482, Min. Situated at Village-Sadarapur, Pargana and Tehsil Dadri, Distt Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, East: Road- 10 ft. West: Other Plot, North: Plot of Lalit Chouhan, South: Road 15 FL.

Sd/-

Date : 05.08.2026 M/s. Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company Limited

Place: Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P)

Jemimah out of
The Hundred,
doubtful starter
for Asia Cup



Jemimah Rodrigues is racing against time to be fit for the upcoming Asia Cup. AP

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

INDIA BATTER Jemimah Rodrigues' participation in the upcoming Asia Cup is up in the air after she was ruled out of the ongoing The Hundred upon suffering a hamstring injury. Rodrigues' franchise Southern Brave confirmed on Saturday that the India player has been replaced by Australian all-rounder Charlie Knott for the remainder of the tournament.

"We can confirm that due to an injury suffered by Jemimah Rodrigues, we've signed Charli Knott as our injury replacement for the remainder of The Hundred. Wishing you a speedy recovery, Jemi," Southern Brave posted on X.

The 25-year-old has scored 143 runs with a highest of 42 not out in six innings for the Brave at an average of 35.75 and a strike rate of 131.19. With the Women's T20 Asia Cup set to start on August 28 and India's first match against Thailand scheduled on August 30, Jemimah will be in a race against time to recover in 3 weeks.

The tournament, to be played in Dubai and in the T20 format, will see India clash with arch-rivals Pakistan on September 5 at the Dubai International Stadium.

The eight teams taking part in the tournament are divided into two groups with India facing Thailand on August 30, followed by Hong Kong on September 3 and then arch-rivals Pakistan in Group A. Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, UAE and Indonesia make up Group B.

The top two teams from each group will qualify for the semifinals with the final set for September 13. Sri Lanka are the defending champions coming into this edition after beating India in the final in 2024. In that match, half-centuries from Chamari Athapaththu and Harshitha Samarawickrama enabled Sri Lanka to defeat the 2022 winners by eight wickets.

With India's first match at the Women's T20 Asia Cup against Thailand scheduled on August 30, Jemimah has 3 weeks to recover

WARM-UP MATCH

Padikkal strengthens his case for
No.3 spot with unbeaten century

Southpaw's ton was built off the back foot; Jaiswal, Pant and Jurel fell cheaply on Day 2

Sriram Veera
Mumbai, August 8

RISHABH PANT needed five balls to commit to the shot that ended his stay in the middle, on the second day of India's tour match against a Sri Lanka Cricket XI at the Nondescripts Cricket Club Ground in Colombo. He charged off-spinner Ramesh Mendis with a fielder posted inside the long-off boundary. The ball was close enough to tempt exactly the shot Pant played. He didn't clear the fielder. KL Rahul had gone before him, bowled attempting a big slog-sweep off the off-spin of Keshara Nuwantha after progressing serenely to 40, missing the ball completely. Yashasvi Jaiswal was dismissed in the second ball, steering Vishwa Fernando to a fielder for a duck.

India would have hoped Pant and Dhruv Jurel got among the runs too on an easy-paced pitch; Pant fell to his own urges, and Jurel to his own limitations. Jurel lasted a touch longer without ever looking settled, until a ball that kicked up waist-high while turning in required soft hands. Jurel didn't. He can be all-arms as a batsman, and he clipped it uppishly to short leg, where Nipun Dhananjaya took the second grab, diving forward. All three fell to spin on a pitch offering turn without much venom. It left the day to a batsman in the XI only because someone else was unfit.

Devdutt Padikkal came in at No.3, standing in for the unfit Sai Sudharsan, with Shubman Gill also out after picking up an injury at training. His last Test innings for India had come in Perth, in the Border-Gavaskar series of 2024. By the time he had retired once after reaching his hundred and returned later to bat on, news had come



Devdutt Padikkal hit an undefeated 142 runs off 164 balls, studded with 18 fours, to anchor India's batting on an easy-paced pitch. CREIMAS

through that Sudharsan was ruled out of the Test series through injury. Padikkal would be India's No.3 in the Test that starts on the 15th.

Compact batting

There has been talk in the Indian camp of using the feet more and combining it with the sweep to handle Sri Lanka's spin. Both are sound methods, but they need the ball to cooperate, and Jurel's didn't: not flighted enough to use the feet, not there for the sweep. Ravindra Jadeja alone looked entirely at ease against it, flowing quietly as he does, showing the right shot for every ball, before retiring for others to have a turn once he'd taken his innings to 63. The day's other, larger story was Padikkal's innings. He was batting as much to settle the question of the No.3 spot as to make runs.

Compact describes his batting. He bats from the middle, sometimes middle-and-off,



Rishabh Pant fell to his own urges for a five-ball 2. PTI

guard, close enough to the line that he should naturally be getting behind deliveries around off stump. He manages to somehow stay beside it instead. He doesn't move much across to get behind the ball; he bends the knees, then either punches through the offside or stretches forward to drive. He can occasionally stab at balls that leave him late, but there wasn't much seam movement on offer today

to test that outside edge.

He began carefully against the new ball, leaving anything wide of off from Vishwa Fernando, and took ten balls to get off the mark. The fifty came up in 61 balls and six fours, built mostly off the back foot, punching seamers through point when they dropped short and working the spinners through the on-side rather than reaching for them.

Past fifty, at 79, he broke that pattern once: a short ball from Vishwa Fernando that he pulled with both feet off the ground, wrists doing all the work his feet hadn't had time to, timed well enough to beat long leg to the fence. The hundred took another 60 balls. There was a leading edge that dropped just short of Mendis at mid-on, and a top edge off a Lahiru Kumara bouncer that clipped his helmet and brought the physio out for a concussion check before he carried on.

He reached three figures

with a pulled four off Mendis, 103 off 121 balls with fourteen boundaries, and kept going rather than settling for it.

Later in the innings, against the left-arm spin of Dilum Sudeera, he did find room for the sweep after all, twice reversing it away behind point for a single each time. It was the shot the team had spoken about wanting more of, arriving late and used sparingly rather than as a plan. He is unbeaten on 142 as India's reply stands at 357 for 6 in 90 overs, six runs behind, with Gurnoor Brar repeatedly swinging Sudeera over the boundary to reduce the deficit.

BRIEF SCORES: India 357/6 in 90 overs (Devdutt Padikkal 142 batting, KL Rahul 40, Manav Suthar 41, Ravindra Jadeja 63 retired out; Ramesh Mendis 2/77, Asanka Manoj 2/32) vs Sri Lanka Cricket XI 363/8d.

Sai Sudharsan ruled out of Lanka Tests with toe injury

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

INDIA SUFFERED another major blow ahead of the Sri Lanka Test series when batter Sai Sudharsan was ruled out of the series due to injury. Sudharsan, who had suffered a toe injury last month during in India A's tour to Sri Lanka, failed to recover in time and will sit out the two-Test series, scheduled to start on August 15.

Sudharsan, who scored two tons in two 'A' Test matches, was hit during the second game against Sri Lanka 'A' and since then has been in rehabilitation



Sai Sudharsan is in rehab at Bengaluru's Centre of Excellence. PTI

at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru. Ahead of the series, India are in a bit of a fix with a lot of key personnel dealing

with injuries. Jasprit Bumrah has been ruled out of the series, and there is no guarantee Washington Sundar would join

the team for the second Test.

The 32-year-old Bumrah, who picked up a knee injury during the second ODI against England last month is far from attaining full fitness and hence will miss the two Tests.

When the BCCI released the squad for the two-match Test series, Bumrah's inclusion was subject to him clearing fitness test. With nearly four-week break before the first Test, India were hoping that Bumrah would regain full fitness by then and were keen to take him on board even if it is unlikely to feature in the warm-up fixture. However, during the rehab pro-

cess, Bumrah is understood to have felt discomfort in his knee and as a result his comeback is expected to take time.

Though Bumrah has played 52 Tests, his career continues to remain stop-start because of injuries. Having overcome a career-threatening back injury, India have been managing his workload carefully. Last year in England, he played only three of the five Tests, but played in all four home Tests against West Indies and South Africa.

Meanwhile, injured India captain Shubman Gill did not take the field against SLC XI on Saturday as well.

BRIEFLY



Shillong Lajong FC blanked Mumbai FC 5-0. DURAND CUP

Shillong Lajong FC go top of
Group E with dominant win

EVERBRIGHTSON SANA struck a brace as Shillong Lajong FC cruised to a commanding 5-0 win over Mumbai FC in a Group E fixture of the Durand Cup. Apart from Sana, the other scorers for winners were Abhay Gurung, Tremiki Lamurong and Figo Syndai. The win extends Shillong Lajong's perfect start to the campaign and leaves them well placed at the summit of Group E with the group stage still to unfold. Langsning FC sit second on four points, with Nongkseh SS&CC third on one point. PTI

Bennacer leaves
AC Milan after
seven years

AC MILAN have parted ways with midfielder Ismael Bennacer, the Serie A club have announced, ending the Algeria international's seven-year stay at San Siro. The 28-year-old midfielder, who joined Milan from Empoli in 2019, has had spells on loan at Olympique de Marseille and Dinamo Zagreb after being sidelined by persistent knee injuries. "AC Milan can confirm the termination of Ismael Bennacer's contract by mutual consent," the club said. REUTERS

'IPL can fit into
Oz schedule, but
need to balance'

AUSTRALIA HEAD coach Andrew McDonald said the IPL can "fit" into his team's hectic schedule, but the demands on his Test stars mean they will have to "balance it out", particularly for the fast bowlers. Beginning with a two-Test home series against Bangladesh, Australia are set to play 20 Tests and 14 white-ball matches across next 12 months, with the 2027 IPL window expected to fall between a five-Test tour of India and the World Test Championship final. PTI

Mosimane set to
return as South
Africa coach

SOUTH AFRICA have approached Pitso Mosimane to return for a second spell as manager to replace veteran Hugo Broos. South African FA president Danny Jordaan said Mosimane was the choice but "we still need to tie up some loose ends. The 62-year-old Mosimane took over as South Africa coach after the 2010 World Cup in place of Brazilian Carlos Alberto Parreira, whom he understudied for three years. REUTERS

India face Korea
on hard court in
Davis Cup tie

INDIA'S DAVIS Cup qualifier second round match against South Korea will be played on a hard court in Seoul on September 18 and 19. According to a PTI report, the match will be played at the Olympic Tennis Centre in the South Korean capital. India and South Korea are closely matched sides - India are currently placed 19th on the Davis Cup standings and South Korea are 16th. Both India and South Korea pulled off major upsets in the first round. ENS

East Bengal's
ACL Two tickets
start at Rs 149

TICKET PRICE for East Bengal FC's AFC Champions League Two preliminary-stage clash against Kuwait's Al-Arabi SC on Wednesday at the Salt Lake Stadium here will start at Rs 149. Fans can choose from four ticket denominations priced at Rs 149, Rs 199, Rs 349 and Rs 499. Tickets are available for purchase on the District app and website. The high-stakes fixture will determine East Bengal continental fate for the season. PTI

Buonanotte
loaned to La Liga
club Elche

BRIGHTON MIDFIELDER Facundo Buonanotte will play for Spanish team Elche this season in what is the Argentine playmaker's fourth loan spell since joining the Premier League club in January 2023. The 21-year-old, who signed with Brighton from Rosario Central, was loaned to Leicester for 2024-25 and split last season between Chelsea and Leeds. Buonanotte played regularly for Leicester. AP

BRAZIL GLAMOUR VS ASEAN CUP GRIND

India's dilemma: Vinicius Jr or a shot at Southeast Asia

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 8

THERE HAS been an unexpected makeover in Indian football. For years, the lament was familiar: not enough matches, not enough meaningful opposition, not enough opportunity for the national team to test itself. India played only 11 games last year. Now, almost suddenly, the problem has inverted. India has entered an era of abundance, able to play four or five matches in a single FIFA international window.

With abundance comes complication. When there is too much football, the pertinent question is which football matters. A wrong answer risks laying bare myopic tendencies.

India were confirmed last month for the inaugural FIFA ASEAN Cup, to be held in Indonesia from September 24 to October 3. They have been grouped alongside the hosts, Malaysia and Singapore: three teams who, on paper, sit much

closer to India's competitive orbit than the latest opponent AIFF announced, Brazil, who India host in Kolkata on October 3. The AIFF, following its Executive Committee meeting on Thursday, announced it would field separate squads, since fielding the same players in both competitions is unfeasible.

"The AIFF will notify FIFA that India will participate in both competitions by fielding separate squads for the match against Brazil and the FIFA ASEAN Cup," its press release read.

Indian football now faces an unusual question: where should its priorities lie, the glamour of a standalone fixture against Brazil, or the competitive grind of the ASEAN Cup?

Amid reports the federation is considering prioritising the former, most former coaches favour the latter. Pradhyum Reddy, former FC Pune City coach, tells *The Indian Express*: "The Brazil friendly is pointless. There's no real value in it. The ASEAN Cup, on the other hand,

presents a clear opportunity. For years, everyone has been saying that India needs to play at a higher level than the SAFF Cup. Now, you have an opportunity to play against the middle tier of Asian football. We have always said we should be playing against teams from the East rather than the West. Now, you're getting the kind of exposure people have been asking for - Indonesia, Singapore and Malaysia. And you're turning your back on that opportunity?"

Sanjoy Sen, who won the I-League with Mohun Bagan, arrives at much the same conclusion: "What purpose does the Brazil game serve? Our priority should be the ASEAN Cup. If we can beat a team like Indonesia, then, as a coach, I would consider Indian football has moved at least one foot, or perhaps half a foot, forward in terms of development and improvement."

Mehrajuddin Wadoo, the former India defender now coaching Mohammedan SC, agrees. "Our priority should 100



India will field separate squads for ASEAN Cup and Brazil game. AIFF

per cent be the ASEAN Cup. Firstly, it is a set of competitive fixtures. There is a trophy to be won, prize money to secure, and crucial experience to gain."

Floyd Pinto, another former India player who coached the Indian Arrows, disagrees. "I would like to look at it positively. Tell me, which senior player would want to miss a game against Brazil? They could be playing

against the likes of Vinicius Junior! This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. Yes, as a coach, I agree that the ASEAN Cup is also a good opportunity, but we are constantly asking why we aren't using more young players? This is our chance to do that."

'India lacks depth'

India, though, cannot treat the ASEAN Cup as an after-

thought. The tournament is organised by FIFA, making a second-string team to Indonesia untenable. Former AIFF secretary general Shaji Prabhakaran explains why. "Normally, at this level, there would be a written Participation Agreement. In FIFA tournaments, you have to send your 'A' team. That is how they work, because FIFA tries to protect the integrity and sanctity.

"The federation has to prioritise whichever option offers greater value in terms of the future prospects of the national team. We simply can't say that we will field two 'A' teams, because we just don't have the depth to field two 'A' teams."

Reddy's answer: send India's strongest side to the ASEAN Cup, and treat Brazil for what it is, a spectacle.

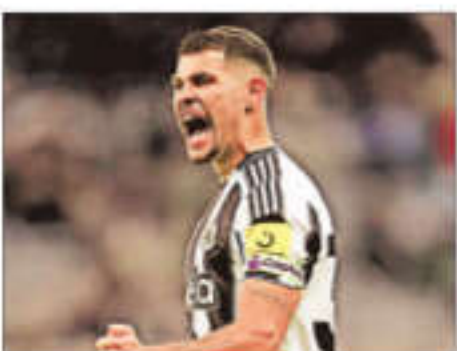
"From a footballing perspective, the Brazil fixture makes very little sense. We will only sit back and park the bus. In my opinion, this is just a posturing gimmick. It's straight out of the Gianni Infantino playbook."

Premier League champs
Arsenal sign Guimaraes

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

ARSENAL FINALLY signed a Brazilian in the transfer window but it wasn't Vinicius Jr. Rather, it was his national teammate and former Newcastle midfielder Bruno Guimaraes. Guimaraes signed a four-year contract with a further one-year option, the Premier League champions announced on Saturday.

According to British media, the deal was worth around 75 million pounds (\$101.16 million) for the Brazil international, adding one of the Premier League's most influential midfielders to Mikel Arteta's squad. "Since the first time I spoke to (Arsenal Sporting Director Andrea) Berta and Mikel, I was excited. I just felt inside of me that I need a new challenge in my life and I think to be an Arsenal player is going to be an exciting challenge in my life," Guimaraes said in a statement.



Arsenal acquired Bruno Guimaraes from Newcastle United for 75 million pounds. AP

"I am so excited to start. We have tough games to play this season, so the squad is going to be very, very important and I'm hopeful we can achieve our dreams," he added.

The midfielder joined Newcastle from Olympique Lyonnais in January 2022 and quickly established himself as one of the league's standout performers, playing a central role in the north-east club's rise over the past three seasons. He played for Brazil at this year's World Cup and has been a regular presence in the national team.

Gardner's ex-wife slams CA over scandal, demands sack



Ash Gardner. AP
Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

AUSTRALIA VICE-captain Ashleigh Gardner's estranged wife, Monica Wright, has slammed Cricket Australia (CA) for inaction over the cricketer's alleged affair with teammate Georgia Voll. Wright, who first made the allegations public in July, has also demanded that the 29-year-old Gardner be stripped of the leadership role in the national team.

"I think if you're privileged enough to represent your country and be seen as a role model, there's a responsibility to hold yourself to a high moral standard," Wright told Code Sports. "What I can't understand is why Cricket Australia hasn't said anything publicly.

"Does their silence mean they support the actions of Ashleigh and Georgia? You can't have an affair with a junior member of staff, especially when there's a clear power imbalance, and then remain in a position of leadership.

In a response to Wright's comments on Code Sports, Cricket Australia (CA) stated that the board considered the incident to be "private and personal."

"Cricket Australia ensures all relationships within our workforce comply with our Respect at Work policy. This includes putting appropriate conflict-of-interest management arrangements in place to support leadership responsibilities and maintain the integrity of team processes," CA said in its statement.

In July, Wright posted a *Daily Mail* article on her Instagram story with the caption that it was 'too vague' and said she'll say 'exactly what happened.' In the next slide, she posted the photo of Voll with the caption: "This is who my wife cheated on me with."

Wright and Gardner had tied the knot in April 2025 but things started deteriorating when the cricketer was in India for the 2025 Women's ODI World Cup, according to the *Daily Mail* report. When Wright had flown in to India to see Gardner, there was a bit of awkwardness, an insider stated according to the report.

They have since separated with Gardner moving out of their Sydney house while beginning divorce proceedings.

According to *news.com.au*, Gardner has also received firm backing from her WBBL franchise, Sydney Sixers, amid the scandal.

"I'm not going to comment on (Ash's) personal life, or anything like that. But certainly we've exchanged messages," Sixers GM and former Australia player Rachael Haynes said.

From training at dry pond to World U20 javelin silver

Yadav once trained with a wooden javelin. Two years on, 19-year-old has won India's first medal at the 2026 World U-20 Championships

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, August 8

WHEN HE took up the sport two years ago, Ashish Yadav trained with a wooden javelin in a dry pond with patches of quicksand near his village, Mawaiya, Mirzapur. It was more out of compulsion than choice, as there were no other open spaces. On Saturday, the 19-year-old, inspired by Olympic Games and World Championship medallist Neeraj Chopra's exploits, won a silver — India's first medal in this edition of the Under-20 World Championships — at Hayward Field in Oregon, USA.

Ashish became the first Indian since Chopra's historic gold in 2016 to win a medal in javelin at the junior World Championships. Though Ashish didn't produce a big throw like Chopra's 86.48 metres — the junior world record, set in Bydgoszcz, Poland — he did what is crucial in championships: secure a podium finish. His throw of 74.09 metres was enough for silver.

South Africa's Jan-Hendrik Heymans won gold (80.50m), while Addison James of Dominica, with 73.89 metres, registered a national record to win bronze.

Ashish didn't get enough time to practise after returning from a knee injury. But his resolve to win a medal helped open India's account despite him not being fully fit.

"There are sportspersons in my family. My aunty, Punam Yadav, is a weightlifter who won a medal at the 2014 Commonwealth Games. Seeing her, I wanted to get into sports. My uncle is a discus thrower and an Army man. Neeraj bhai is an inspiration for taking up the javelin. I still have a lot more to do, so I don't want to be compared to Neeraj bhai. But this medal is a good start for me because it proved that I can compete at the highest level and finish on the podium. I was about 80 per cent



Ashish Yadav became the first Indian since Neeraj Chopra to win a javelin medal at Jr Worlds. ASIAN ATHLETICS

fit, but I am not using that as an excuse. Injuries are bound to happen," Ashish told *The Indian Express* from Eugene.

Milkman father

Until Ashish became serious about the sport, he helped his father in the milk distribution business.

"Until I was 17, I used to help my father, who is a milkman. From the age of 10, I went to houses in and around my village and milked cows and buffaloes. My father would sell the milk," Ashish said.

His discus-thrower uncle, Dharamraj Singh, irritated that he neither took up a sport seriously nor studied well, gave him a tongue-lashing one day. The uncle promised to get him wooden javelins, which cost Rs 1,200 each. Mawaiya and nearby villages didn't have a proper ground. But that didn't stop Ashish from trying to become the next Chopra.

"The pond, which is about 2 kilometres away from home, would dry up. I could throw without being worried about hitting someone with the wooden javelin. But there was a risk because there were spots which were like quicksand. Every year, there are incidents of children being sucked into the mud. Children have died too. I got a beating a few times when my family got to know about where I was training. But I was always careful. There is a Shivji mandir

“Until I was 17, I used to help my father, who is a milkman. From the age of 10, I went to houses in and around my village and milked cows and buffaloes. My father would sell the milk.”

ASHISH YADAV, SILVER MEDALLIST, U20 WORLDS.

near the pond, so I was sure I would be protected. There is no proper ground in Mirzapur or in my village. I had to start somewhere," Ashish said.

Chopra on loop

Dharamraj said Ashish would watch videos of Chopra on loop. "I told Ashish you have to work hard and not lose heart because javelin is not an easy sport. Also, the competition in India is very tough. The silver at the World Championships proves he is on the right track."

Winning silver at the Under-20 World Championships made up for his fifth-place finish at the Under-20 Asian Championships in Hong Kong in May. Ashish got his big break when he was selected to train at the Hisar Centre, which is run by the

Sports Authority of India in collaboration with the *Inspire Institute of Sport*.

"Usually, athletes from Uttar Pradesh don't get selected at the Hisar Centre easily. But Arvind Kumar, the coach at the Hisar Centre, saw potential in me and selected me. When I joined the centre, my weight was just 70 kilograms; now it is 84 kg. I am six feet and one inch tall. Earlier, I was underweight, but my coach taught me the importance of eating well and training right. He is like a god to me; he treats me like his own son. Whatever money I needed for the sport, my uncle and my coach would give. They have not asked me to return a single rupee."

Coach Kumar was impressed by Ashish's explosive speed, though he didn't top the trials with 64 metres. "We conduct motor-ability tests. His standing board jump was 3.10 metres. Anything over 3 metres is very good; most of the kids do about 2.70 metres, 2.80 metres. His vertical jump was also good. He had a lean body, was tall and his speed was good, which can help a javelin thrower," he said.

Before the final, the coach told Ashish not to overthink. Ashish's next target is to improve his speed on the runway. "Technically, I have to make changes. I won't rest on my laurels. Javelin is booming in India; one can't afford to take it easy."

Chaliha realises her talent at place she had left on crutches

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, August 8

THE LAST time Ashmita Chaliha was at the Korea Open, she had to leave on crutches. Back in August 2024, she suffered a mid-meniscus tear and needed a flight upgrade because she couldn't sit with a swollen knee that resembled a balloon. When her mother rushed to Bangalore airport to pick her up, she couldn't contain her tears watching Ashmita walk down an escalator on crutches.

Two years on, the chill Asamese, with stinging south-paw talent on her strokes, has completed the Korean circle and reached the finals of the Super 300 Korean Masters. She defeated Rakshitha Sree Santhosh Ramraj 21-13, 16-21, 21-13, relying on her left-handed shot-making, and plays Chinese Han Qian Xi in the finals.

Hand speed

Local shuttler Kim Ga Ram was battling on an adjacent court. But the crowd was riveted by the all-India contest between Rakshitha and Ashmita as both shuttlers unfurled attacks that were magnetic and entertaining in their shot quality.

Ashmita's standout quality was just how high she took the shuttle, creating all these deft angles while keeping it aggressive.

Ashmita's hand speed combined with the leftie angles denied Rakshitha early entry into a rally, and she trailed 13-6 and 9-1 in the first and third set, effectively being driven out of the match when the 26-year-old Ashmita played from the faster side.

It wasn't just the overheads where Ashmita showed great speed and urgency to dislodge Rakshitha, who smashed a racquet in frustration. The Asamese had the crowd on its feet when she flicked a dipping shuttle inches off the backline and managed to send it over the net.

It was a semifinal between World No 50 and the World No 49, but the older Indian, on her comeback, was both fighting fit and calmly aggressive, building a good lead and putting Rakshitha under pressure. The knee from two years ago had been a memory needing closure, and her bouncy confidence was evidence that the crutches from Korea were safely tucked away.



Ashmita Chaliha beat Rakshitha Sree Ramraj. BADMINTON PHOTO

The game has always been there. If anything, it was the most talented game after Sindhu's. A hop smash, an entire arc of attacking pushes and the ability to keep the game away from the net — all at a fast clip.

Mother Geetali recalls the dampener of an August in Bangalore. "PPBA took good care of her and her employers helped land an appointment with Dr Pardiwala for an emergency surgery in Mumbai in two days, which would otherwise take a month and a half.

But Korea was a painful memory," she recalls. "Injuries happen to every sportsman. I told her even Tendulkar and Dhoni have battled injuries. But it took a long time," she says. It was 8 months before she returned to the court, and two years till she made the finals.

Her ranking had slipped over 200.

Ashmita returned to Guwahati, but stays at the National Centre hostel in the same city, coming home only over the weekend.

Playing struggles

Her struggles as a non-prodigy are not really documented, even as the Indian propensity to write off talent after age 23 if it doesn't medal big continues. "She was hurt by criticism. She used to

wonder, 'they say nice things when I peak but pass negative comments when I lose.' It would affect her, but now she's settled into a groove and doesn't bother," her mother says.

The game has always been there. If anything, it was the most talented game after Sindhu's. A hop smash, an entire arc of attacking pushes and the ability to keep the game away from the net — all at a fast clip.

"Earlier, she would make errors and not learn from them. Now she rectifies quickly. The maturity has come with age," her mother says. "She was immature before." An enigma who loves watching motor-racing, playing video games and listening to music, but only with her closest friends, Ashmita struggled to fit in in Bangalore even while her game improved.

She won India a crucial WS2 match at the Asian team gold win, but it was evident that she needed a coach who would constantly be on her case and not let her drift.

Earlier this year, she did well at Malaysia and Macau to reach No 50, but the surge into finals has finally played out at Korea.

"What keeps her going is that she truly loves badminton. It's an in-born drive. She loves to play, looks forward to practising, and enjoys it. At 26, she is back to fighting. Fingers crossed for the final," her mother says.

Ashmita Chaliha might prove to be coach Park Tae Sang's big challenge with the goal to steer the prodigious talent, albeit not a prodigy, back into the elite tier.

54 all out: Bangladesh suffer embarrassing start to Aus tour in warm-up

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 8

BANGLADESH'S FIRST Test tour to Australia in 23 years got off to a rocky start as they were bowled out for 54 in an innings defeat during the three-day warm-up game against the Cricket Australia XI in Darwin on Saturday.

Starting the final day of the three-day practice match with two wickets down, the Bangladesh batting order was razed by an unknown Australia quick, Campbell Thompson, playing only his second First-Class game.

The 22-year-old left-arm pacer stormed through with

figures of 8 for 25 as Bangladesh followed their first-innings effort of 263 with a tepid innings that lasted only 22 overs.

Campbell's chance

"Sometimes you get lucky," Thompson was quoted as saying by *Cricinfo*. "It fell my way today, which was nice. It's always a good experience and opportunity to come and play up against a Test side a few days out from a series.

"Then to play alongside experienced Aussie guys as well, like Kurtis Patterson and Corey Rocchiccioli and stuff like that. So, just involving myself around these guys has



Bangladesh suffered an innings defeat at the hands of CA XI. BCB

Bangladesh will have 4 days before they take on a Australian attack led by Cummins, Starc and Hazlewood in the first Test at the Marrara Stadium, the first Test at the venue in 22 years.

been awesome."

"I think the opportunity to step out and play against the top liners in Australia, bowling to the best batters, has definitely given me some good ex-

perience heading into this year," he said after his match-winning effort.

"Hopefully there's more of that but just trying to take it one step at a time. Trying to just bowl as well as I can in any level while I'm playing and hopefully putting my best foot forward."

Bangladesh will now have four days before they take on a full-strength Australian attack led by Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc and Josh Hazlewood in the first Test at the Marrara Stadium in Darwin, also the first Test played at the venue in 22 years.

The second Test, to be played at Great Barrier Reef

Arena in Mackay from August 22 to 26, will also be the venue's first-ever men's Test match.

While Australia dominated the ICC World Test Championship standings with a points percentage of 87.50, Bangladesh rank fourth after four Tests this cycle.

BRIEF SCORES: Cricket Australia XI 355 all out (Teague Wyllie 130; Hasan Mahmud 4/42) beat Bangladesh 263 all out (Mehidy Hasan Miraz 109 not out; Corey Rocchiccioli 6/83) & 54 all out (Tanzid Hasan Tamim 22; Campbell Thompson 8/25) by an innings and 38 runs.

Lionel Messi's father and agent Jorge dies aged 68 after unspecified illness

Associated Press
Buenos Aires, August 8

JORGE MESSI, the father of soccer star and Argentina captain Lionel Messi, died Saturday at a hospital in the central Argentina city of Rosario. He was 68.

The Rosario-based Club Atlético Newell's Old Boys announced his death in a social media post that said he had undergone treatment in recent months for an unspecified illness. The post described him as "the pillar and the person who, with vision, rigor and affection, supported the career of the best player of all time, alongside his wife, Celia Cuccitini."

The South American Football Confederation, CONME-

BOL, in a statement also offered its condolences "with respect and affection for Lionel."

Lionel Messi led Argentina to a runner-up finish in this year's World Cup. In the team's first match, against Algeria, he was visibly emotional after scoring the first of his three goals. He said later that he wept for "a reason unrelated to sports."

Messi's anger at media

"I went through some difficult, complicated days," he said. "I am grateful to the delegation, to all my teammates, because they were always by my side wishing me strength so that I would be OK."

Media reports at the time outraged the Messi family, which days later released a



Jorge Messi was reported to be ill around the 2026 World Cup. AP

statement confirming that "Jorge is experiencing a health issue," without specifying the nature of his condition.

"A person's health and the peace of mind of their loved ones should not be the subject of speculation or irresponsible

Club Atletico Newell's Old Boys announced his death in a social media post that said he had undergone treatment in recent months for an unspecified illness.

media interest," according to the statement, which also expressed "discomfort at the lack of sensitivity, respect and scruples with which some people have treated a strictly private and family matter."

Jorge Messi was a chemical technician and worked as a steelworker. He played soccer as a midfielder and reached

the youth ranks of Newell's Old Boys but had to abandon the sport to complete his mandatory military service in Argentina.

Fundamental role

He played a fundamental role in his third son's career, serving as his agent and managing his business affairs.

He was the one who traveled with a young Messi to Barcelona in the early 2000s for the trial that would open the doors to La Masia, the club's youth academy. Lionel Messi made his professional debut in 2005 and went on to win eight Ballon d'Or awards. He led Argentina to the 2022 World Cup title.

"My dad was always by my side," Lionel Messi said in a

2007 interview with Radio del Plata. "Sometimes I would lock myself in my room to cry when we arrived in Barcelona, or my dad would do the same without me seeing him, or thinking I didn't see him. We pretended we were both OK, but we weren't. My dad even asked me what I wanted to do when we were feeling down, if I wanted to stay or go back, and I wanted to stay, and he stayed with me."

His father negotiated the contracts with Barça and later his transfers to Paris Saint-Germain and Inter Miami, while also managing the use of his famous son's image rights and his numerous investments in real estate, hotels, and restaurants.

In 2013, father and son

were accused by a Spanish prosecutor of trying to conceal earnings from the player's image rights. Jorge Messi paid more than 5 million euros (\$6.6 million) on Aug. 14 to cover alleged back taxes and interest.

The president of Argentina's soccer federation, Claudio Tapia, on Saturday issued a lengthy statement in which he recognized Jorge Messi "for having raised a person of values: humble, respectful, and deeply committed to others."

The organization ordered a moment of silence to be observed at all matches across all categories of Argentine soccer and mandated that players, referees and coaching staff wear black armbands.



Kargil, From the Skies

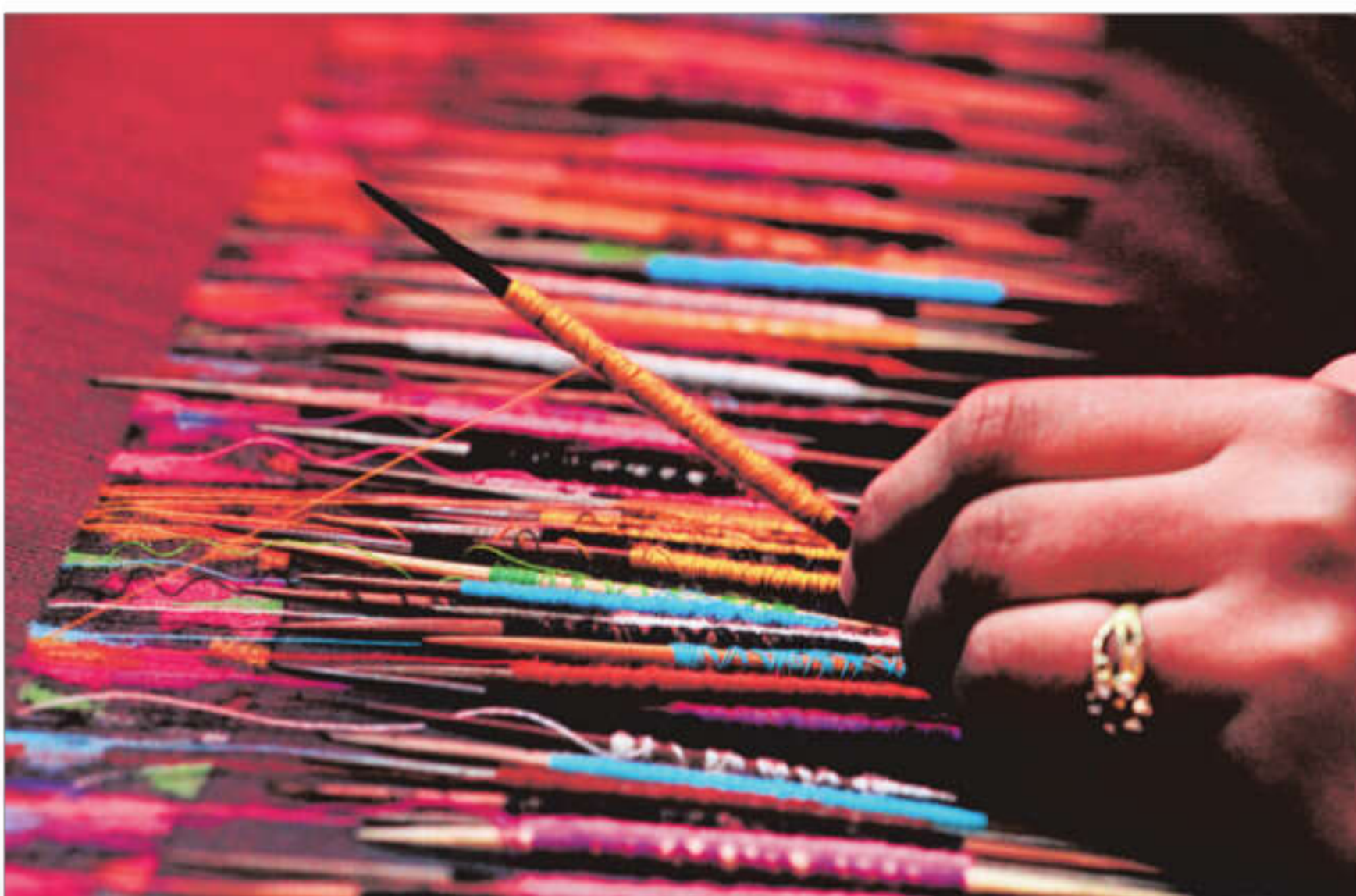
A new Netflix series revisits the 1999 Kargil War through the eyes of the young pilots of the Golden Arrows squadron

Remembering Nirmal Purja



THE MANY LIVES OF A WEAVE

From learning how a small investment in weaver communities can result in big returns to empowering artisans in rural India, LAILA TYABJI traces the hands, histories and chance encounters behind the country's handloom revival



SHUAIB MASOODI



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

A STORY IN EVERY STATE

(Clockwise from above left) Kani shawl weaving in Bandipora (Jammu and Kashmir); jamdani weaving; Laila Tyabji with craftspeople in Rajasthan

Every day, they shook their heads (one cheerfully, one sadly), and said they would have to change the width of their looms, get new yarn dyed in these outlandish colours. Then, when I came to say goodbye, they suddenly whipped out a fabulous golden-yellow dupatta with a forest-green border and ends. They said that while I was gone (I'd been working with Kasuti embroiderers in the neighbourhood) they felt bad, and decided, "Why not try it?" They remained a successful part of Dastkar bazaars all through the 1980s and '90s and, at one point, everyone in Delhi was wearing their saris and dupattas. When Babri Masjid fell in 1992 and there were fears of violence and communal riots, they wrote us a letter, helped by an English-speaking village scribe: "God is all where's" it said, ending, "Do not weary, we are praying..."

Bihar's gobar collection

In Dastkar's 45 years, we worked with



DASTKAR

countless weaver communities. In the process, we saw a revival and flourishing of many almost lost traditions — Mangalagiri, Begumpuri, Bomkai, Tangalia; the thick goats wool shawls of Kutch and the Thar desert transformed into dramatic best-selling cotton garments and furnishings; the revival of Karvati saris of Maharashtra; Kani weaving in Kashmir; Uppada Jamdani; the Kotpad madder tribal lugdis that becoming stunning saris; Bodo and Naga weaves adapted for urban wearers; hill communities in Ladakh, Uttarakhand, Assam, and Himachal thriving and Ikat going viral worldwide.

But probably the most memorable, because its happy ending started from such sad beginnings, was our Berozgar Mahila Kalyan Samiti, a project in Bihar. In the early 1990s, a young man walked into our Dastkar office. Working in a Gandhi *ashram* in Bhagalpur, he had discovered a group of over 500 women, who had been in

bonded labour for over 20 years, spinning tussar yarn for local traders. They were in debt, taking loans of Rs 500-1000, unable to pay the money back. They had been spinning 10-hour days without pay ever since. Plus paying 25 per cent interest on the original loan. The young man, Nirranjan Poddar, asked for our help.

Driving to dinner that night I wondered what we could do. At the dinner, serendipitously, I met my friend, the writer Gita Mehta. I told her the story. Gita, always practical, wanted to know what the total debt amounted to. After a quick calculation she said, "Ok, I'll give you the royalties from my next book." The book was *River Sutra* (1993) and a cheque from her New York publishers duly arrived. After paying off the women's debts, we taught the group to weave and found a young National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT) student designer to work with them. Romi Chopra, aesthete and Delhi man-about-town, teasingly called the resulting range of saris, stoles and dupattas, with their beiges, fawns and creams and contrasting black, brown and taupe borders, "Laila's *gobar* collection" but they were an immediate hit — everyone from Sonia Gandhi to Shabana Azmi was wearing them. The group soon had a turnover of crores, selling goods worth Rs 20 to 30 lakh at every bazaar. Bhagalpur silks are now famous, having added stripes and checks and vibrant jewelled colours to their range.

The story is a paradigm, of how in the handloom sector, a small investment can result in big returns, given that weavers don't need expensive equipment or infrastructure. It also illustrates that any intervention has to be holistic: incorporating all aspects of the development cycle — credit, skills training, raw material procurement, design and product development, market information. The actual marketing is only one part of the process. Another are the deep friendships one develops.

Holding on to rituals

A last story: Five decades ago, I was a brash young merchandiser-designer. Working with Gangarappa, a master weaver in Pochampalli (Telangana). It drove me crazy that he would never work on my samples till he had groomed, fed and garlanded the family bullocks, sprinkled his hearth with water, bathed, decorated his loom with fresh flowers, and completed an elaborate puja. He would then weave a ritual few inches on the oldest ancestral loom, centuries old, passed down from his forefathers, before he agreed to begin on something new. By then, it would be well past 11.30 am and I would be hopping up and down, impatiently. I did not grasp then that these disciplined age-old rituals were integral to his creative mastery. He told me later that when he wove those first inches on the family loom, he communed with the spirits of his grandfather and great grandfather and received their blessing. Something I heard again later, from Vankar weavers in Kutch. It is those traditions, going beyond hand skills or market demands, that we have to understand and preserve, while taking India's extraordinary handlooms into global markets.

Laila Tyabji is former chairperson, Dastkar

CREATING PLATFORMS FOR CRAFT

From digital marketplaces to artisan-run collectives, these new-age enterprises are reaching a wider audience while ensuring makers remain at the centre of the story

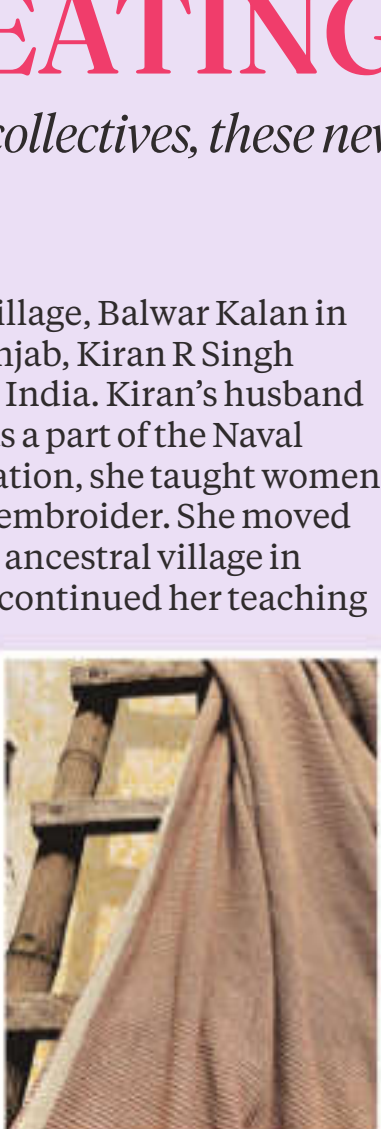
GAATHA

GAATHA HAS been working in the craft sector for over 15 years, actively supporting Indian artisans by providing a unique online platform for their products and voices. Co-founders Shivani Dhar and Sumiran Pandya's passion for handicrafts took root during our academic journey at Ahmedabad's National Institute of Design (NID). It started as a blog in 2009 documenting crafts and heritage, which were fading away. Then, they launched an online platform in 2013, displaying not only handcrafted products but also the makers behind them. In 2019, they began Gaatha Research and Archive Portal — a comprehensive digital documentation of Indian handicrafts and handlooms. It's now grown to a community of over 2,000 artisans, who directly connect with a global audience.



BALWAAR

NAMED AFTER the village, Balwar Kalan in Sangrur district of Punjab, Kiran R Singh started Balwaar Rural India. Kiran's husband was in the Navy, and as a part of the Naval Wives Welfare Association, she taught women to crochet, stitch and embroider. She moved back to her husband's ancestral village in 1999, and in 2004 she continued her teaching endeavour with the women of the village. Today, her brand celebrates the heritage of Punjab through handwoven textiles like khes, durries, charpois and embroidered pieces, all crafted by women. The khes was traditionally woven in Punjabi kumbal, a hand-thrown shuttle known as a pit loom. But to make the production easier, Kiran introduced the fly shuttle loom, which makes the process faster due to a wider weave. Their durries are woven on fixed-frame looms called atta. Balwaar designs its durries using Punjab's iconography, most of them inspired by the weavers' surroundings.



PORGAI

PORGAI ARTISANS Association was started by Neela and Gammi, natives of Tamil Nadu's Sittilingi village, almost 21 years ago when they decided to bring back Lambadi embroidery into their tribal community. Porgai translates to "pride" in the Lambadi dialect. But the association came into being through Dr Lalitha Regi. Lambadi embroidery originates from the nomadic Banjara/ Lambani tribe, who were travelling traders and transporters. Their embroidery reflects their cultural journeys, using vibrant threads, mirrors, coins and shells. During the 19th century, Lambani communities settled in southern India, where their embroidery evolved into a distinctive folk tradition known for bold colours and dense patterns. Porgai, an artisan-owned and artisan-run organisation, comprises over 70 members, all local women from the Lambadi community. They make a variety of items including saris, blouses, kurtas, set mundu, shirts and conceptualised textile works.



URA MAKU

IN ASSAMESE, Ura means to fly and Maku is the shuttle in weaving. Hailing from the upper valleys of Assam, Manjushree Saikia grew up with Assam Textiles and folk cultures, translated into love for fashion. She graduated as a Textile designer from NIFT in 2016 and proceeded to start her clothing line two years later. Having launched nine collections till now, her designs are timeless and classic. After her graduation, when she started travelling to craft clusters across India, she realised the responsibility a designer holds towards Indian artisans and society. Her apparel is a product of that realisation; hence, using fabrics that are handwoven by artisans. Reviving local crafts from northeast India and some parts of central and western India, she now specialises in tailored suits and indigo dyes.



METAPHOR RACHA

RAVI KIRAN, a B.Sc (electronics) graduate, always had an inkling to work with textiles. He worked in a few garment factories for four years and realised his true calling was more towards handcrafted textiles and made-ups. In 2011, he formed Metaphor Racha to work with local and rural craftspeople, be it spinners, weavers, dyers, printers and tailors, and bring the deserving to the forefront, while providing them a global platform. Metaphor Racha is a dedicated Khadi brand authentic to Karnataka. From khadi tops, trousers and dresses for women to shirts for men and home essentials such as hand-quilted bedspreads, they go by the motto: rural hands, global spirit. Kiran's wife, Brinda, handles the financial aspects, while he focuses on connecting with the weavers, making the designs, and marketing of the products. REVA THAKKAR AND ANUSREE KC



The Storied Life of Daryaganj

Kanupriya Dhingra's debut book is a portrait of the Sunday book market that shaped her identity as a reader

Adrija Roychowdhury

FOR YEARS, every Sunday morning, a kind of magic unfolded on the footpath near Delhi Gate in Old Delhi's Daryaganj. As if conjured from thin air, hundreds of books would appear, transforming the pavement into one of the city's most beloved open-air book markets. Kanupriya Dhingra first encountered it as a child, accompanying her parents in search of "useful" books. Years later, she rediscovered the market as a student at Delhi University, when her limited pocket money could no longer keep pace with an appetite for reading that stretched far beyond her college syllabus.

On one of her weekend visits to the market, she came across a collection of love-letter writing manuals — an encounter that eventually led to an extensive ethnographic study of the Daryaganj Sunday *Patri Kitab Bazaar*. In her debut book, Dhingra offers an intimate account of her engagement with the Sunday book market while reflecting on how it shaped her identity as a reader. As she writes, "My Daryaganj finds are not simply second-hand books; they are souvenirs of moments in which I was, often without knowing it, beginning to identify myself as a reader."

The book is a rich, immersive portrait of a stretch of pavement in Daryaganj. It traces the Sunday book market through its many incarnations — from its beginnings near the Red Fort to Lohe Wala Pul, then to the stretch between Golcha Cinema on Netaji Subhash Marg and Delite Cinema on Asaf Ali Road, where it flourished for more than four decades, before its relocation in 2019 to the enclosed compound of Mahila Haat.

Dhingra narrates the story of the market by plunging into the lives that unfolded around it. The bazaar is an "ecosystem of knowledge, skill, improvisation." Its vendors come from different generations and communities. There is Om Prakash Mago, founder of Om Books International, who began as a bookseller in the Sunday market before building a publishing business. Then, there is Surendra Dhawan, who was a full-time photographer before turning to the book trade in search of stability. There is also Asha, one of the market's senior booksellers, who would often tell Dhingra that "*kitab bechna aadmi logon ka kaam hai, hum kaise uthayenge bhari bhari kitabein?*" (Selling books is men's work. How could women lift such heavy books?) Yet, every Sunday she would arrive with her stack of books and run her stall with complete confidence.

Unlike bookshops, the vendors at the Sunday market sell what Dhingra calls "*nai jaisi*" (as good as new) books. Their stock includes rare books, second-hand books, school textbooks, photocopied study material, pirated editions and a wide variety of other printed material. They follow a business model shaped as much by intuition as by educational policy, examination patterns and changing reading trends. One of the vendors she interviews, Abdul Wali, tells her: "*Ek student ko achha maal do, woh agle saal phir aata hai, apne doston ke saath.*" (Give one student good material, and they come back the next year with their friends). It is a business strategy refined over decades.

Then, there are the buyers, many of whom, like Dhingra herself, first come to the market out of necessity — formal education to learning the practical skills of everyday life. They may be looking for manuals on playing the piano, cooking, tailoring, Ayurvedic medicine or even writing letters. The bazaar, she writes, caters to everyone's needs without discrimination. It is a space where a rickshaw puller and an IAS aspirant, both have an equal claim to the same pile of books.

Dhingra's writing stands out for its attention to details. Every aspect of the bazaar — from walking through the city to the serendipitous discovery of books — is thoughtfully reflected upon. But the book's greatest achievement lies in prompting readers to reflect on what makes someone a reader in the first place. Ours is a society that often values reading only for its utility — to excel in school, college or competitive examinations. Reading for pleasure remains the preserve of a small privileged minority. What the Daryaganj book bazaar did for Delhi was bridge these two worlds. It catered to both kinds of readers and, in the process, transformed many utilitarian readers into *shaukeen* readers.

BY KANUPRIYA DHINGRA
Speaking Tiger
311 pages
₹599

THE SUNDAY BOOK BAZAAR-DARYAGANJ AND THE MAKING OF A READING PUBLIC IN DELHI

THE SUNDAY BOOK BAZAAR-DARYAGANJ AND THE MAKING OF A READING PUBLIC IN DELHI

Decoding Beijing's Black Box

In China's Wars, Vijay Gokhale offers a scholarly analysis of the motivations and impulses behind China's aggressive actions with its adversaries from an Indian perspective

Shubhajit Roy

CHINA'S DECISION-making has been a black box. It is seen to be opaque. So, it poses a unique challenge to neighbours, partners and adversaries alike, who struggle to understand the motivations, impulses and factors that shape and influence Beijing's strategy towards the world.

Vijay Gokhale, who has spent the better part of his diplomatic career dealing with China from three vantage points — Hong Kong, Taiwan and Beijing — has tried to decode Beijing's black box. He began his career as a young diplomat learning Mandarin in Hong Kong (before the British left), and then served in Beijing during the Tiananmen protests, and went back to Beijing as India's ambassador in 2016-17. He served as India's Foreign Secretary till his retirement in 2020. In Delhi, he manned the China desk, as joint secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs.

In his previous book, *The Long Game: How the Chinese Negotiate with India* (2021), he sought to illustrate the various ways and means in which Chinese negotiators interact, influence the agenda, and shape outcomes — sometimes with deception and subterfuge as essential tools. In the book, he had given a toolkit used by Chinese negotiators — and he has had wide experience in dealing with his counterparts in Beijing — that is useful for practising diplomats, business persons and scholars and students of China to understand their behaviour, and negotiating style.

In the latest book, *China's Wars: The Politics and Diplomacy Behind its Military Coercion*, Gokhale takes a step forward: He analyses Chinese motivations and im-

pulses behind their aggressive and kinetic actions with their adversaries.

He uses four case studies: Taiwan Strait Crisis of 1958, India-China war of 1962, Sino-Soviet conflict of 1969 and the China-Vietnam War, and seeks to come up with a framework for Chinese behaviour.

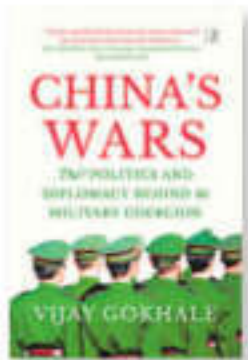
While all these cases have been analysed earlier, he is uniquely positioned to conduct the academic analysis that can be useful for current and future diplomats. He says that this is not a book of war history, but a "history of the geopolitics of war".

With India and China being neighbours, the book has been written to analyse it from the Indian perspective and draw lessons for India in future. At a time when the border-standoff between India and China is still ongoing, Gokhale's book is a timely scholarly analysis.

India has suffered a war with China in 1962 and come close to conflict on other occasions since. China's claim on Indian territory has gradually expanded as has, more recently, its encroachment on the ground. How and when China will deploy force in pursuit of its claims in the future is, therefore, a legitimate question in the minds of Indian strategists and thinkers.

Scholars have argued that China uses conflict as a tool of "psychological deterrence" and the Chinese draw no clear distinction between peacetime and wartime. Gokhale notes that fighting and talking go hand-in-hand with the singular objective of securing China's political goals, which might be territorial, geopolitical or purely related to domestic politics.

Concluding quite candidly that the 1962 war delivered a "psychological-political blow" to India, Gokhale makes a case that the invasion was "not a sudden counter-re-



CHINA'S WARS: THE POLITICS AND DIPLOMACY BEHIND ITS MILITARY COERCION
VIJAY GOKHALE
Simon & Schuster
210 pages
₹699



HUMANS FIRST, MACHINES SECOND: 30 SPARKS TO REIMAGINE WINNING IN THE AGE OF AI
VINEET NAYAR
Penguin
216 pages
₹799

SHELF LIFE

'I wrote about people, not AI'

Vineet Nayar, former CEO of HCL Technologies, on how AI is affecting our sense of self

Saptarshi Basak

By placing 'humans' before 'machines' in the title, what do you want to say about the relationship between people and AI?

Most people think I wrote a book about AI.

I didn't. I wrote a book about people. As machines become more capable, I am asking if human beings will still believe they are capable of extraordinary things? That question stayed with me for years and eventually became the reason I wrote this book. Every conversation I heard was about investing in AI. Almost no conversation was about investing in people. Yet, my four decades in the tech industry has taught me something simple. Technology creates opportunities, but people create breakthroughs.

What prompted you to write this book now? Was there a particular gap in the public conversation about AI that you felt needed to be addressed?

When you spend your time with two crore rural children, you stop thinking only about technology and start thinking about possibilities. Many of these children begin life with every disadvantage imaginable,

yet they dream. They believe that tomorrow can be better than today. That belief is precious because it is often the only thing they truly own. Suddenly, the world was talking as if machines would soon do everything better than humans. I found myself asking what happens if a generation of young people begins to believe that before they have even discovered what they are capable of?

A central idea running through the book is that people should harness AI without surrendering what makes them uniquely human. What, in your view, is the real danger?

I have spent four decades building technology businesses and the last decade working with two crore children in government schools. Those two worlds seem different but they have taught me exactly the same lesson. People don't achieve extraordinary things because they know more. They achieve extraordinary things because they

reconstruction is less a faithful transcript than a dream, one that Thomas himself enters and continues to inhabit, even as his own memory fails.

Thomas is also performing for a recording device that is not there. He insists on checking if the device is working. He understands that, in a culture ruled by what Benjamin called "exhibition value", the act of recording has become more significant than the words being recorded.

Transcription also traces three generations of fathers who, try as they might, cannot communicate with their children and vice-versa. Thomas ships his son Max off to boarding school after his wife took her own life, but as a professor, he adopts and mentors his students as intellectual heirs. Max, the over-wrought modern dad, tries so hard to be present for his daughter Emmie — who is starving because of a food disorder, the only time she

is able to eat is while watching unboxing videos on her iPad. The narrator, also a father of the same generation, seems to swallow his daughter's anxiety as she — unable to cope with a rapidly transitioning world with pandemics, politics and floods — refuses to go to school. He tries to talk to her about his own anxieties, but she is busy making the most of

her screentime on the iPad. The daughters are Kafkan hunger artists in an age of surplus, refuseniks withdrawing from a world that offers too much.

Max tries to talk to his semi-conscious father on what seems to be his deathbed at the height of the pandemic, but whether the words are registered and remembered, nobody can tell. The South Korean-German theorist Byung-Chul Han calls it a "crisis of listening" in our hyperconnected age where we speak constantly but cannot truly hear.

The plot comes to an ironic full circle as Max tries to secretly record his father in the novel's third section, only to find himself half-listening, as he mulls on how his own voice is warped during the performance.

A novel that speaks to our modern age of technology and anxiety, *Transcription* is one of the most dazzling novels of the year, suggesting that the most authentic conversation is the one that lives in the unreliable architecture of memory, where "waking does not end the dream". It won the Orwell Prize and was tipped for the Booker, though Lerner's name was conspicuously absent from the longlist, much to the consternation of many literary critics.



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

BEING NEIGHBOURS
Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Chinese President Xi Jinping

sponse to Indian aggression" and had been "carefully planned." And it sharply "undercuts Indian self-confidence."

In the current scenario of the border standoff, which is most relevant, he says that the era of peaceful coexistence is at an end, and India must therefore prepare for a prolonged period of armed coexistence.

While he assesses that the India of 2025 is not what it was in 1962, "China knows a total victory is not likely."

Gokhale's book argues that China risks potential reputational damage through an open conflict with India and is likely to use more tools of coercion to achieve political goals in future. However, he cautions rightly that there is no circumstance under which large-scale conflict between India and China should be ruled out entirely.

As someone who served in Beijing after Chinese President Xi Jinping assumed office, he makes a case for carefully monitoring internal political developments within the People's Republic of China.

In this context, this line is telling: "It is not uncommon for beleaguered leaders and regimes to deflect public attention from a serious domestic crisis to an external threat but authoritarian regimes such as China are more likely to do so as they

lack legal or popular legitimacy." He cites that the stand-offs in Depsang and Chumar in 2013 and 2014 coincided with the political transition from pre-Xi Jinping era to the Xi era.

In India's case, China adopts what he calls a "fight and talk" strategy, where "grey-zone coercion" (military intimidation, including massing of troops on the border, large-scale land, sea or air exercises or threats of force, employment of paramilitary for law enforcement, manipulation of borders through cartographic aggression) and "negotiations" go hand-in-hand to achieve a favourable outcome. He wisely notes that the "grey-zone warfare" is likely to be adopted against India more frequently in the future.

The book eruditely explains Beijing's strategy but as someone who is deeply aware of the recent crises in Depsang, Demchok, Doklam and Galwan, the book could have been richer if he would have added more insights and granular details from these episodes. Nevertheless, it is an outstanding work for students of Chinese strategy at a time when China's comprehensive national strength and global role has become key to geopolitics and geo-economics.

When the machine falls silent

In Transcription, Ben Lerner looks at the act of keeping record in an age of technology and anxiety

Aishwarya Khosla

DID A conversation never recorded actually take place? Did one really visit a place in the absence of a photograph? With phones, our personal black boxes, recording everything from calories consumed, places visited, screen time to phone numbers, photographs and emails, what happens when the medium fails? And, if we know we are being recorded, is the transcription itself unauthentic in the first place?

Structured as a sonata, Ben Lerner's *Transcription*, opens with the unnamed narrator, a poet and journalist, on a train, seated backwards ("facing the past"), heading to interview his 90-year-old mentor, Thomas, a polymath renowned as one of the foremost thinkers on art and technology. Horror of horrors, his phone falls into

the sink just before the interview and can neither be resuscitated nor replaced. He is unable to confess what has happened, assuring his mentor — who insists that the interview be recorded — that the dead brick between them is whirring away.

Lerner asks: If the medium is the message, does the message survive once the device fails? What is lost when we outsource memory to machines and what is gained when the archive fails? At 144 pages, the novel itself becomes a hand-held device for transmitting a message whose meaning refracts through the unavoidable lens of the interlocutor, distorting what it claims to preserve.

Without his phone, what the French philosopher Bernard Stiegler would call his "tertiary memory" — an external support for consciousness — the narrator drifts through time and space into a phantasma-



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

EPHEMERAL EVIDENCE
Ben Lerner

goric realm where remembering and misremembering, the recorded and the lost, the past and the present collapse into each other.

The cultural theorist, Walter Benjamin, famous for his 1936 essay, *The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction*, writes about the "aura" of the unique artwork, arguing that mechanical reproduction withers presence but Lerner inverts the dialectic, and so, the conversation, never captured, becomes a free-floating ghost. The narrator's



TRANSCRIPTION
BEN LERNER
Granta Books
144 pages
₹1099



A new Netflix series revisits the 1999 Kargil War through the eyes of the young pilots of the Golden Arrows squadron, recreating their missions with help from the Air Force

Alaka Sahani

FOR MOST Indians, the Kargil War is remembered primarily as a story of soldiers fighting on some of the world’s highest battlefields. But the 1999 war was not only fought on the mountains, the skies became another crucial battleground. *Operation Safed Sagar* brings this lesser-known chapter of the war to the screen, telling the story through the Indian Air Force (IAF) and, more specifically, the young pilots of the Golden Arrows squadron.

For actor Jimmy Shergill, who plays former Air Chief Marshal Birender Singh Dhanoa, the story itself came as a revelation. “I always thought that the Kargil War was fought mainly by the Army. I never knew this part of the story in such detail.”

In his university days, actor Siddharth had heard about Squadron Leader Ajay Ahuja, whose character the actor essays in the series, but he did not know much about *Operation Safed Sagar*. So, when he met director Oni Sen and the show’s co-creator Abhijeet Singh Parmar for the first time, he found the story moving and relevant. “I knew it’s always going to be relevant because it’s a story of a nation going to war and we are seeing it through the lens of the Indian Air Force. But when I heard the script, I believed, it could really move young people,” he says.

That sense of discovery and the desire to share the untold Air Force story of Kargil are at the heart of the series.

Created by Parmar and Kushal Srivastava, *Operation Safed Sagar* grew out of latter’s own experience with the Indian Air Force. Srivastava joined the Force in 2000, shortly after the Kargil War, and served for six years. During that period, he came across Ahuja’s story as well as the experiences of the Air Force personnel who had served during the conflict. The idea stayed with Srivastava. In 2018, when he met Air Chief Marshal Dhanoa, he proposed making a series around *Operation Safed Sagar*. Years of research followed before the

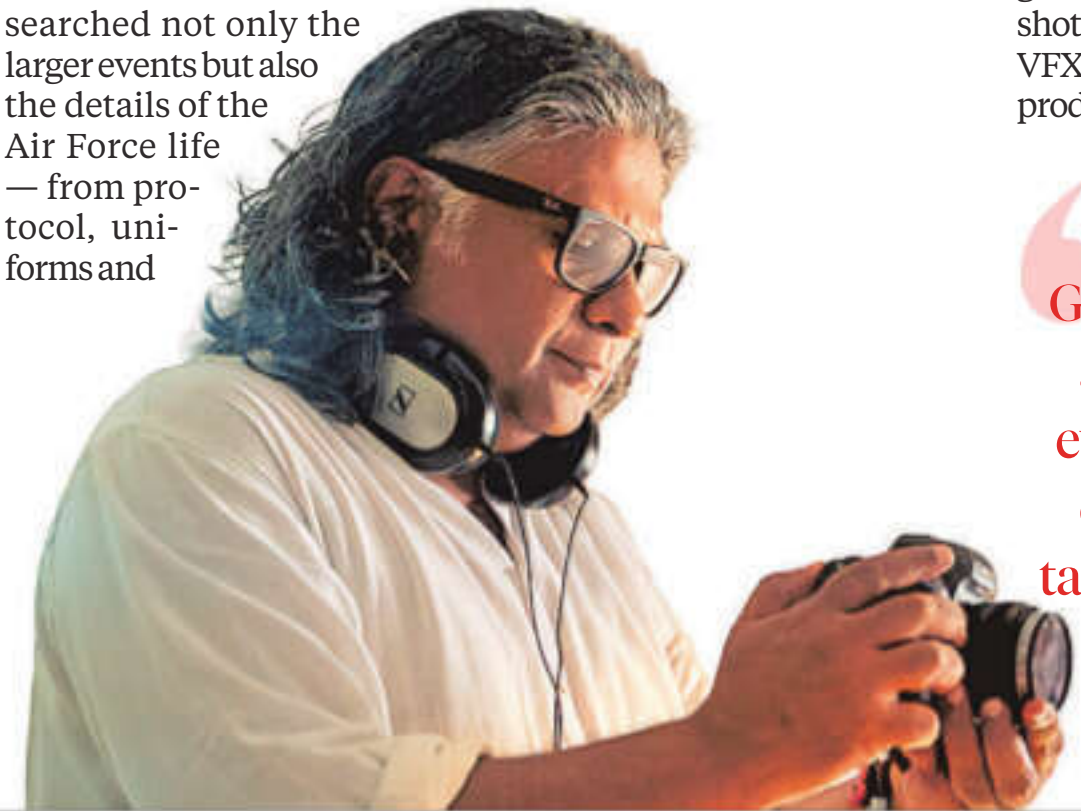


‘TAKING FLIGHT’ (Clockwise from above) A still from *Operation Safed Sagar*; director Oni Sen; co-creator and showrunner Abhijeet Singh Parmar

series was released on Netflix on August 7. It tells the story of *Operation Safed Sagar*, the iconic Indian Air Force mission that was carried out at higher altitudes. The high-stakes drama about the Kargil War also shines a light on the political machinations beyond enemy lines as well as the maverick fighter pilots of the Air Force’s Golden Arrows squadron who put everything at stake to defend the nation.

Detailing the Air Force Life

For Tanya Bami, series head at Netflix India, the scale of the historical event came with an equally large responsibility. Authenticity, she says, was central to the process. The makers researched not only the larger events but also the details of the Air Force life — from protocol, uniforms and



body language to the technicalities of flying. “Consultants were involved from the earliest stages of the story and screenplay, and pilots from the Golden Arrows squadron advised the makers on everything from how the characters walked and talked to how they saluted and interacted with equipment. Consultants were also present on set throughout the shoot,” says Sen.

The series, however, is careful not to present itself as a comprehensive account of the Kargil War. Instead, it focuses on the Air Force’s role in it, particularly the young members of the Golden Arrows squadron. They are introduced as a photo-reconnaissance unit, trained to fly into hostile territory and gather intelligence. But as the war unfolds, their role changes.

“This is not a war series. It is actually about the people in the war,” Bami says. So, instead of creating the spectacle of war, the series devotes its time to presenting the young pilots as they go about their lives, preparing for a conflict they did not know was coming.

Shooting with MiG-21s

The makers were among the last to shoot with MiG-21s before the iconic fighter jets were decommissioned. The production had to accelerate its schedule to ensure the aircraft would still be available. While the ground footage involving the MiGs was shot in real, the flying sequences combined VFX with an elaborate physical setup. The production built a photorealistic cockpit on

a computer-controlled hydraulic platform. Every button, metre, texture and seat was recreated, while the hydraulic system was programmed to replicate the movement of a MiG during flight. “The pilots, who flew the aircraft for us, flew it exactly the way we wanted them to fly. They not only understood the MiGs but also cinema. Some of them decided to take their cameras up on smaller aircraft to shoot aerial views for us,” shares Sen.

For the actors, however, creating an authentic feel posed a physical challenge. Siddharth recalls spending a week sleeping in a G-suit and learning the cockpit console by heart. But knowing the mechanics was very different from actually experiencing the movement of the aircraft. Once inside the hydraulic cockpit, he found himself getting dizzy as the machine replicated the movements of a fighter jet. “You’re controlling it but you have no control over it,” he says.

The actors also had to synchronise their performances with the programmed movements. A line had to be delivered at precisely the right moment before the cockpit banked. A mistake meant starting the sequence all over again. Shergill found the experience equally demanding. Before filming, he spent two days in Chandigarh with Dhanoa, listening to his stories and trying to understand the man behind the character. “He is an intelligent man and could make quick complex calculations,” he says.

Another major challenge for the team was shooting in sub-zero conditions. “The Army sees everything at eye level. The Air Force is everything from above,” says Siddharth. In that sense, *Operation Safed Sagar* offers what Siddharth calls a “bird’s-eye view” of the Kargil War — one that shifts the focus from the familiar images of soldiers on the mountains to the pilots flying above them, preparing to enter a war they never expected.

Twenty-seven years after the Kargil War, the makers hope that the series can add another layer to a story Indians thought they already knew.

Consultants from the Golden Arrows squadron advised the makers on everything from how the characters walked and talked to how they saluted and interacted

ONISEN Director

Devansh Sharma

NOLAN CHOSE India” — declared Universal Pictures as it announced Academy Award-winning filmmaker Christopher Nolan has picked Mumbai as one of the six cities around the world for the global promotional tour of his new adventure fantasy epic *The Odyssey*. When the director, producer Emma Thomas and actors Matt Damon and Tom Holland arrived in the city recently, there were huge signs put up by a fan club right outside the screening venue. This was for the much-anticipated superhero movie *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* that was just three weeks away from release.

“No mask, no Tom Holland” read one of the signs planted by a zealous *Spider-Man* fan club in India. Even Nolan knows that it’s not just him, but the culture of watching movies from around the world that India has been singularly obsessed with. The box-office performance of key Hollywood releases in the country this year is a testament to that. *Spider-Man* scored the highest opening (*Rs 250 crore+*) for a Hollywood film ever in the country. This milestone came only a couple of weeks after *The Odyssey* opened big, and has now become Nolan’s highest grossing film in India, at over *Rs 170 crore*.

“Hollywood has undoubtedly enjoyed one of the strongest years in India but each success has been driven by a different factor,” says Sanjeev Kumar Bijli, Executive Director, PVR INOX Ltd. While *Spider-Man* demonstrated the enduring strength of a global franchise backed by exceptional fan engagement and advance bookings, *The Odyssey* proved that audiences will actively seek out premium formats for filmmakers they deeply admire, he says.

That Golden Ticket

Is the defining story of 2026 Hollywood versus Indian cinema? Industry experts weigh in



Nolan’s longstanding advocacy for IMAX has led the Indian moviegoers to clock in the highest grossing IMAX sales in Indian history with over *Rs 50 crore* and counting. But it was also not only the summer blockbuster tentpoles that brought Hollywood glory in India. Curry Barker’s psychological horror film *Obsession* amassed *Rs 84 crore* in the country despite 38 seconds being cut by the Central Board of Film Certification. Trade analyst Taran Adarsh attributes it to the perpetual money machine that is the

OUTSIDE THE BOX Scenes from *The Odyssey*; *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* (right)

horror genre.

But both exhibitors and trade experts feel the rise in the contribution of Hollywood in the India box office this year doesn’t take away from Indian cinema’s prowess. While there are homegrown blockbusters like *Dhurandhar 2: The Revenge* (*Rs 1,375 crore*) and *Border 2* (*Rs 316 crore*), Adarsh says there have been more hits recently, from *Bhooth Bangla* (*Rs 169 crore*), *Welcome to the Jungle* (*Rs 138 crore*) to *Dhamaal 4* (*Rs 171 crore*). “I don’t think the defining story of



2026 is Hollywood versus Indian cinema. It’s that audiences have become more discerning,” says Bijli. “The films that have succeeded are the ones that gave audiences a compelling reason to step into cinemas.”

“It’s the scale, technology and budgets that gives Hollywood that franchise value and the ability to cultivate markets. Indian cinema is still at a relatively nascent stage when it comes to the kind of money spent,” says film exhibitor Akshaye Rathi.

Akshaye now has his sight set on much-anticipated Hollywood tentpoles peppered across the rest of this year, like Tom Cruise’s *Digger*; Dwayne Johnson’s *Jumanji 4: Open World*; Robert Downey Jr’s *Avengers: Domsday*, and Timothee Chalamet’s *Dune: Part Three*. Bijli affirms. “If there’s one lesson from Hollywood, it’s not about making different films but about building anticipation with greater consistency. The most successful campaigns create a clear proposition months before release, giving audiences a compelling reason to watch a film in theatres from the very first trailer.”

Making their Voices Count

Sharkhand filmmakers are documenting their tradition as means of preserving a digital archive of their lived culture



FOUND IN TRANSLATION

Angen, which won in Best Debut Film of a Director category, is the first Santhali film to win a national award

Shriya Murmu

WHEN A thought comes to my mind, it is in Santhali. If I am thinking of shooting in the backyard, it would resemble my home, not a Japanese garden,” says Ravi Raj Murmu, a 33-year-old Santhal filmmaker from Jharkhand who recently won the Best Debut Film of a Director award at the 72nd National Film Awards.

His 12-minute Santhali short film, *Angen* (2024), which loosely translates as invisible, unseen or vanished, is the first Santhali film to win a national award and only the second fiction film made in an Adivasi language to be recognised.

Adapted from a Santhali folktale, *Angen* follows Sukku, a flute player whose music enchants a goddess living in the spirit world. Drawn into her realm through water, a portal between the human and spiritual worlds, Sukku later realises he no longer belongs there and begins searching for his village. Through metaphor, the film shows how, as urbanisation expands, forests disappear, natural spaces shrink, and even spiritual spaces begin to vanish.

Storytelling is one such art where it matters who is telling the story. Santhal stories have often been written only in Santhali. Sometimes, the works may have found mention in Bengali or Hindi or Oriya.

“Our greatest challenge is not the lack of stories but the lack of opportunities to narrate our own reality. For decades, the little that we have been represented has been distorted stereotypes and external perspectives,” says Santhal filmmaker Shristy Marandi. “Filmmaking is a medium through which communities can exercise agency over the representation and preservation of their own cultural histories,” she adds.

Her documentary *Palimpsest* (2025) received a Special Jury Mention at the 8th National Short Film Competition during Samvaad 2025 in Jamshedpur. It documents Dasai, a Santhal festival that unfolds alongside West Bengal’s Durga Puja season. The 43-minute film layers memory and ritual through hypnotic dances of Santhal men adorned as women, the rhythmic pulse of drums and trance-like invocations of ancestral spirits, the Bongas. As elders recall forgotten origins and youth question its relevance, the film becomes both a mirror and elegy — a meditation on what it means to remember, reinvent and reclaim a culture standing at the crossroads of tradition and modernity.

“By documenting Dasai and the cultural practices surrounding it, I wanted to create an accessible visual archive and used as a starting point for further research and inter-generational learning,” says Marandi.

The connection between memory and lived experience is central to cinema produced by many Adivasi filmmakers. One such example is Oraon filmmaker Biju Toppo. He is among the first Adivasi filmmakers to use the camera to counter the community’s

When a thought comes to my mind, it is in Santhali. If I am thinking of shooting in the backyard, it would resemble my home, not a Japanese garden

RAVI RAJ MURMU

Santhali filmmaker; Director of *Angen*

misrepresentation in the mainstream media. For the new generation of Adivasi filmmakers to run, experienced ones like Toppo had to walk.

Toppo graduated in 1994 and co-founded Akhra, a Ranchi-based production house documenting the lives and struggles of Adivasis, with filmmaker-activist Meghnath in 1996. The only formal visual training he received was a 15-day filmmaking course at Patna’s Notre Dame Communication Centre in 1995. “I realised there is power in the camera; there is power in storytelling,” he says.

His landmark documentary *Shaheed Jo Anjaan Rahe* (1996) focused on the 1985 massacre of 14 tribals, including former MP and activist Father Antony Murmu, in Jharkhand’s Sahibganj district. He has since won three National Film Awards for documentaries — *Iron is Hot* (2007), *Ek Ropa Dhan* (2010) and *Naachi se Baanchi* (2017).

“I was a student when the Netarhat Andolan (tribal resistance movement) began in the early 1990s. The Jharkhand Andolan was at its peak. The ‘*Jal, Jangal, Jameen*’ (water, forest, land) chants never left the space. Gradually, I understood what’s happening. I understood whose story I will tell when I pick up a camera. I started documenting displacement, environmental pollution and exploitation of Adivasis,” says Toppo. He is currently working on a film based on a concept by Kurukh writer Mahadev Toppo that explores the intersection of film, literature and art.

Nandini Tank, assistant professor in the Department of English and Cultural Studies at Christ University, Bengaluru, talks about the challenges that come with translation and oral histories among tribal communities. “The stories passed down orally are not simply repeated word for word; they are remembered, interpreted and retold by each storyteller. Oral narratives from tribals present a unique challenge: because they depend entirely on generational memory,” she says.

“As researchers, we have traditionally relied on British archives, elite historical records and non-tribal ethnographies to understand tribal cultures in India,” she adds.

It is, therefore, important that films such as *Angen*, *Palimpsest* and *Naachi Se Baanchi* serve as digital archives.

Days after
mountaineer Nirmal
Purja's death in an
avalanche, we revisit
a 2024 conversation

Heena Khandelwal

NIRMAL PURJA had built an extraordinary life long before he ever set foot on a mountain. Born into a humble family in Nepal, Purja had once recalled growing up without even being able to afford a pair of flip-flops. He joined the Brigade of Gurkhas in 2003 and, six years later, was accepted into the Royal Navy's Special Boat Service, reportedly becoming the first Gurkha to join the elite British unit. Then came the mountains. He climbed all 14 of the world's eight-thousanders — peaks rising above 8,000 metres — in six months and six days. He became the first person to summit Mount Everest, Lhotse and Makalu within 48 hours. In 2021, he was part of the 10-member all-Nepali team that completed the first winter ascent of K2.

Purja, 43, died last week when an avalanche swept him and nine fellow climbers and guides down Broad Peak, the 8,051-metre mountain in Pakistan's Karakoram range.

Journey that began
with a question

When *The Indian Express* met Purja in Kathmandu in October 2024, he spoke of how his mountaineering journey began with a question. "Every time I told people in the UK that I am from Nepal, they would ask, 'Have you climbed it? Have you seen it?'" "It" was Mount Everest. At first, Purja would simply say 'no'. But after about half-a-dozen people had asked him the same question, he began to feel he should at least see the mountain for himself. "So, in 2012, during my Christmas holiday, I booked a flight to Nepal with one purpose: to trek to the Everest Base Camp," he said.

As he trekked through the Himalayas and looked up at the mountains, another question began to take hold: What could I see from the top? He eventually climbed



ON A HIGH
Nirmal Purja; (top)
a scene from the
documentary *14
Peaks: Nothing Is
Impossible*

Lobuche East, a peak rising more than 6,000 metres above sea level. "My whole perception started to change," he said, "I felt more alive on the big mountains."

Turning the clock back

The *Indian Express* spoke to Purja at the height of his fame. Returning to his words now offers a glimpse not only of the climber the world admired but also of the ideas that drove him.

After his first expedition in 2012, Purja shared that he returned to the Special Forces and requested a transfer to the mountain troop, which specialised in extreme cold-weather warfare. "I started diving into that and, at one point, became an instructor before I left my career," he said.

Then, in 2018, he decided to attempt something that sounded almost impossible: climb all 14 eight-thousanders in less than seven months. Purja had no social media following, little public recognition and no wealthy backers. When he pitched the idea to potential sponsors, they compared it to swimming to the moon.

"I remortgaged my house and put the money towards (climbing) the first three mountains," he said. "I told my wife and family: If someone like me, a Gurkha, is scared to do this, what about normal people?

Even if I fail, I have a tent, I have food from the Army for a week. After a week, I will find a job. We don't have to worry," he did not fail.

Project Possible was completed on October 29, 2019, in six months and six days, smashing the previous record by more than seven years. The feat was later documented in the Netflix film *14 Peaks: Nothing Is Impossible* (2021), and his book, *Beyond Possible* (2020).

In 2024, Purja faced sexual harassment allegations that he denied. His relentless chase for records too drew criticism from some quarters but Purja maintained it was never only about setting a record. "What I realised was that Sherpas were the pioneers of 8,000-metre climbing, but their names weren't recognised enough. I wanted to put them on the global platform, so I came up with a project nobody could imagine."

For Purja, the success of Project Possible was also proof that people from modest backgrounds could imagine extraordinary lives. "I truly believed in the vision: to raise the name of Nepalese climbers and, in parallel, to show the world that nothing is impossible," he said, "Look at me today — I had no rich parents, no connections, nothing. When someone from a really poor street looks at me, they can dream too. They can dream that they can be that guy, that

they can do better."

Purja believed Project Possible had also transformed opportunities for Nepalese climbers. Before the project, he said, many Sherpas earned little and had work only during a limited climbing season. As interest in records and expeditions grew, more climbers began arriving in Nepal, creating better-paying opportunities for guides and support staff.

"Being the first to do something is a ground-breaking evolution, not just a record," he said. "Records can always be broken, but being the first to show a concept, a vision, benefits the whole industry and community. I think I managed to open the door for everybody."

He also worried about the future of mountain labour. The Sherpa community, he said, remained small, while younger generations were increasingly choosing different careers. "The fathers work so hard to send their kids to school, and those kids aren't going to carry 40 kg loads for the pay porters get," he said. "The government and the industry need to start protecting them."

That concern led him to build a porterhouse in Lobuche, near the Everest Base Camp route. Previously, he said, porters carrying supplies from Pheriche to Lobuche had nowhere to stay and were forced to re-

CONCERN FOR
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turn to Pheriche at night before beginning the journey again the next morning.

"What I believe in is helping the helpless," he said. "Fifteen years ago, even if I had worked day and night, I couldn't have done this. But now I have that opportunity, so why should I stop?"

Through his NGO, Nimsdai Foundation, Purja said he contributed five per cent of his earnings — from guiding, clothing, skydiving, speaking engagements and books — to community work. The foundation had supported people affected by floods in Pakistan, built homes and helped vulnerable families. His belief in collective achievement was most visible during the first winter ascent of K2 on January 16, 2021. The mountain was the last of the world's 14 eight-thousanders to remain unclimbed in winter. "The other 13 had all been climbed by Western climbers," Purja said. "I felt we needed one title for the country and the Sherpas."

Although he led the expedition, he wanted all 10 Nepalese climbers to reach the summit together. "When you share equal glory and equal success, happiness multiplies," he said. "I wanted to show the world the power of unity. When we summited K2 in winter, honestly, I wasn't focused on the view. It was the energy I felt from my friends, doing it together."

Even away from the mountains, Purja remained driven. He spoke of waking up at 3.30 am and finishing much of his work before his staff arrived at 8 am. He worked for 11 months a year and turned to skydiving and paragliding when he needed to clear his mind. But becoming a father had changed his relationship with risk. "I definitely take a bit less risk than before; I used to just go full-on," he said. "Now I think about what happens given that I have a daughter, so I'm more conscious of it." His daughter was two-and-a-half when we met him. He spoke of wanting to introduce her to skiing and paragliding, once she was older.

A loss mourned globally

He believed humanity had much to learn from nature, particularly in an era of climate crisis. "No matter how powerful you are, you cannot fight nature," he said. "If we don't listen, nature will teach us the lesson." Purja's death, along with that of nine fellow climbers and guides, has been mourned from Kathmandu to London and across the mountaineering world. For a man who spent much of his life insisting that no mountain was impossible, the ending feels painfully literal.



Neil Patil
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I was on the window seat last week, flying into Srinagar, and I was just in awe. The plane had crossed the Pir Panjal range and was descending into the Kashmir Valley, and there it was, an entire geography laid out like something from a film that hasn't been made yet. Snow on the high ridges even in August, green valleys so vivid they looked like they'd been colour-corrected, the Jhelum River threading through the floor of the valley like a silver nerve, and then Dal Lake appearing in the distance, flat and still, with Srinagar arranged around it like someone had placed a city there very carefully.

And here's the thing that makes this view even more unusual: you can't capture it. Photography and videography are prohibited below 10,000 feet on the Srinagar approach and at the airport itself. Security reasons. Which means this is one of the last great travel views on earth that you can only experience with your eyes. No Instagram reel, no phone pressed against the glass, no proof for anyone else. Just you and the window and a valley that looks like it was designed to be seen exactly this way, from above, in silence, with nothing to do but look.

I've flown into cities all over the world. I've seen the approach into New York, the descent into Hong Kong, the first glimpse of Sydney Harbour from the air. And I'll say this without hesitation: the approach into Srinagar, on a clear day, from the right seat, is as good as any of them. Maybe better, because you can't hide behind a camera. You have to actually be there for it.

That flight got me thinking about something we don't talk about enough. India, seen from 35,000 feet, is one of the most visually spectacular countries on earth. And most of us fly over it with the window shade down, watching a film we have already seen, completely unaware of what's happening on the other side of that plastic panel.

The India You Fly Over

The Valley That Appears

Let me stay with Srinagar for a moment, because it deserves more than a passing mention. The Mumbai-Srinagar flight is about 3 hours. For the first two, you're over the Indo-Gangetic plain, flat, agricultural, unremarkable from the air. Then the Shivalik foothills begin, and the terrain starts folding. Within minutes, you are over the Pir Panjal range, and the landscape transforms entirely. Brown rock, white snow, deep gorges, and the kind of scale that makes you understand why the Himalayas have their own mythology.

And then, the valley. The Kashmir Valley doesn't reveal itself gradually. It appears. One moment you are looking at mountains, and the next there's a perfectly flat, impossibly green floor between the ranges, and the plane is dropping towards it. On a clear morning, the light catches the rice paddies and the whole valley glows. Dal Lake comes into view, and you can see the shikaras as tiny dark lines on the water. It looks like a painting you'd dismiss as unrealistic if you saw it in a gallery. The seat you want is A, the left side going north. That's where the Pir Panjal view lives.

Where the Earth Stops Pretending

If Srinagar is beautiful, Leh is otherworldly. Kushok Bakula Rimpochee Airport in Leh sits at 3,256 metres, over 10,600 feet, making it one of the highest commercial airports in the world. The approach is so technically demanding that flights can only land in the morning, when wind conditions are calm and visibility is clear. If the weather doesn't cooperate, your flight doesn't go.

But when it does go, and you are on the right side of the plane, what you see is staggering. The flight from Delhi crosses the Shivaliks, then the Pir Panjal, then the Great Himalayan range itself, and then drops into the Trans-Himalayan landscape of Ladakh. A completely different planet. Brown and ochre mountains scored with deep wrinkles, the Indus River glinting far below, snow-capped peaks of the Zaskar and Karakoram ranges in the distance, and not a single tree anywhere. The landscape looks like Mars with better lighting.

Passengers on this flight consistently describe it as the most spectacular domestic flight in India. I would go further. It's one of the most spectacular short-haul flights anywhere in the



world. An hour and a half from Delhi, and you're landing in a valley surrounded by mountains so bare and ancient they make the Himalayas look young. Left side going to Leh. Don't sleep.

Where the Ocean Changes Colour

Now go the other direction entirely. Chennai or Kolkata to Port Blair is a two-hour flight over the Bay of Bengal, and for most of it, you see nothing but grey-blue water. It's easy to zone out, put on headphones, close the shade. Don't.

About twenty minutes before landing, the Andaman archipelago appears below you, and the colour of the ocean shifts. It goes from deep navy to turquoise to pale green in bands so distinct they look like someone drew lines on the water. The islands emerge as dark green shapes rimmed with white sand, surrounded by coral reefs visible from cruising altitude. It's the moment you realise the Andamans are closer to Thailand than to mainland India, and that they look like it.

The final descent into Port Blair takes you over tiny islands you'll never visit, each one fringed with beaches that could be on a postcard. The runway at Veer Savarkar Airport is lined with teak forest on one side and turquoise water

on the other. You land feeling like you have already had the first experience of your holiday before the wheels have touched the ground.

The City That Glitters

Mumbai doesn't have mountains or turquoise water. What Mumbai has is drama, from the air, at night, and in broad daylight.

On a night approach, coming in from the north or east, the first thing you see is a vast darkness, the coast, the sea, and then, suddenly, a carpet of light. Mumbai from the air at night is endless. It stretches in every direction, orange and white and flickering, and it doesn't seem to stop. You can pick out the curve of Marine Drive, the Queen's Necklace, as a string of amber lights tracing the shoreline. You can see the Bandra-Worli Sea Link as a lit thread across dark water. On a clear night, you can make out the difference between South Mumbai's dense glow and the sparser lights of the northern suburbs.

But the view I want to talk about is the one on takeoff. If you are flying out of Mumbai and you are sitting on the left side, look down as the plane climbs and banks over the Arabian Sea. What you will see is the entire western edge

of Mumbai stitching itself together. The Sea Link sweeping across Mahim Bay, and then, the Coastal Road crawling along the shoreline, connecting Worli to Marine Drive in a ribbon of concrete and tarmac that didn't exist a few years ago. From the air, you can see the full ambition of it: the reclaimed land, the tunnels disappearing into the hillside at Malabar Hill, and the way the new road draws a continuous line from Bandra all the way down to the southern tip of the city. It's Mumbai rewriting its own coastline in real time, and the only place you can see the full picture is from the window of a departing flight.

I have flown out of Mumbai hundreds of times, and I still lean into the window. Our city pulls you in even as you leave it.

The Flights Nobody Talks About

These are the headline approaches, the ones any frequent flyer will nod at. But India has dozens of routes where the window seat tells a story most passengers miss, and half the trick of good travel is learning to look down before you land.

Bagdogra, the gateway to Darjeeling and Sikkim, where on a clear day Kanchenjunga, the third highest mountain on earth, fills the entire horizon as you descend. It's not in the distance. It's right there, massive and white, closer than you expect a mountain that size to be. Most passengers are busy collecting their bags, and they miss the ten seconds when the clouds part and the whole Himalayan wall rises up beside the aircraft.

Mumbai to Goa, where the Western Ghats drop sharply to the Konkan coast and you can see the transition from mountain to plateau to coastline to beach in a single glance. Flown low on a small aircraft, the same stretch gives you a geology lesson in forty-five minutes: green hills give way to laterite plateaus, the plateaus break into river valleys, and then the land simply ends in a ribbon of white sand.

Dibrugarh in Assam, where the Brahmaputra stretches so wide from the air that it looks less like a river and more like a moving sea, with sandbars and islands that shift with every monsoon. Fly this route twice in a year and you may not recognize the river below you the second time.

Jodhpur, where the Blue City earns its name from the air. The old city shimmers in shades of blue and white,

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compressed inside the walls of Mehrangarh Fort, looking like someone spilled paint on the desert. Rooftops and courtyards form a cool blue puzzle against the tan of the Thar.

And Udaipur, where the lakes, Pichola, Fateh Sagar, Swaroop Sagar, appear as jewels in the brown Aravallis, the white palaces on their shores visible even from cruising altitude, a reminder that this is a city built as much around water as around stone.

My Argument for the Window Seat

Here's what I keep coming back to. Travellers will pay two lakhs for a Switzerland trip to see mountains, four lakhs for New Zealand to see landscapes, and eight lakhs for Iceland to see dramatic geology. And then they will fly over the Pir Panjal range, or the Western Ghats, or the Brahmaputra delta, with the shade down.

India's geography, seen from the air, is absurdly varied. In a country this size, you can fly over snow-capped Himalayan peaks, desert cities, volcanic islands, tropical coastlines, river deltas, and dense forest, all on domestic routes, all for the price of a two-hour flight.

The window seat isn't just a seat preference. On the right Indian route, on the right day, it's the first, and sometimes the best, experience of the destination.

So the next time you book a flight, pick the window. Know which side to sit on. And keep the shade up. You are already flying over one of the most beautiful countries in the world. You might as well look. See you next week...

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